

INNOVATIONS IN EFL TEACHING, LEARNING AND ASSESSMENT:

**on the Threshold of the University
of Concepción's Centennial**

Editores

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**Universidad
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Facultad de
EDUCACIÓN
UNIVERSIDAD DE CONCEPCIÓN



Magíster en Innovación de la Enseñanza, Aprendizaje y Evaluación del Inglés
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On the Threshold of the University of Concepción's Centennial
Claudio Díaz, Caterin Díaz, Cristián Sanhueza (editores)
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Universidad de Concepción

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PROLOGUE

Researching into English teaching, learning and assessing in Chile has always been an overwhelming endeavor. For some reason, teachers of English from either the school system or tertiary education, have been immersed in a great deal of classroom teaching hours that very often leave little room for researching or publishing. This may be clearly a disadvantage for the enhancement of metacognition and reflection as two essential skills for teacher development. Likewise, researching and publishing have sometimes developed a grounded stigma of two activities that are distant from classroom reality and teaching practice. Both are usually described as theory-based and alien-like with no impact in what in-service teachers of English have to face in their jobs and inside the classroom.

The explanation for this has generally been that university training is just theory that can not be applied anywhere and schools are just practice that reflects what really happens there. Both assumptions are probably half true, because theory nurtures practice and practice nurtures theory, so there should be a bidirectional relationship that we all have certainly been unable to build.

This book constitutes an initial effort to help build this necessary relationship between practice and theory as two constructs that are tightly intertwined. The book originates from some of the action research studies conducted by in-service teachers from the *Master in Innovation of Teaching, Learning and Assessment* at the University of Concepción. These in-service teachers of English who are enrolled in this master program certainly want to provoke a deep change in their teaching practices and students' learning. Action research as its name suggests implies that research practitioners (real language teachers) identify teaching or learning problems of their daily professional life, think of a plan of action to intervene their teaching practices, assess the impact of their own pedagogical interventions, and repeat the research cycle again, if necessary, as a continuous process of reflection and improvement.

It is also a book that is enriched by the contributions of other national and international researchers that have conducted empirical or reflective studies that center on students' language learning from cognitive, affective and social perspectives and on the value of quality research as a tool to enhance language education.

It is in the hope of this book to start viewing language teachers as education professionals who do not only diagnose, describe problems or teach the language automatically as a result of professional experience, but as agents of change who are able to reflect and intervene their practices, and find ways to suggest changes based on their own students and educational contexts. This book attempts to provide some elementary tools to support the building of a community of professionals who can enrich themselves from their own teaching experiences, reflections and assessments. It is additionally a book written by in-service teachers of English to their fellow colleagues who work at primary, secondary and tertiary education. This text is besides concrete evidence that applied research must and can be published and shared to help others start their own journey to become a reflective practitioner.

I finally invite all of our readers to take advantage of the ideas and experiences that are shared in each one of the chapters, not as unbroken truths, but as thought-provoking insights that can trigger their own process of change and creativity. My final words go to thank Professors Caterin Díaz and Cristián Sanhueza for their hard work and invaluable collaboration to make this publication possible.

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INTRODUCTION

Teaching English as a second language is not an easy task, especially when the learners do not have plenty of opportunities of exposure to the target language, as it happens in the Chilean educational context. This poses a considerable challenge for teachers, who need to provide their students with plenty of opportunities to use the language in the classroom. Moreover, these opportunities can be limited sometimes, due to certain factors like the number of hours of English classes, the number of students in the classroom and also learners' intrinsic motivation. Consequently, teachers of English need to be constantly seeking for new techniques and approaches to language teaching, not only based on the students' linguistic needs and the teaching conditions, but also on the fast-paced development of society and technology.

Innovation is a key factor in the teaching process, since present-day learners are quite different from the learners of previous decades. Throughout the years, several different approaches to language teaching have been developed, from the grammar-translation method in the 18th century to nowadays communicative approach. Each of these methods has evolved, adding new features according to the context in which it is used and the students' needs, which change over time. Thus, materials, resources and teaching techniques need to be updated. In this endeavour, teachers do not stick to only teaching, but also to researching and studying, in order to improve the quality of language education. Furthermore, teaching is not static; as long as society changes, teaching techniques and methods will need to be renovated.

The University of Concepción is one of the third oldest universities in Chile, and one of the 25 members of the Council of Rectors. It was founded in 1919, as a regional initiative, and it started functioning with 123 students and only a few programmes, such as Chemistry, Pharmacy, Dentistry, and English Language Teaching. Nowadays, the University offers 91 undergraduate programmes and 102 postgraduate programmes. Education was one of the main concerns of the founders, Enrique Molina Garmendia and Virginio Gómez, and it remains one of the main focal points for the University, which nowadays offers 14 different programmes related to teaching and education.

As a means of celebrating the University of Concepción's centennial, the Innovation in Teaching, Learning and Assessment of the English Language Master's programme of the Faculty of Education has gathered a number of

articles written by different experts in English Language Teaching and TEFL in-service teachers, both from Chile and abroad. Consequently, the book “Innovations in Teaching, Learning and Assessment of the English Language: On the Threshold of the University of Concepción’s Centennial” arises. Each of the chapters in this book is a reflection on the authors’ teaching practice or a product of the authors’ research in different fields of language teaching. These constitute attempts to give the reader some insight on the many ways in which innovation can be facilitated in the classroom or the benefit of the learning process.

“Innovations in Teaching, Learning and Assessment of the English Language: On the Threshold of the University of Concepción’s Centennial” consists of eleven chapters, which describe a wide range of topics and research related to language teaching and how to implement innovative methods and approaches in the classroom, with the purpose of enhancing the learning process for both students and teachers. The array of themes covered in the book goes from the development of soft skills to communicative competence proficiency, as well as instruction giving, educational research, methods and approaches, assessment and technology use. Each of the chapters illustrates how innovation can be fostered in multiple areas of English language teaching and learning, and the benefits it brings to all the actors involved in the learning process.

There are several ways in which teacher educators and educators in general can innovate and improve their teaching practices. One of them is focusing on different aspects of learning and seeing beyond content, by developing soft skills in the students. In their book chapter “Learners’ perceptions on the implementation of an English listening strategy program”, Javiera Boudon and Yasna Pereira propose a strategy to develop listening skills by using one of the most popular online platforms: YouTube.

Likewise, in the chapter named “The effects of telecollaboration on ELLs’ motivation and intercultural competence: A pilot project”, Ester Quiroz, Karis Hanson and Sarah Shaw describe their experience implementing a telecollaboration project between Chilean and American university students. This inventive study portrays the experiences of the research practitioners, as well as the students’, who expressed how this type of methodology helped improve not only their motivation, but also their learning.

The speaking skill is one of the most complex skills to develop in students, especially when the number of students in the classroom is considerable. In the chapter named “Raising awareness in the conversation classroom through drama clips - a case study” written by María Moreno, movie clips are used with the purpose of developing conversation skills. The author describes

the positive effect that movie clips have on students, since they not only present examples of natural conversation, but also include interesting topics which motivate students to speak.

One of the essential tools in innovation in language teaching is the use of technology and online platforms, with the purpose of promoting second language use. There are several platforms that can be used for this ambition, such as Facebook, Instagram, Snapchat, etc. In their chapter, “Online communities for English language teaching and learning: Pre-service teachers’ experiences in the virtual world of Second Life”, Jaime García and Sandra Morales describe a study carried out with pre-service teachers of English and the online community “Second Life”. In this chapter, they explain how the use of an online community could improve the students’ level of English, as well as raising their awareness about the benefits of the use of technology in the classroom.

Instruction giving is another area in which there is room for innovation. An example of this is presented by Gemalli Ulloa and Claudio Díaz, in their chapter “Reflecting on the role of instructions, modelling and visuals on young learners’ comprehension”. The authors describe a pedagogical experience in which a combination of instructions, visuals and modelling was used in a class for young learners. As the authors explain, the mentioned combination proved to be an efficient model for giving instructions, since visual aids can enable the students to gain a deeper understanding of the instructions, even when they may lack the linguistic knowledge to perform the tasks requested by their teachers.

As classroom practices change, assessment evolves accordingly. It is essential to keep coherence between the way language is taught and the way it is assessed, as previously mentioned. Therefore, Cristián Sanhueza and Marco Ugarte address the assessment of one of the most controversial areas in language teaching and learning; pronunciation. The chapter named “Issues in teaching English pronunciation to pre-service teachers in Chile”, discusses certain aspects of pronunciation which have been subject to debate, such as the extent to which the pronunciation of a pre-service teacher needs to resemble the one of an English native speaker. Moreover, the authors discuss certain factors that influence the speakers’ pronunciation, such as identity, age and cognitive development.

Educational research has also been subject to innovation. Traditionally, criteria such as reliability, validity, objectivity and generalizability have been used to assess integrity in all kinds of research. However, these criteria may not be the most suitable ones for educational sciences. Nonetheless, in the chapter named “Validity, trustworthiness and integrity in educational research”, Patrio Pino discusses those criteria, and the underlying research paradigms that

support them. Moreover, the author revises the concept of trustworthiness and proposes some criteria to analyse it in critical inquiries.

Methods, approaches, and strategies for language teaching are constantly evolving. The chapter called “New expressions on familiar faces: Using a fusion of known methods to facilitate lexical acquisition in the EFL classroom”, written by Jenny Faber, describes how language teaching approaches, rather than being mutually exclusive, may be implemented together in the language classroom. By doing so, it is possible to create and maintain an immersion environment in which students can feel safe to experiment with language and, therefore, get meaningful knowledge and develop their communicative competence.

“Exploring the implementation of affective practices in a context of Critical Literacy Pedagogy: The use of movie scenes to increase students’ empathy levels in the EFL/ESL classroom” describes the steps to implement affective literacy practices based on the use of movie scenes in the EFL/ESL classroom. The aim of the chapter, written by Elena Dominguez and Jelena Bobkina, is to provide teachers with a methodology to improve students’ levels of empathy towards language, through the use of movie trailers.

Similarly, in the chapter named “Grammar approaches to the EFL classroom” Caterin Díaz discusses different methods for grammar teaching and how those methods can have different learning outcomes. The author also emphasizes that the approach to grammar teaching a teacher uses needs to be consistent with the type of assessment carried out for the students.

Macarena Yacomán and Claudio Díaz in their chapter “Willingness to communicate when speaking English” reflect on how learners’ classroom interaction and their desire to speak in a foreign language can help their learning processes.

Finally, it is important to mention that this book seeks to be of help to any educator or teacher educator who aspires to innovate and try new methodologies and techniques in the classroom, in order to improve and enhance their students’ learning experience. We encourage teachers to test the methodologies and models described in the chapters of this book in their own classrooms, and, what is more, we encourage teachers to keep researching, designing and implementing their own models in order to cover all areas in education. It is essential to remember that teachers are role models, responsible for more than academic enrichment. Regarding this, innovation is a key factor, which can help teachers and students to have significant learning experiences, by creating motivating and meaningful activities and tasks, as well as incorporating new components to the lessons.

SECTION 1:
RESEARCH REPORTS

LEARNERS' PERCEPTIONS ON THE IMPLEMENTATION OF AN ENGLISH LISTENING STRATEGY PROGRAM

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Abstract

The aim of this study is to explore the effect that teaching pre-listening and while-listening strategies and using a bilingual YouTube channel as a source of oral input has on the development of the listening for specific information subskill of an adult English as a Foreign Language (EFL) class. Participants were 16 university students from an A1+ class in Concepción, Chile. They were given explicit teaching of a set of pre and while-listening for specific information strategies, which were used when working with a bilingual YouTube channel. The effect of the tools chosen for the development of the listening for specific information subskill was assessed by a focus group session. Results show that the participants' subskill improved after four sessions. Additionally, the participants expressed that the combination of both, the YouTube videos and the strategies learned were beneficial to their subskill development.

Keywords: listening skill, listening strategies, subskills, YouTube, listening input

Resumen

El objetivo de este estudio es explorar el efecto que tienen la enseñanza de estrategias antes y durante la comprensión auditiva, y el uso de un canal bilingüe de YouTube como fuente discursiva oral, en el desarrollo de la habilidad de comprensión auditiva en información específica en una clase de inglés como lengua extranjera (EFL) para adultos. Los sujetos de este estudio fueron 16 estudiantes universitarios con nivel A1+ de inglés en Concepción, Chile. Los sujetos fueron instruidos explícitamente en un conjunto de estrategias de *pre-listening* y *while-listening*, que se utilizaron al trabajar con un canal de YouTube bilingüe. Se midió el efecto de las herramientas elegidas para el desarrollo de la habilidad específica de *listening for specific information* con un grupo focal. Los resultados muestran que los sujetos mejoraron la habilidad específica después de cuatro sesiones. Además, los sujetos expresaron que la combinación de ambos, los videos de YouTube y las estrategias aprendidas fueron beneficiosas para el desarrollo de la habilidad específica aprendida.

Palabras clave: comprensión auditiva, estrategias de comprensión auditiva, habilidades específicas, YouTube, input auditivo

INTRODUCTION

From the current point of view of most Chilean universities (Vicerrectoría Académica Universidad del Bío Bío, 2008; Dirección de Docencia Universidad de Concepción, 2011), it is expected that students are able to communicate in a foreign language before obtaining their degrees. However, when students enter their first General English course, even though some of them are somewhat proficient in written comprehension and production for their level, a lack of development of the oral components of the language (listening and speaking) can be observed.

As a way to explore new methods to develop listening comprehension in learners, an action research study was conducted to assess the effect of teaching pre-listening and while-listening strategies when using a bilingual YouTube channel as a source of oral input for the development of the listening for specific information subskill in an adult EFL class in Chile. In this chapter, the participants' perceptions of their own listening comprehension improvement after a four-session intervention will be reported.

The aims of this study are the following:

- To identify the participants' perceptions about having worked with pre-listening and while-listening strategies to develop their listening for specific information subskill development.

- To identify the participants' perceptions about using a bilingual YouTube channel as a source of oral input to develop their listening for specific information subskill.

LITERATURE REVIEW

What are listening strategies and subskills?

Listening strategies can be understood as techniques, actions, or steps intended to contribute directly to the comprehension of oral input. Chamot (2004:14) describes learning strategies as “the conscious thoughts and actions that learners take in order to achieve a learning goal”. Although, in general, people successfully utilize listening strategies every day for communication in their L1, those strategies do not transfer automatically to the L2. Some learners possess natural abilities to discover and manage listening strategies in their L2. However, most learners need to be taught strategies explicitly in order to obtain good results in their L2 acquisition and successful academic results. According to Mendelsohn (1994), the instruction of strategies is a process which is as explicit and direct as possible at the beginning, moving to a stage in which the teacher provides the input and the students apply the learned strategies in an autonomous way.

Learners need to master several abilities and strategies before saying they are, for example, proficient in listening comprehension. Some authors (Harmer, 2010; Scrivener, 2011; Wilson 2008) divide them into “subskills”, implying how general or specific they are inside their own classifications. Examples of listening subskills are: listening for gist, listening for specific information, and listening in detail.

How are listening strategies classified?

Listening strategies are mainly divided in two ways. The first model to divide listening strategies is the taxonomy of cognitive, metacognitive and socio-affective strategies (O'Malley & Chamot, 1990; Vandergrift, 1996; 1997; 2003; Goh, 2002; Kondo & Yang, 2004) which identifies what processes occur when a learner uses certain strategies, and which strategies are needed in a given context, depending on the situational needs and the characteristics of the learners.

The second classification is concerned with the time in which they are used, before, during, or after the listening activity. This occurs in the same manner in which a typical listening comprehension sequence is arranged: pre-listening, while-listening, and post-listening. According to Richards (2005), in the pre-listening stage, we will find strategies which deal mainly with predic-

tions, anticipation and prior knowledge. The while-listening stage will include strategies such as selective listening, gist and sequencing, among others. Finally, the post-listening stage involves responding to the comprehension.

YouTube as a source of authentic input

In July, 2017, YouTube was the third most-visited website (Donchev, 2017). These numbers are increasing day by day and are impossible to ignore when looking for modern, engaging, and most importantly, authentic materials for our EFL class. YouTube was considered an ideal tool for EFL learning a few years ago, even when it was not yet so popular as today. McDonough, Shaw & Masuhara (2013) present this site at the top of the list of the most appealing materials to be used as a source of input, but also as a way to produce content. YouTube can be very flexible and easy to use in day-to-day EFL lessons. Any content, part of the language, topic, register or accent can be addressed in the classroom by choosing the most appropriate video.

METHOD

Research problem

A group of first-year university students have demonstrated an unbalanced level of proficiency in the English language skills. They are much more proficient in reading and writing than in speaking and listening. Most of them had communicated their concern, explaining that in their school years, little attention was paid by their teachers to spoken English. In this study, it was decided to focus on listening comprehension in particular, since it has been probably the most neglected skill both in the English classroom and in research for many decades (Elin, 1972; Mahsefat, 2012).

Participants

The participants were 16 tertiary education students taking a compulsory General English course intended for learners with an A1+ level (Common European Reference for Languages, CEF), according to the course program. They were placed in that course after taking an entry test. All the participants are in the first year of their programs, and consequently, this is their first semester taking English at university. Their ages range from 18 to 20 years.

Stages of the action research study

The target group had English lessons twice a week. Every lesson lasted two pedagogical hours, for a total of four hours a week. The intervention was implemented during the second half of the first semester, for a period of two weeks.

Step 1: the teacher explained the intervention which was going to be held during the following four lessons. **Step 2:** the students worked with a YouTube channel as a source of oral input. Learners were exposed to teaching, modeling, and practice of listening for specific information pre-listening and post-listening strategies, which were then applied while using a bilingual YouTube channel called *Amigos Ingleses* as a source of oral input. **Step 3:** in the class after the intervention, the participants shared their perceptions about their experience in listening for specific information subskill development through a 25-minute focus group.

Videos

Four six-minute video clips were used (one for each session), covering topics appropriate for an A1+ learner. Videos were chosen based on the familiarity of the topics. The video clips were projected on the classroom board using a projector and loud speakers. Each video clip was presented twice.

The YouTubers in the videos are an English man and a Spanish woman, and they present some dialogues and jokes in Spanish in between the stories. They deal with fun topics about the Spanish and English languages, such as cultural differences and common mistakes.

Strategies

The strategies taught to the learners were a selection of cognitive, meta-cognitive and socio-affective pre-listening and while-listening strategies presented by Lynch and Mendelsohn (2010, based on Goh, 2002, Vandergrift, 2003, and Kondo & Yang, 2004). The criterion for the strategies chosen was how useful they were to the listening for specific information subskill development. Every strategy (predicting/inferencing, contextualization, planning, comprehension monitoring, selective attention, questioning and cooperation) was taught, modeled, and practiced in every session before watching and working with the video clips.

Data collection technique: focus group

To assess participants' perceptions about the intervention, a whole-class focus group technique was used. All 16 participants were invited, but only 10 could attend. This focus group was specially created for this research. The procedural guide and list of questions were written following the step guide for focus groups by Hamui-Sutton & Varela-Ruiz (2013). The guide consisted of 10 questions, covering the following dimensions: a) perceptions about the intervention as a whole, b) perceptions about the use of videos and strategies, and c) perceptions about the development of the subskill. This instrument went through a process of expert validation from four judges, and a piloting session with a similar group of students, who made suggestions about the instrument's readability.

The focus group was conducted in Spanish (participants' mother tongue) and it took approximately 25 minutes. All participants gave their opinions whenever they felt necessary and their answers were recorded, transcribed, and translated to English in order to be analyzed. The information obtained from participants was grouped into eight themes and 20 subthemes for a thematic analysis (Guest, MacQueen & Namey, 2012; Chapman, Chapman & Hadfield, 2015).

Data analysis techniques

In the thematic analysis, the most repeated or significant concepts and ideas were classified in groups, forming themes and subthemes, which was useful to identify the collective perspectives of the group about the pedagogical intervention, and how they thought their listening for specific information subskill developed. The themes emerged based on what the participants said in the interview (Gibbs, 2007).

Description of the intervention

The first question of the focus group gathered information about what learners thought they were doing during the intervention. Two learners actually answered what was being asked in the question, while most of the other participants focused more on the benefits and the positive effects of the intervention, a topic which will be discussed in the corresponding section. According to those two participants' opinions, the intervention was useful in two ways. First, it was a good way to explore their own listening comprehension level. When asked how they realized what their level was, they explained that checking their scores after each mini quiz was very helpful to see where they were standing and how much progress they had made by the end of the process. Second,

it allowed them to learn how to listen for specific information. Both learners mentioned that the intervention was very important, because they had never been taught how to listen before. Many of them also stated that listening was the most difficult thing to do for them in English.

It is very important to highlight the fact that many participants reported the exact same phrase when speaking about their experiences with listening: "listening has always been hard for me". It is a positive fact that participants could acknowledge their difficulties in this skill given that their scores in the pretest were low.

Regarding the quality of the input they used before this course (in their school years), all participants expressed that, in their lessons, recordings were presented in CD or cassette format. The participants claimed that those recordings sounded unnatural and that it was very hard for them to understand the context of what was happening in the story. One of the participants mentioned that the English taught in the classrooms is often *too formal*, and some sounds or expressions that Spanish speakers are taught sometimes *do not exist in the target language*.

As to the methodology used, the participants recalled that they had never been taught how to listen. Some of the elements they mentioned as negative aspects were: the time provided for listening practice, the time provided for pre-listening, the lack of practice (frequency), and the lack of tools (strategies) to make the listening task less difficult.

Listening for specific information subskill development

The majority of the learners had something to say about this matter, even when they were being asked about other subjects. This theme was recurrent within other themes as well. Most of them spoke about the development of the subskill listening for specific information in particular. This would mean that not only they learned what they were taught, but also about what they were taught. It was clear to them what they were learning.

At the same time, they mentioned how their mini quiz scores improved and how they felt their listening became better. The expressions 'now I know how to listen' and 'I learned how to listen', were mentioned several times. When they were asked if they felt they made progress in the listening for specific information subskill, everybody nodded.

The learners were clearly aware of their progress. Many of them mentioned that checking their scores after each mini quiz helped them realize how much the subskill was being developed lesson by lesson. "I liked it, because in the first video it was hard for me, but then, in the next lessons, it became easy for me to answer the questions" (P.13), who said this phrase, moved from 40% of achievement (first mini quiz), to 100% of achievement in the last mini quiz.

The strategies contribution

In regard to the strategies learned (described in the 'strategies' section) in order to work with the listening for specific information subskill, the participants had positive perceptions about them. Some of the learners mentioned them in general, but many of them referred to some strategies or *tips* in particular. The learners were very conscious about using them and in what way they contributed to succeeding in the assessment instances.

The videos' contribution

The participants (P) had many things to say about the contribution of the use of the chosen videos in order to develop the subskill. First of all, they explained how helpful it was for them to see what was happening: "visualizing the person who is speaking is much better than just listening" (P.14). Far from being a distraction, they said that it helped them concentrate on what was happening in the story, and that provided clues to identify in which part of the story they could find the information they needed (anticipating). It also helped them give meaning to the words or phrases they did not understand.

Regarding the authenticity of the language, participants also appreciated having the possibility to listen to real language, which was something they missed in their school years, "the English you showed us is real English" (P.9). Other participants also mentioned authentic *context*, referring to what was happening in the videos was real, and they were in real places. It was not only a voice coming from a radio, "what I liked is the context in which the explanation of the situation was given" (P.16).

The contribution of practice

One of the elements that contributed the most to the success of the implementation of this pedagogical intervention was practice. Apart from the two resources that were chosen for developing the learners' listening for specific information subskill (videos and strategies), the amount of time and the frequency of practice provided was considered to be very important to accomplish the objectives of this study.

In the focus group session, some participants mentioned the role of practice in their listening comprehension development. Participant 7 alluded to a very common issue among Chilean students in general, which leads to a very well-known phrase: 'Materia pasada, materia olvidada'. This refers to how short-term learning (or not proper learning) happens when students try to study for an evaluation, after which the studied content is forgotten. P. 7 said that the kind of methodology used for the intervention, in which practice was present in every class, contributed to tackle this common problem.

Suggestions and difficulties faced in the intervention

Due to the positive results participants observed in this process, it was hard for the participants to think of negative aspects when consulted. It took some time for them to answer the last questions, related to the changes or improvements they would have made to the intervention, and the difficulties of having worked as they did.

In regard to the improvements and suggestions, three participants mentioned that it would be a good idea to relate the topics seen on the videos to the professional degrees they are pursuing. They would like to learn more about their own professional fields, and when consulted, they said that some vocabulary in English is sometimes required in some other subjects. This need can be explained due to the nature of the English course they are taking which focuses on general English instead of English for specific purposes. Most of the learners in the group belonged to the programs of Sound Tech and Business Administration. One of those participants said that she liked the methodology used during the lessons, and she would like to see that in the English classroom more often.

In terms of the difficulties faced in this process, P.6 commented that for beginners, the way the YouTubers spoke on the videos might have been too fast. At the same time, when answering a different question, she explained that using the video clips was a good opportunity to learn even more. This could be interpreted in the sense that, the level of English shown in the video clips was above her level, presenting her with an interesting challenge. Participants, though, were capable of performing all the activities and assessment instances.

Participants' perceptions about their listening comprehension skill

Participants' initial and final perceptions about their listening comprehension skill capacity will be presented and discussed in this section.

Participants' initial perceptions

The main motivation to work with the listening comprehension skill in particular was the concerns and insecurities the learners showed in regard to their own listening comprehension skill. They were conscious of their weaknesses at listening and the insufficient practice of the skill during their school years. Before the pretest, learners' listening comprehension (listening for specific information subskill) had been assessed through non-graded activities. In those assessment instances, learners had shown poor results. In several opportunities, learners expressed how listening was difficult for them and how

they felt they were not familiar with how to deal with listening comprehension tests. Additionally, they criticized the quality of the listening practice they had at school.

The negative perceptions the learners had towards listening, and more specifically, how listening was taught to them at school are not difficult to explain. Listening has been considered as the most neglected skill in English language teaching (Elin, 1972; Kuo, 2009; Mahsefat, 2012). One possible reason for this phenomenon is the common belief that students listen to their English teacher all the time, thus, further practice is not necessary. Additionally, it is also believed that the strategies used for listening in the L1 could be automatically transferred to the L2 (Kuo, 2009).

If that was the case, and listening was being neglected and ignored in most of learners' schools, it is logical for them to think that listening in English is a difficult thing to do. Kuo (2009) states that there are neither efficient nor sufficient opportunities to practice the listening skill in English classrooms. This lack of opportunities for listening activities is also present in the Chilean classrooms. According to Figueroa & Márquez (2013), the Chilean Ministry of Education encourages teachers to pay more attention to reading and writing rather than the listening and speaking skills as it is stated in the educational programs for the national curriculum.

Participants' final perceptions

In the focus group session, when learners were asked about what was done in the pedagogical intervention of this study, and why it was done in that way, they were very clear about how important knowing how to listen was. Furthermore, they were able to understand very well what was done and why. Contrary to the common belief that listening in a foreign language is practically the same as listening in their L1, learners were conscious of the differences between listening in their L1 (Spanish) and the L2 (English). Furthermore, participants understood that what was taught to them had to do with one of many subskills of the listening skill. In this action research study, learners learned and practiced the listening for specific information subskill, and that was very clear to them. Learners understood in which specific contexts they could use what they had learned, and how they could adapt it to other contexts as well. In the focus group session, they explained how they improved their ability to understand the specific information they were listening for. This does not mean that they would suddenly become very proficient in all the listening subskills.

In the case of the listening for specific information micro skill or sub-skill, the main focus is on finding some specific information or predicting information. Learners need to master several abilities before saying that they are, for example, proficient in listening. These abilities are commonly known as micro skills (Richards, 1983; Brown, 2004) or subskills (Harmer, 2010; Scrivener, 2011; Wilson 2008). Learners mentioned that by the end of the inter-

vention, they were able to identify the specific information they needed. They were aware that they would not suddenly become very proficient in listening; however, they recognized their progress in the listening for specific information subskill in particular.

Previous studies have found that using the L1 may be considered beneficial for the development of the L2 (Weschler, 1997; Brooks-Lewis, 2009; De La Campa & Nassaji, 2009; Galindo, 2011). Unfortunately, it remains unclear whether the use of the participants' L1 in the video clips was of use to their learning as they did not mention this topic at any point in the focus group discussion. In general, participants found the video clips very useful for their learning. However, the effect of the presence of their L1 remains inconclusive as there was no specific comment about this linguistic aspect. It may be the case that participants were so concentrated on the tasks that they did not even realize when the YouTubers started speaking in Spanish (Guest, MacQueen & Namey, 2012; Meuter & Allport, 1999).

CONCLUSIONS

In the light of the analysis and discussion of the data emerging from this study, the implementation of the methodology used may be considered successful, as observed in the comments made by participants. Therefore, teaching listening strategies and using a bilingual YouTube channel seems beneficial for L2 learners of English. The qualitative data obtained in the focus group activity revealed that learners valued this experience as positive as they were able to perceive their improvement. This suggests that learners, especially adults, can be very accurate in analyzing their own learning. Thus, learners' comments need to be valued and considered when making important decisions in teaching. At the same time, it is advisable to have in mind individual differences in learners' learning styles which may impact the different ways in which they make progress.

It is also concluded that the participants can change their negative perception about their capacities. After their participation in this study their perceptions about their listening skills were more positive. They became learners who were more aware of what they had learnt as they stated having learned specific strategies that helped them know what to do in a listening scenario, and made them feel more comfortable. At the same time, they showed a capacity to assess the material and strategies chosen for the tasks.

Contrary to what some researchers suggest, the fact that the aural input contained some bits in Spanish did not seem to divert participants' attention from the main focus in the listening tasks (i.e. the listening extracts in English). However, there is no evidence that learners would find the "bilingual" aspect beneficial in any way as this issue did not appear in any comment in the focus group session. This leaves the criteria for choosing this bilingual channel unsu-

ported. However, this lack of evidence may be due to the absence of a question directed to target this aspect in the focus group discussion. The evaluation of this topic was outside the scope of this study.

As a conclusion, the combination of the listening strategies taught and the use of the YouTube channel as oral input can be considered beneficial for the participants of this study, and thus, it may have similar impact in other groups of learners. However, it is important to consider that there must be constant, substantial, and systematic practice of listening strategies to achieve improvement. Finally, this action research study showed that it is possible to improve learners' listening subskills.

Future applications of the methodology

Participants' comments related to how this methodology, including the materials and strategies, will be of use to them in the future as they helped to increase their level of English in general. They also referred to the beneficial impact for their speaking skill and confidence. Finally, many of the participants mentioned that what they learned during these lessons would help them in future listening assessment instances.

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THE EFFECTS OF TELECOLLABORATION ON ELLS'¹ MOTIVATION AND INTERCULTURAL COMPETENCE: A PILOT PROJECT

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Abstract

The use of technology in university level ESL/EFL classrooms is an ever-expanding topic. This telecollaboration pilot project between students from Universidad de Concepción and the English Language Institute at Nazareth College focused on the ability of technology to enhance students' motivation, intercultural competence, and second language acquisition. Drawing on various scholarly sources, teacher observations, and student survey results from the 24 student participants, it was concluded that telecollaboration is an effective method of increasing student engagement and motivation in an intercultural dialogue. Telecollaboration also provided an authentic environment to develop key L2 (second language) communicative skills.

¹ ELLs': English Language Learners'

Keywords: communicative skills, EFL, intercultural competence, motivation, telecollaboration

Resumen

El uso de la tecnología en las aulas de Inglés como Segunda Lengua (ESL) e Inglés como Lengua Extranjera (EFL) a nivel universitario es un tema cada vez más amplio. Este proyecto piloto de telecolaboraciones entre estudiantes de la Universidad de Concepción y el English Language Institute de Nazareth College se enfocó en la capacidad que tiene la tecnología para mejorar la motivación, la competencia intercultural, y la adquisición de una segunda lengua de los estudiantes. Basándose en diversas fuentes académicas, observaciones de profesores y resultados de encuestas a los 24 participantes, se concluyó que la telecolaboración es un método efectivo para incrementar la motivación e involucrar a los estudiantes en un diálogo intercultural. Las telecolaboraciones brindaron también, un entorno auténtico para desarrollar habilidades comunicativas claves en su segundo idioma.

Palabras clave: competencia intercultural, habilidades comunicativas, inglés como lengua extranjera, motivación, telecolaboración

INTRODUCTION

Learning a Second or Foreign Language in a traditional classroom can become redundant and dull, with the “teacher as information giver; knowledge flows only one way from the teacher to the student” (Anikina, Sobinova, & Petrova, 2015, p. 158), but with new advances in technology that barrier could be overcome (Eisenberg & Ely, 1993; Kern, 2013; Warburton, 2009). The necessity of learning the English language to become part of a globalized community is imminent (Crystal, 2003), and therefore new ways of using technology in the classroom to create a more collaborative environment must be explored (Graddol, 2006; Levy, 2009). Teletandem (Telles & Vassallo, 2006; Vassallo & Telles, 2006) or telecollaboration (Guth & Helm, 2012; Jauregui & Bañados, 2008; Jauregui, de Graaff, van der Bergh & Kriz, 2011) can be used as methods to integrate technology into the learning process in order to help enhance the communicative competence of students (Lázár, Huber-Kriegler, Lussier, Matei & Peck, 2007) and give language learners an effective intercultural experience (Belz & Thorne, 2006; O’Dowd, 2003; Tudini, 2007; Ware & Kramsch, 2005). Students can participate in authentic activities and interactions (Crook, 1994; Lantolf, 2000), which allow them to learn about different cultures and customs (Clark, 1996). These types of experiences can also help

students promote their collaborative learning (Doughty & Long, 2003). Telecollaboration gives the opportunity to combine many different factors that are vital to language education and learning, specified by Dooly as “social interaction, dialogue, intercultural exchange, and communication.” (2017, p. 169). Multiple studies also focus on increasing students’ motivation (Warschauer, 1996). Garden and Lambert (1959, 1972) focus on motivation and the second language acquisition, while others focus on how students’ motivation influences education and cultural learning (Dörnyei & Ushioda, 2011; Jauregi, de Graaff, van den Bergh, & Kriz, 2011). Telecollaboration gives students a dynamic, meaningful experience in their language learning process that increases their cultural awareness and motivation for learning the target language (Jauregi et al., 2011).

LITERATURE REVIEW

Just as technology has changed and evolved rapidly, so has the interest in telecollaborative experiences in language learning and teaching (Dooly, 2017; Dooly & O’Dowd 2018; Warschauer 1997). The idea of connecting language learners in different countries and from different cultures is not a new idea, however the ability to “connect language learners across the globe” (Dooly & O’Dowd, 2018, p. 12) became much more attainable with the appearance of the internet and the invention of personal computers (PCs) (Jauregi & Bañados, 2008; O’Dowd, 2018). Computers and technology have in turn had a significant influence on the experience of learning a foreign language (Pennington, 2003; Warschauer, 1997). Kern specifies that the continued rapid advances in technology and accessibility around the globe, “promises that technology-supported language learning will remain a critical area for teaching and research.” (2013, p. 211). However, as Dooly and O’Dowd (2012) point out, the increase in the accessibility of technology has expanded the use of telecollaboration in language learning, but it does not completely explain the continued growth of its popularity and use as an accepted language teaching method. There are other aspects that have influenced the popularity and spread of telecollaboration such as the ability to give students a meaningful and authentic use of language outside of the typical classroom environment, and the potential to increase students’ intercultural communicative competence (Belz & Thorne, 2006; Dooly & O’Dowd, 2012; Kelm, 1996; O’Dowd, 2011). Telecollaborative interactions have also shown to benefit the enhancement of students’ motivation (Warschauer, 1996), which has been described as playing a “crucial role in all kinds of learning processes, and particularly in the development of an L2.” (Jauregi et al., 2011, p. 3). Telecollaboration can be used as a mechanism to increase the motivation of students to learn English while practicing the language in a safe and authentic communicative setting (Jauregi & Bañados, 2008; Ushioda, 2011; Warschauer, 1996).

What is our definition of telecollaboration?

In just a decade the amount of research and interest in using telecollaboration as a tool for language learning has increased at an extremely rapid rate (Dooly & O'Dowd, 2018). Many different definitions and terms have been used to describe this type of language exchange (O'Dowd, 2013). Some examples of these terms are "computer-mediated communication" (Jauregi & Bañados 2008; Jauregi et al., 2011; Warschauer, 1997), "teletandem" (Telles & Vassallo 2006), "e-tandem" (O'Rourke, 2007), and "virtual exchange" (Helm, 2015). An exact definition from O'Dowd describes telecollaboration as "the engagement of groups of learners in extended periods of online intercultural interaction and collaboration with partners from other cultural contexts or geographical locations as an integrated part of their educational programmes and under the guidance of educators and/or expert facilitators" (2018, p. 5). Telecollaboration not only allows collaboration and interaction to happen inside the classroom, but it also brings flexibility to students as it can be "carried out in a variety of settings (classroom, home, workplace, laboratory)" through various online communication devices such as computers, tablets, and cellphones (Dooly, 2017, p. 169). Much of the research on telecollaboration has shown that the availability, flexibility, and benefits of this technology have made it an increasingly popular tool to support the communicative abilities and motivation of language learners (Dooly 2017; Dooly & O'Dowd 2018; Jauregui & Bañados, 2008; Jauregi et al., 2011; O'Dowd, 2011; Warschauer, 1996).

METHOD

This pilot project was conducted from September to November 2018, and it emerged after numerous exchanges of ideas and discussions about common problems observed in university level EFL/ESL classes at the University of Concepción and Nazareth College. The aim of the project was to observe how a student's levels of motivation, L2 proficiency, and intercultural understanding can change throughout the semester when given an authentic and safe space to practice with another university level English Language Learner (ELL). This is a common goal for EFL/ESL teachers worldwide due to the emergence of learners who crave more non-traditional and dynamic classroom methods. EFL/ESL university level learners are no longer satisfied with monotonous classroom material and when faced with traditional classroom teaching methods tend to lose attention, motivation, and continue having trouble communicating in their L2. Educators need to understand that the learning process affects all the actors involved and a productive way to start changing the method is by utilizing technology and introducing activities that allow students to feel comfortable and discover their own ways of learning. In this type of environment, students are allowed to make mistakes, and most importantly, to

learn from them. The combination of using technology while in a collaborative classroom environment can ultimately shape the way a person sees a language, speaks a language, and lives that language.

To initiate the project students were asked to volunteer from each university and initial guidelines were set by both lead teachers to begin the process of collaboration. The participants were twelve students from the University of Concepción, Los Ángeles Campus, who belonged to the English Online Program. This group of students consisted of seven Chilean women and five Chilean men, whose ages ranged from 18 to 21 and whose mother tongue was Spanish. Their L2 proficiency level ranged from beginner to pre-intermediate. The group of participants from Nazareth College in Rochester, New York included twelve students who belonged to the English Language Institute (ELI). This group of students consisted of nine women and three men, whose ages ranged from 18 to 23. Their nationalities were Chinese, Turkish, and Saudi, and their L2 proficiency level ranged from beginner to advanced.

Procedure

After attempting to use various online platforms such as Google Hangout and Skype, it was decided that Zoom would be the most efficient way for the students from the two universities to communicate during sessions. The lead teachers held previous meetings through Zoom and Google Hangout, and Zoom was the preferred method of weekly communication for the preparation of student speaking tasks.

The themes of the weekly conversations were agreed upon by both lead teachers the week before the telecollaboration sessions and were given to the students 2-3 days in advance so they could build their background knowledge and vocabulary. When deciding the topics, the level of English proficiency, content from students' classes and authentic scenarios from home or university were taken into account. The goal was for students to use a variety of vocabulary and to express themselves more naturally in a variety of contexts.

Students met weekly with a partner for 40-minute conversation sessions. Students were randomly matched in pairs with some exceptions. For example, students with low levels of L2 proficiency or L2 speaking anxiety were matched with partners who had a higher level of language proficiency or with a partner who spoke the same L1. In this case, groups of three students were formed; two students who spoke the same L1 and one student who spoke a different L1. In this way, the student with a low level of L2 proficiency would have support from their classmate who spoke the same L1 when communicating in their L2 with their conversation partner. Another exception was made for students who had gender preferences due to ethnic and religious practices. These students were allowed to work with a partner who shared their gender during each session.

Typically, at the beginning of each meeting, technical issues needed to be solved such as slow internet connections and the adjustment of the microphones and video systems. Because of the volunteer nature of the participants, there were also a few instances when students were unable to attend a session. See table 1 below for a detailed explanation of each session:

Table 1
Telecollaboration Sessions

Type of session	Activity
<i>Pre session activity 1</i>	Students were required to upload a short video to youtube to introduce themselves and ask their partner a personal question. The purpose of this was to help students feel more comfortable when they met their partner/s for the first time. As students sometimes face speaking anxiety in their L2, it was expected that they would be more open to speaking if they were able to exchange information with their partner/s in advance.
<i>Telecollaboration session 1</i>	Students met their partner/s, introduced themselves and shared some background knowledge about their country and city. Specifically, students were also required to speak about themselves and explain different things about the place they were born, including local traditions, customs, weather, and typical food.
<i>Pre session activity 2</i>	Students were asked to upload a short video to youtube describing their best friend. In this video, they were required to describe what their best friend looked like and what specific qualities they had that made them such a dependable person. Some of the students chose to bring photos of their friend to give their partner/s a visual representation of the person they were describing.
<i>Telecollaboration session 2</i>	Students became re-acquainted with their partners from the previous week. After this initial discussion, most partners began to talk about their friends and the aspects they consider to be most important when choosing a close friend. The discussion then shifted naturally to the topic of family members, and students began talking about their families and describing different personal and physical qualities of their favorite family members.
<i>Pre session activity 3</i>	Students were required to find pictures of their birthplace and also the region where they were living in order to have a conversation about the weather, climate and free-time activities. Once again they were encouraged to bring pictures and photos to show real images of the places to their partners.

<i>Telecollaboration session 3</i>	Students explained details of their country's climate, the clothing they need to wear, free time activities and sports they perform depending on the weather. They were encouraged to express their preferences about these topics in general. The Chilean student participants were from different regions in Chile, which was beneficial because they could make a comparison between the city they were from and the place they were living at the time. Students from Nazareth also found this topic engaging since they came from different countries, and different regions within their own countries. Due to this, they were also able to describe the differences in climate within their native regions and how this compared to the climate in their current country of study.
<i>Pre session activity 4</i>	Students were given the task of describing their university schedule including names of the subjects, and activities they usually do during the week and weekend. This information was relevant and useful for the following session in which they had to tell their partner about a typical day in their life.
<i>Telecollaboration session 4</i>	Students discussed a normal day on campus, some of them filmed areas of their university to show their partners what the campus facilities looked like. They then discussed the differences and similarities of the two universities. As all of the students were from different majors, they had to explain the different classes they took, and the activities they did as students during a regular day.
<i>Pre session activity 5</i>	Students were required to prepare photos of holidays in their home countries or country of study. Students from Nazareth College prepared pictures of their Halloween costumes, and students from UdeC chose some images of national celebrations to share during the following session.
<i>Telecollaboration session 5</i>	Students shared information about national celebrations and traditions. Topics included Halloween, Chinese New Year, Christmas and New Year's Eve. Students enthusiastically participated and described these holidays using photos from their phones, along with websites and videos.
<i>Pre session activity 6</i>	Teachers asked their students to communicate with their partner via WeChat (an online platform used to communicate through text messages, videos, and photos) about any topic that interested them. Students prepared the topic by themselves without teacher guidance.

<i>Telecollaboration session 6</i>	This session began in the classroom with the teacher and students discussing the topics the students had spoken about with their partner/s via WeChat. The discussion included difficulties they had during the virtual meeting, and how they solved their problems regarding vocabulary, grammar, and context. During the last 20 minutes of the session, students talked with their classmates and teacher about topics of their choice.
<i>Final Telecollaboration session 7</i>	No preparation was required for this session. During this final collaborative discussion, the teachers thanked the students for their participation and encouraged them to continue speaking with their partner/s. Students took group pictures and shared them through their technological devices. After some time for students to say goodbye to their partners, the teacher and the students participated in their last focus group. Finally, the teachers gave an informal oral survey to the group of students as a way to receive feedback about the program.

Note. Source, Instructor Observation Notes.

RESULTS

The goal of this pilot project was to give the participants the chance to have an authentic speaking experience in their L2 while also observing whether their telecollaborative experience impacted their motivation, cultural understanding, and communicative competence. In general, the majority of the student participants were extremely motivated to interact with their conversation partners weekly. Their motivations were based on learning more about the culture of their partners and practicing their English oral communication. The Chinese student participants were driven to merely speak English since oral L2 communication is the most challenging aspect of the language learning process for them. Similarly, Saudi and Turkish students were motivated to participate due to their interest in learning more about students from other areas of the world. Specifically, they were curious to understand more about their universities, traditions, customs, and family life. An online survey was created by the Chilean teacher and sent to her students at the end of the program, in order to obtain feedback about their experiences throughout the telecollaboration program. Most students described having a high level of commitment to the program, and in almost all cases they expressed that their motivation to learn English had increased significantly. All of them reported that they would recommend the experience to other students because it allowed them to learn more vocabulary and grammar, as well as express themselves more fluently

in their L2. Throughout the telecollaboration project, they became more confident in facing real English conversational situations because they were able to embrace mistakes as part of their learning process and take charge of their language development with the guidance of the professor.

The Chilean participants commented:

"This programme helped me gain confidence and self-esteem, not to be afraid of making mistakes when speaking English in public."

"In some way, it helped me express myself more easily and with more confidence when talking to people who speak a different language."

The majority of students also reported that the telecollaboration significantly increased their knowledge and interest in other cultures. During the oral survey, students described in detail how their amazement about how similar their lives were to their partner/s and the many commonalities they shared regarding family life, friendship and university responsibilities. The students from Nazareth College expressed their hopes of visiting their partner/s in the future and demonstrated interest to learn more about Chile and other countries in South America. During the focus group, Chilean students expressed that the opportunity to learn about foreign cultures and customs fascinated them. Although, they never expected to be able to communicate effectively in English, with the support of their partner/s they were able to learn about different realities and ways of living. Some learners pointed out that traditions, family life, and many other aspects were similar in some ways, while others expressed their amusement with getting to know very different customs and ways of life. The majority of the students expressed their positive intercultural experiences throughout the sessions, hoping to have the opportunity to visit their partner/s in the US in the future. Some students commented:

"It was a very entertaining experience in which I was able to meet someone from another country, I learned some things from her and my Chilean classmate, I would recommend this experience, it makes us more interested in the language."

"I loved the programme! Now, I have a friend from China, and I never thought that as a freshman at the university I would have this possibility, to learn about other cultures and make a new friend who, along with my Chilean classmate, we are in touch with. Now we are very close friends. I learned English, although I loved English before, now I love it even more!"

This project drove students to learn more about other participants and their cultures, which also directly impacted the participants' ability to com-

municate because they were more concerned with learning and expressing information about themselves than they were about making mistakes when using their L2. The Chinese student participants reported during the oral survey that they were "so excited" to see and speak to their partner every week that they rarely used their pre-session notes. Occasionally, when they were unable to express themselves clearly to their Chilean speaking partner, they were able to communicate using photos and the message feature on Zoom. It was observed that Chilean students also used the same communicative methods when they had difficulty expressing themselves orally. This method worked well for the intermediate to advanced level ELLs because they had enough background knowledge in their L2 to decode and explain what they needed to say when communication became difficult. For the beginner Chilean ELLs, they relied more on their prepared vocabulary and sentences to communicate with their partners. Despite their low level of proficiency, they were able to use other non-verbal ways to communicate, such as pictures, gestures, and isolated words to speak and understand each other. At the same time, the continued practice using the target language was a key for their success throughout the learning process. The participants knew and understood their limitations regarding their language-level, but that was not a concern when speaking English with their partner/s. A student commented:

"I think the programme was quite good because it helps you relax when you have to speak and to have more confidence and fluency when structuring sentences at the moment of speaking."

CONCLUSIONS

The reflections on this interactive computer-based project show that giving students the opportunity to communicate in a target language with language learners from distinct countries and cultures directly impacts their motivation and intercultural awareness in the English language learning process. The telecollaboration sessions engaged the students in dynamic and authentic interactions, which allowed them to gain unknown and unexpected knowledge of different cultures. The bonds that emanated from the sessions allowed the participants to create a collaborative learning environment where students not only communicated in their L2 but ultimately felt a sense of belonging. Both groups of learners demonstrated a willingness to participate throughout the project in pursuit of the same goal. Although many unexpected situations arose such as technical issues, time constraints, absent partners, and communicative challenges, students were able to face them with tolerance, adaptability, and commitment. Overall, the participants reported that the experience met their expectations and they expressed a great deal of enthusiasm for taking part in future projects.

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RAISING AWARENESS IN THE CONVERSATION CLASSROOM THROUGH DRAMA CLIPS - A CASE STUDY

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Abstract

Starting from the assumption that speaking, and in particular, conversation, is often the greatest challenge faced by EFL learners, the present study aims to move towards a consistent approach in L2 conversation pedagogy. In doing so, a methodology based on language awareness through drama clips is put to the test in a conversation classroom, with the purpose of obtaining some preliminary empirical evidence to check whether it is an effective approach for developing L2 conversation skills. The results obtained in this small-scale study suggest that using audiovisuals in the classroom may indeed contribute to the improvement of L2 students' conversational competence.

Keywords: conversational competence, language awareness, drama clips

Resumen

Partiendo de la base de que la competencia conversacional suele representar uno de los mayores retos a los que se enfrentan los estudiantes de inglés como lengua extranjera, este estudio trata de ser un aporte a la pedagogía de la conversación en inglés como L2. Con este fin, se examina la eficacia de una metodología basada en la activación de la consciencia mediante el uso de clips

de vídeo en el aula de conversación, mediante un estudio piloto de pequeña escala. Los resultados de este estudio de caso sugieren que, efectivamente, el uso de materiales audiovisuales para la aplicación de la metodología inductiva puede contribuir de manera positiva a la mejora de la competencia conversacional del alumnado.

Palabras clave: competencia conversacional, activación de la consciencia, fragmentos filmicos

INTRODUCTION

A common problem in Spanish schools, and one that can certainly be found in other EFL contexts as well, is the poor level of oral skills amongst students, as compared to their level of performance in other areas. Most learners of English, even those armed with good knowledge of syntax, phonology, and a wide range of vocabulary, often face many problems to interact orally. The reasons that may account for this are no doubt multiple, and range from a low amount of input and output opportunities, to the implementation of poor methodologies that still focus on conversation via written-based models of spoken exchanges, along with more practical issues such as the traditional high ratio of students per class or the difficulties it poses when it comes to its evaluation.

In even worse scenarios, we can also find practitioners who neglect the teaching of conversation altogether, on the assumption that this ability will take care of itself by the natural transfer of skills from the L1. In this sense it is sometimes assumed that as long as students become competent in producing oral messages, they will naturally be ready to hold conversations. In our view, this is an oversimplistic perspective that seems to overlook the specificities of conversational skills. Conversing is not simply speaking. Instead, it involves several dimensions which should be specifically attended to in the classroom. Still, the ways in which this should be done are subject to debate in the field of applied linguistics, and more research in the area is needed.

In an attempt to contribute to this debate, this paper reports the results of a small-scale pilot study where the effects of implementing a language-awareness methodology in the conversation classroom were tested. As part of a bigger project aimed at the development of L2 learners' oral interaction skills, this pre-test/post-test study explored the extent to which the use of drama clips portraying different speech acts in a number of contexts can be an effective approach to help students boost their conversational competence.

The teaching of L2 conversational competence

The nature of conversation

Since the 1960s, the study of oral interaction has increasingly developed in many communication-related fields, with the subject being explored from the philosophical, sociological and ethno-methodological perspectives, as well as the purely linguistic point of view (Firth, 1957; Halliday, 1970). Progressively, the advancement in areas such as Pragmatics (e.g. Austin, 1962; Searle, 1969; Grice, 1975; Brown & Levinson, 1987 [1978]; Sperber & Wilson, 1986), Discourse Analysis (e.g. Foucault, 2002 [1969]; Sinclair & Coulthard, 1975; Brown & Yule, 1983; Stubbs, 1983; Carter, 1997), Conversation Analysis (e.g. Sacks, Schegloff & Jefferson, 1974; Levinson, 1983; Drew & Sorjonen, 1997; Johnstone, 2002), Corpus Linguistics (e.g. Baker, 2006) and Multimodality (e.g. Baldry & Thibault, 2006) have contributed to our understanding of the features that shape conversation as a specific genre within spoken language.

Due to the variety of perspectives produced, and surely to the complexity of the very phenomenon as well, there is no consensus today as to the exact nature of conversation, with different coexisting definitions (e.g. Biber et al., 1999; Warren, 2006; Rühlemann, 2007). In spite of their differences, however, all authors seem to agree on identifying the following characteristics as the basis of conversation: it reflects a shared context; it avoids elaboration, unnecessary explicitness or specification of reference; it is interactive and has a specific internal structure implying discourse and relation management elements; it has a restricted and repetitive repertoire; it responds to the needs of real-time processing; and it uses a vernacular range of expression, including a vast number of lexical routines and multiword units.

The specified characteristics reveal that conversation must be seen as an independent form of spoken communication, which differs greatly from other forms of spoken discourse (e.g. lectures, conferences, formal presentations, etc.), and which demands therefore specific attention in the L2 classroom. In this sense, theoretical contributions to the study of conversation must be the keystone supporting the teaching action. As these features reflect, conversation is a multidimensional notion, which requires approaches and resources suitable to the complexity of the phenomenon. This is the area where the present study tries to make a contribution.

Pedagogical approaches to conversation

In EFL contexts, the teaching of conversation has been approached in different ways during the last decades. With the advent of communicative

methodologies, the so-called Indirect Approach was first adopted in the 70s and 80s. In the belief that languages should be learnt by being engaged in extensive communicative tasks where students have to manage real-life situations, this approach focuses on language use (e.g. role playing, problem-solving activities, debates) with no explicit teaching of conversation rules, strategies or lexico-grammatical elements (Richards, 1990). By experiencing the internal mechanism of conversations, learners are thus expected to infer its structure and main features.

As early as the 1990s and in view of its poor results, this approach came in for heated criticism. Authors such as Johnson (1992), Burns (1998) or Bygate (2002) stated that although learners improved their fluency, it was at the expense of accuracy and appropriacy, with students becoming “tediously inaccurate chatterers” (Johnson, 1992: 180). The main problem this approach poses seems to be, in fact, its lack of specification and systematic treatment of the conversational skills to be developed.

As it is often the case, the reaction to this criticism materialized in the advent of the opposite extreme: the Direct Approach. In Richards’ (1990: 79) words, it “focuses explicitly on the processes and strategies involved in casual conversation”, and it entails preparing the lessons around them. This approach favours a systematic development of conversational competence, since it aims at stimulating the students’ declarative (and not only performative) knowledge of the conversational features, rules, strategies, discourse-level grammar, expressions and formulae, phonology, and underlying processes involved. In the same vein, Dörnyei and Thurrell (1992) argued that if learners are made conscious of all these features and practise them in controlled ways, they are likely to make much faster progress towards becoming relaxed and polished conversationalists.

When put into practice, nevertheless, this approach also presents shortcomings. As any experienced teacher may know, when learners’ attention is systematically focused on form, they tend to become too self-conscious every time they use the language, and are therefore faced with many difficulties to develop fluency properly.

Another approach emerged parallel to the previous one: The Language Awareness Approach. Closely related to the Direct Approach, it is based on the premise that “using data provided or collected, learners observe and analyse patterns of interest and come up with descriptions on tentative rules, usually in group work” (van Lier 2001: 164). Thus, this approach diverges from the Direct one in that students are not provided with the conversation features explicitly; instead, it is based on samples of conversation from which learners are expected to infer the underlying features or rules autonomously. Despite all the advantages this approach clearly presents (e.g. learners’ active involvement,

cognitive effort and noticing, meaningful learning favoured), it still falls short when it comes to the development of fluency, and also when we consider the many cultural and contextual features that characterise conversations, which tend to be neglected in language awareness activities (Moreno Jaén & Pérez Basanta, 2009).

All the approaches discussed so far come, then, with their pitfalls, and none of them represents a method which could be said to be wholly satisfactory for teaching conversation. A mixed approach is therefore desirable, so that it includes various approaches to better help learners to achieve fluency, without sacrificing accuracy or awareness of cultural and contextual features of conversation. A number of proposals have been put forward as attempts to put together the best features of each approach. One of the first ones was the framework proposed by Nolasco & Arthur (1987), which included four types of speaking activities, combining the three approaches mentioned above: controlled activities for accuracy (Direct Approach), awareness activities for identification of features (Awareness Approach), fluency activities (Indirect Approach) and feedback activities for awareness of errors and areas to improve (Awareness Approach). Nevertheless, and despite the obvious step forward this proposal represents, it would seem that the mere mixture of activities does not necessarily lead to a new approach per se. In fact, Nolasco and Arthur's framework can be said to lack cohesion, given that features of the different approaches are not truly integrated and merged.

From our point of view, the aforementioned lack of cohesion in Nolasco and Arthur's (1987) approach has been overcome by a more recent proposal designed by Pérez Basanta and Rodríguez Martín (2007). Since this is the method implemented in the present study, we will consider it in more detail in the following paragraphs.

Pérez Basanta & Rodríguez Martín's (2007) model

Framework of features and strategies of conversation.

The proposal elaborated by these authors is a comprehensive model for teaching L2 conversation. In this sense, it starts by providing a full list of the elements that comprise conversation and that should be the focus of any pedagogical intervention (Table 1). This framework is not focused on a sole approach, but it takes into reckoning the contributions made by different perspectives (from fields such as Pragmatics, Discourse Analysis and Conversation Analysis), selecting the most relevant factors from each of them with a view to apply them when teaching conversation. In our view, the diversification of this proposal makes it an eclectic and useful tool from a pedagogical perspective.

Table 1
Framework of Features and Strategies of Conversation

1- SPEECH ACTS	e.g. thanking ('thank you', 'thanks'); requesting ('I want/need...', 'could you...?' 'Would you mind...?'); etc.
2- TURN-TAKING:	
-TAKING THE TURN:	
STARTING UP:	a hesitant start using filled pauses (um), verbal fillers (well, I mean, you know) or/and items such as 'obviously', 'actually'; a clean start using introductory devices or starters (such as 'well').
TAKING OVER:	Subsequent turns may be connected by an 'uptake' (eg. 'yeah', 'oh', 'well', 'yes', 'no') or a link (e.g. 'and', 'but', 'cos', 'so') which is often triggered by an 'appealer' in the previous speaker's turn (eg. 'you know').
INTERRUPTING:	'alerts' ('hey', 'listen', 'look') and 'metacomments' ('can I just tell...', 'can I say something about this', 'could I stop you there', 'may I stop you', 'let me just...') are discourse devices which serve as interruptors.
-HOLDING THE TURN:	To hold the turn means to carry on talking. Some devices help the speaker to play for time, avoiding a breakdown and take-over: filled pauses and/or verbal fillers, strategically placed silent pauses, repetition, a new start.
-YIELDING THE TURN:	
PROMPTING:	Some discourse acts prompt the other party to respond, acting as turn-yielders. E.g. apology, greeting, invite, offer, question, request.
APPEALING:	Turn-final 'appealers' serve as an explicit signal to the listener that some kind of feedback would be appropriate. They occur in separate tone units with a rising tone. E.g. question tags, all right, right, OK, you know, you see.
GIVING UP:	the speaker realises that s/he has no more to say or that s/he thinks it is time the listener said something.
3- BACKCHANNELLING	e.g. um, ye, oh, I see, really, O.K., right, aha

4- ADJACENCY PAIRS, e.g.,	
greeting–greeting	e.g. ‘Hello’ – ‘Hello’
congratulation –	e.g. ‘Congratulations on the baby’ – ‘Thank you’
apology–acceptance	e.g. ‘I’m sorry’ – ‘It’s okay’
inform– acknowledge	e.g. “My name is Peter” – “Okay”.
leave-taking – leave-taking	e.g. ‘Bye’ – ‘Bye’
5- HEDGES	e.g. sort of, kind of.
6- DISCOURSE MARKERS	e.g. ok, now, so, well, actually, in fact, of course.
7- DOWNTONERS	e.g. just, please.
8- FILLERS OR THINKING DEVICES	e.g. you know, you see.
9- PAUSES:	
-FILLED PAUSES e.g. er, erm, um.	
-SILENT PAUSES	
10- DISFLUENCIES:	
-SPEAKER-EDITED:	
HESITATIONS	
(comprising repetition of segments, syllables, single and multiple words)	
-----	e.g. ‘Uh sh...shall I go...’, ‘I think we must... we must...’
SELF-CORRECTIONS	e.g. ‘Yeah I definily definitely can’
FURTHER-DETAILING	e.g. ‘She was thinking... Lizzie was thinking of...’
CHANGE OF PLAN -----	e.g. ‘No but actually you weren’t supposed to... you were advised not to...’
-NON-SPEAKER EDITED:	
INCOMPLETE ITEMS	e.g. ‘That is hilar... hilarious’
ERRORS	e.g. ‘I didn’t see too many... much evidence...’

Note. Source, Pérez Basanta & Rodríguez Martín (2007).

Given the limited scope of the present study, the decision of focusing on a single feature of the framework was taken. Speech acts, as language

functions, can be considered one of the main conversational organization principles, and, more than that, the ultimate competence every speaker wants to achieve when using the language; therefore, this piece of research focused on the pragmatic section of the framework, and hence, on speech acts. Since one of the premises of Pragmatics lies on the assumption that any utterance is more than a verbal issue given that it is always embedded within a given context which is constantly adapting itself as the interaction develops (Mey, 2009), teaching conversation necessarily requires using methodological approaches and materials that allow students to both access and produce language in naturalistic contexts. This is another aspect in which the model proposed by Pérez Basanta & Rodríguez Martín (2007) represents a notable contribution.

Methodological approach.

As already mentioned, this model includes a methodological framework focused on the teaching procedures to develop oral interaction skills, as well as the materials that best fit with that methodology. Drawing on Hadley (2002), the authors propose the following three-step model:

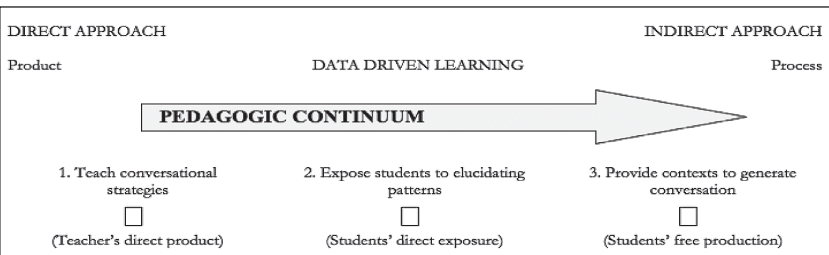


Figure 1. Pérez Basanta and Rodríguez Martín's (2007) methodological model.

This model is designed to connect both Direct and Indirect approaches by using data-driven learning (DDL). DDL – a subcategory within the language awareness methodology – encourages the student to become “a research worker whose learning needs to be driven by access to linguistic data” (Johns 1991: 2). In following this approach, learners are exposed to natural examples of language in context, in an attempt to help them notice and explore linguistic patterns which are made salient because of their frequency and stability. In other words, learners are made aware of how native speakers go about conversation, by encouraging them to observe and analyse real samples of interaction – usually taken from a bank of data or corpus – and guiding them in drawing their own generalisations with regard to language behaviour.

In our view, this framework succeeds in combining previous methods to

create a solid learning/teaching model that can be implemented in the conversation classroom, allowing (a) the explicit learning of conversational features, (b) the chance to observe natural conversations in real communicative situations for students to extract their own conclusions on language behaviour; and (c) the opportunity to put this knowledge into practice, thus gaining fluency.

The use of film clips and TV series as teaching materials.

The proposal by Pérez Basanta and Rodríguez Martín is based on the use of video clips as sample materials for illustrating natural conversation. No doubt, since “learners are expected to use their linguistic knowledge (...) in the appropriate social context” (Mekonnen, 2011: 2), this emphasis on the exploitation of authentic materials – i.e. not “specifically produced for the purposes of language teaching” (Nunan, 1989: 149) – seems particularly remarkable. In Boxer and Pickering’s (1995: 56) words, “only through materials that reflect how we really speak (...) will language learners receive an accurate account of the rules of speaking in a second or foreign language”.

The advantages of using audiovisual material for the development of L2 conversation skills have been highlighted in many studies (e.g. King, 2002; Shawback & Terhune, 2002; Sherman, 2003; López Sako, 2010; Frumuselu et al., 2015). In short, the main reasons to encourage teachers to use audiovisuals in the EFL classroom are: a) their realism, providing contextualised visual exchanges in real-life situations rather than artificial contexts; b) easy access to a wealth of social and cultural information; c) exposure to a wide range of language models (native and non-native accents, different registers or levels of formality, etc.); d) pedagogical exploitability both for receptive (language awareness) and productive skills (prompts for interactive output activities); e) accessibility of the materials through technological devices; f) motivation and involvement on students’ part.

Despite all the merits of audiovisual materials in EFL contexts, we cannot ignore one of the most recurrent criticisms directed against their pedagogical use: the extent to which scripted language can be considered authentic spoken input for students, given that dialogues are first written and therefore lack one of the basic features of natural language: spontaneity. On the basis of the comparative studies they have conducted, authors such as Taylor (2004), Rodríguez Martín (2010) or Rossi (2011) have found, indeed, differences between film language and real-life conversations. Overall, differences seem to emerge at all linguistic levels, with scripted dialogues containing, on average, richer vocabulary, more structured and cohesive interactions, less hesitation and overlappings, and relatively higher morpho-syntactic complexity.

In this respect, it should also be noted that Taylor (2004) found differences when he compared the original script (text given to the actors) of the film *Notting Hill* and its final transcription (what is actually said in the film). He argues that this is likely to be the result of actors’ tendency to “naturalize”

(Taylor, 2004: 80) language as they speak, in their attempt to simulate reality and be credible. Bearing on these results, the findings reported by those studies which analyze scripted language should be taken with caution, as they might not portray the actual, ‘naturalized’ language, learners are finally exposed to.

In any case, we entirely agree with Taylor (2004: 76) when he says that “given that film texts are inevitably false to some degree (...), the question to ask is how authentic can a film text be expected to be, and how desirable it is that it be realistic”. Film language may differ from authentic language, but if we consider that the former tends to be richer, more varied and easier to understand than natural conversation, it may even be an advantage for the language learner. Counting on good models of natural language that reflect most of the features of spontaneous discourse in context, and which at the same time make it easier for learners to cope with the input presented seems to be a good enough option for EFL contexts.

Thus, bearing upon the proposal put forward by Pérez Basanta and Rodríguez Martín (2007), the present study attempts to initiate an empirical analysis of its actual implementation in the classroom.

THE STUDY

In order to shed some light on the effectiveness of the language awareness methodology proposed by Pérez Basanta and Rodríguez Martín (2007) to improve L2 conversation through drama clips, we established the following research questions for the present pilot study:

- 1) Does the language awareness methodology increase L2 students’ linguistic resources to realize a given speech act (in this case “arguing”), specifically as regards formulaic expressions?
- 2) Does this methodology increase L2 students’ skills to realize a given speech act in accordance with a variety of registers and contexts (in particular formal vs. informal contexts)?

Participants

The participants in this case study were three 19-year-old Spanish university undergraduates, two females and a male, in their second year of the English Studies Degree at the University of Granada (Spain). All three had a B2 level of English competence according to the Common European Framework of Reference, had only spent between 3 and 6 weeks in an English speaking country, and were enrolled in a compulsory course focused on improving

students' speaking skills. As to their course grades, at the end of the semester previous to our study the first female student, whom we will henceforth refer to as Subject 1 (S1), had scored 85%, the male student (Subject 2, or S2) had scored 78%, while the mark scored by the second female participant (S3) was 89%. These three participants were randomly chosen from the ones who volunteered to participate in the study, out of the total of 35 students who were attending the course.

METHOD

To answer our research questions, we conducted an exploratory case study, with a pre-test/post-test methodology. The target set for the teaching intervention, as already said, was to improve students' ability when performing the macro speech act "arguing" in both formal and informal contexts. This macro speech act includes more specific functions like exchanging ideas and opinions, showing (dis)agreement, or persuading.

Both the pre-test and the post-test consisted of a semi-structured oral interview carried out with each participant individually, while the researcher recorded the session and took notes of the language resources (in this case the set phrases and formulaic expressions) used by the subjects to realize the target speech act. The interview was a two part process: 1) a role play where participants had to persuade the researcher, first in an informal situation and then in a formal one; 2) a reformulation task to test learners' ability to freely recall as many formulaic expressions as possible related to the target functions. Thus, these two tasks allowed us to test the students' competence in a meaning-focused and a form-focused activity respectively. The pre-test was administered one week before the beginning of the teaching intervention, while the post-test took place six days after the last teaching session of the study.

The pedagogical intervention consisted of four 60-minute sessions, taught along two weeks (two sessions per week). In order to implement the intended language awareness approach, a teaching unit consisting of three sets of activities based on three drama clips was designed.

The clips selected for the study were two from the film *The Queen* (2006, directed by Stephen Fears) and one from the series *How I Met your Mother* (Season 4, Episode 13 'Three Days of Snow', 2009). By using these two different works, we ensured access to the two registers tackled in our study, since *The Queen* portrays highly formal British English in the conversations held between the characters Queen Elizabeth II and Tony Blair, along with more familiar exchanges between Tony Blair and his wife, while the interactions between the characters in *How I Met your Mother* are a good model of colloquial American English. Each clip portrays a conversation where our target macro speech act is realized, and where some of the most recurrent expressions to fulfil it appear in the conversations captured, so that students can

observe how native speakers apply the appropriate language according to the specific situation.

For the implementation of the three-step language awareness pedagogy suggested by Pérez Basanta and Rodríguez Martín (2007), the first stage was covered at the start of the intervention, by providing students with a direct, explicit introduction to the notions addressed in the unit. Thus, in the first session they were lectured on the structural features of natural conversation and the determinant role of context and appropriacy in interaction, as well as on the more specific notion of speech acts and formulaic language in natural conversation exchanges.

Then, for the second and third stages of the pedagogical model, a different set of worksheets was created for each drama clip, following a similar pattern: 1) warm up activity, introducing the drama clip and its context; 2) utterance detection, for students to identify relevant expressions that realize the target speech act in the clips with the help of guiding questions; 3) rewording/rephrasing, which allows students to notice and become aware of the range of language resources applicable in different contexts; 4) new vocabulary: students work on new words and multiword units from the clips, sometimes with the help of the transcripts, and with extra emphasis on their register; 5) output activities: role plays, debates, rankings and similar production activities which encourage students to put into practice their conversational skills.

RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

The first table below shows the results obtained in the first activity of the pre-test and post-test, where learners were asked to persuade the interlocutor (Table 2).

Table 2
Pre-test and Post-test Results from Task 1

Subject	Pre-test		Post-test	
	Informal situation	Formal situation	Informal situation	Formal situation
S1	You should / shouldn't... Maybe I would... I think that...	I think it is a very good idea if...	It could be interesting if you... It would be great that you... Why don't you...?	Excuse me, I'd like to suggest... In my view, the best option for you is... Perhaps you may want to consider that...

S2	I must tell you... You should think about... You have to think about...	It is also possible to... I think it is a good idea since...	I've had a great idea It could be good if... It would be great if you... I don't think you should...	You may think about... It would be nice if you...
S3	I don't think that you should... What you should do is... You should / shouldn't...	I think that... (x3) If we consider that... Try to consider that...	It may be good that you... What I'd do if I was you is... What if you...?	I've been considering the possibility that... It may be relevant that... You may find it interesting... It could be the case that...

As regards our first research question, and comparing the results from the pre-test and the post-test, we can observe that, in general, the learners increased their repertoire of formulaic expressions after the teaching intervention. Thus, while the expression “I (don't) think” was used seven times in the pre-test to introduce a suggestion, the three subjects avoided it in the post-test, with only one exception: “I don't think...” (S2). A similar phenomenon can be observed in relation to modal verbs. In the pre-test there is a clear overuse of the verb “should” (7 occurrences), which, interestingly, is not used by any subject in the post-test. In detriment of it, the participants chose different modal verbs such as “would”, “could”, or “may”, showing an increase in the variety of language resources at their disposal when involved in a meaning-focused task.

As to the second research question, related to subjects' ability to adapt their language to the appropriate register, in the pre-test, subjects do not seem to make any substantial change in the utterances they use in the two different situations given (perhaps with the exception of S3, who chooses “if we consider that...” and “try to consider it” as an attempt to soften her speech). In contrast, in the post-test all subjects made an effort to adapt their language to the appropriate register, and obvious attempts to use a more formal type of language can be observed in utterances including markers of politeness such as “Excuse me, I'd like to suggest...” (S1), or more formal vocabulary as in “it may be relevant that...” (S3). These features, together with the aforementioned use of modal verbs like “may”, represent new skills that contribute to soften

learners' utterances and add politeness to their turns. In our view, this may suggest that the teaching intervention was effective in raising learners' awareness of the pragmatic features that govern natural conversation. Table 3 Reports the Results from the Second Task of the Pre- and Post-Tests.

Table 3
Pre- and Post-test's Results from Task 2

Subject	Pre-test	Post-test
Task 2a: Show disagreement		
S1	I must disagree I don't think so you are not right I don't think you are right I think you are wrong	maybe you are not right in my opinion... if I may speak... I may be wrong, but I feel that... I reckon not. I see your point, but...
S2	I don't think... I disagree with that I don't think so	Sorry, but I disagree I may be wrong, but... I strongly disagree we don't share the same point of view
S3	I disagree with you I think the opposite I don't think the same	I disagree I am not of your/the same opinion you are right, but... I have a different opinion you are not completely right are you sure? because... excuse me for insisting on... of course not!
Task 2b: Show agreement		
S1	I agree with you I believe you are right	I agree with you that's absolutely right I couldn't agree more in my opinion it is a good/great idea I support your opinion
S2	I agree I like that of course	why not? I certainly agree with you I think that's great

S3	of course what you said is right I agree you are right excellent idea!	of course I agree right / you are right I totally agree with you I think the same I am of the same opinion I share your opinion / point of view I couldn't agree more
Task 2c: Ask for further information or an explanation		
S1	what's the matter? what's the point? what's the main problem? what are you trying to do/say? what are you going to do to solve it?	may I ask you something? the/my question would be... I would like to ask... excuse me, but I don't think I'm understanding...
S2	what happened next? can you tell me more about that?	can you tell me what happened? could you explain yourself? what do you think? are you saying that...? do you mean that...?
S3	sorry, I didn't manage to understand can you repeat? I didn't understand your point... I don't understand the point you're making	could you repeat, please? could you give me further information? I would like to know more details I didn't get what you just said I didn't understand you point of view do you mean...?

The comparison between the pre-test and post-test data seems quite revealing in the second task too. This task asked learners to produce as many formal and informal formulaic expressions as they could think of to fulfil the functions given, focusing thus their attention on forms. At first sight we can observe that the amount of alternative expressions clearly increased in all subjects' post-test performance. Moreover, looking closely to each participant, some particular conclusions can be drawn.

In the first part (2a), S1 seems to be less blunt in the post-test than she was in the pre-test. She also seems to avoid the verb "to think", as students had

done in one of the activities practised in class. The second part of the task (2b) shows an increase in the alternatives she provided to express agreement, using more elaborate formulaic expressions than the ones used in the pre-test as well. As to the last part (2c), she uses the same kind of structures in all the sentences in the pre-test (e.g. “what’s the point/matter” or “what are you...”), while the post-test presents a wider set of structures as well as signs of discourse politeness through the use of formulae such as “excuse me” or “may I...?”

S2 clearly uses more complex sentences in all sections of task 2. Furthermore, in the first and second parts he adds some adverbs (“certainly”, “strongly”) that emphasize or reinforce the function of the sentence. Moreover, although basic items like “agree” or “disagree” are still present, S2 finds less direct ways of expressing agreement and disagreement, for instance through the use of rhetorical questions (e.g. “why not?”) or discourse hedges such as “Sorry, but...” or “I may be wrong but...”. With respect to the third section of the test, S2 seems to be better prepared to negotiate meaning in the post-test with questions such as “are you saying...?” and “do you mean...?”, while in the pre-test only direct questions asking for information came to his mind.

As to S3, a clear difference between her pre-test and post-test performance is observed even at first sight, particularly in the number of alternatives she provides. There are only three sentences in 2a of the pre-test, in which “disagree” and “think” are the only verbs used, while she uses seven different ways of expressing disagreement in the post-test. Although in 3b the difference is not so evident given that the sentences used in the pre-test are more complex than in 3a, the results from the post-test still show certain features that make the difference, such as the use of an adverb (“totally”) to stress the meaning, or the set phrase “I couldn’t agree more”, that adds naturalness to her speech. In the last part of the test (2c), S3 repeats the same pattern in the three negative utterances provided in her pre-test, while in the post-test she uses more varied structures, adding also modal verbs (e.g. “could”, “would like”) and markers of politeness (“please”).

CONCLUSIONS

This small-scale pilot study intended to test the extent to which the implementation of a language awareness methodology using drama clips may be effective to improve L2 conversational skills. In particular, our first research question asked whether this methodology increases L2 students’ linguistic resources to realize a given speech act (mainly as regards the amount of formulaic expressions). The results obtained suggest that this seems to be indeed the case. In particular, the number of formulaic expressions which subjects provided in the post-test was notably higher than the alternatives they uttered in the pre-test in both a meaning-focused and a form-focused task.

Concerning the second research question, the comparison of results

from our tests indicates an improvement of the subjects' resources to realize the macro speech act "arguing" in formal and informal contexts. This is so not only from the quantitative point of view (i.e. number of options provided to perform the speech act) but also from a qualitative perspective. In this respect, the utterances produced after the teaching instruction were more elaborate both from a lexical and grammatical point of view, and showed a greater sensitivity towards the subtleties that language must portray to adapt our speech to the given context.

All in all, we can conclude that, in view of the results obtained in this preliminary study, the implementation of a language awareness methodology through the use of drama clips would seem to have positive effects for the development of L2 speakers' conversational skills. This is particularly the case not only with respect to their ability to realize specific speech acts in different contexts through a wider variety of constructions but, beyond that, to their awareness of the very nature of conversational exchanges and the development of their autonomy to notice key features which they need to add to their own language repertoire in order to improve their L2 competence.

Drawing on the promising data obtained in this pilot study, and aware that the small number of subjects and the relatively short time devoted to the teaching intervention impose obvious constraints for the generalization of our results, future research studies are being planned to overcome these limitations, with the purpose of conducting statistical analyses that may provide us with more robust findings. Finally, the present study focused on speech acts, which is the first point specified by Pérez Basanta and Rodríguez Martín (2007) in their framework of features and strategies of conversation. The measurement of the impact of this methodology focusing on other conversational features may also be of interest as the topic for future studies.

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ONLINE COMMUNITIES FOR ENGLISH LANGUAGE TEACHING AND LEARNING: PRE-SERVICE TEACHERS' EXPERIENCES IN THE VIRTUAL WORLD OF SECOND LIFE

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Abstract

New technology facilitates breaking traditional educational patterns so educators can teach and innovate in the language classroom. Online and blended education have also revolutionised language teacher education, as it can be included in both initial teacher education and professional development courses supporting teaching and learning techniques. This book chapter examines how an online community within the Virtual World of Second Life supported pre-service teachers' learning for one academic semester. The study took a qualitative stance using interviews and inductive analysis as its methodology. The use of this virtual community not only facilitated the participants' language learning but also their teaching skills. This experience raised participants' awareness of the benefits of using technology as development resource.

Keywords: online teaching and learning, online community development, professional development, pre-service teachers, Second Life

Resumen

Las nuevas tecnologías facilitan romper patrones educacionales tradicionales para que los educadores puedan innovar y enseñar en la clase de idiomas. Metodologías en línea y “combinadas” también han revolucionado la formación de profesores de idiomas ya que pueden ser incluidas en formación inicial de profesores y cursos de perfeccionamiento para apoyar técnicas de enseñanza-aprendizaje. Este capítulo examina el uso de una comunidad en línea desarrollada dentro de la plataforma Second Life para apoyar la formación inicial de profesores durante un semestre académico. El estudio tuvo un enfoque cualitativo que incluyó el análisis de entrevistas. El uso de la comunidad virtual no solo facilitó el aprendizaje de la lengua inglesa, sino que también ayudó a mejorar las competencias pedagógicas de los participantes.

Palabras clave: aprendizaje y enseñanza en línea, desarrollo de comunidades en línea, desarrollo profesional, profesores en formación, Second Life

INTRODUCTION

The use of online learning environments has had vast acceptance amongst educators in different educational contexts with a plethora of studies which have explored how technology influences and (re)shapes pedagogical approaches (Salmon, 2011; de Freitas, Morgan, & Gibson, 2015; Limperos, Buckner, Kaufmann, & Frisby, 2015; Samaniego Villarroel, 2016). The use of online spaces, such as virtual reality, has changed the way in which individuals interact with others to teach and learn with claims stating that online settings have a pivotal role to enhance language learning and teacher education (Borko, 2004; O’Connell & Groom, 2010). In this sense, members of a community can engage in reflection and co-construct knowledge at any time from different places, opening access to a rich learning experience.

Similarly, teaching methodologies have faced numerous adjustments triggered by the development of internet-based technology resulting in pedagogical approaches being reshaped (Henderson, Selwyn, & Aston, 2017). However, and despite the use of technological tools in educational contexts, there is a necessity to further explore individuals’ perceptions towards the inclusion of technology assisted learning in order to improve its implementation at classroom level (Venkatesh, Croteau, & Rabah, 2014).

Bearing this in mind, a semi-structured interview-based study was conducted which included inductive analysis of written logs kept by the participants. The study implemented by the main author of this chapter aimed at examining pre-service teachers’ perceptions about online virtual communities for language learning and training. This book chapter, therefore, looks into

the views of pre-service teachers who took part in a learning experience using the virtual world Second Life and how they further developed their language and teaching skills in such context. Firstly, we review the literature related to the use of online communities in teacher education. Secondly, we explain how communities of inquiry (COI) (Garrison, Anderson, & Archer, 2000) can create a support network to ameliorate pre-service teachers' learning practices and development. After that, we discuss the theoretical lenses which were used to guide the study. Then, we present the methodological framework. Subsequently, we elaborate on the results which derived from data analysis. Finally, we state conclusions and suggest pedagogical implications of the use of virtual communities for pre-service teachers' learning and professional development.

LITERATURE REVIEW

Online communities for language teacher education

With the beginning of distance education, bodily proximity has been a focal element for academics and educators (McKerlich & Anderson, 2007). The current digital era allows people from around the globe to access information and virtually gather in groups that have a common interest. For instance, online communities, which are virtual spaces where people are in constant interaction to exchange their opinions and views (Shea, 2006) are present informally, via social media, and formally through online courses. For instance, social networks resources such as Facebook or Twitter can be used to promote learning and development. Carpenter and Krutka (2015, p. 29) explain that 'social media is generally characterized by digital platforms where users can create, share, and interact with each other in online collaborative spaces'. A clear example of a social network used as an online community of practice for language teacher education is Twitter (Rosell-Aguilar, 2018). In this study, a group of language teachers discussed their perceptions about using Twitter for professional development purposes. The results suggest that the teachers felt supported by the community as they had their colleagues in the community to turn to when facing difficulties in the classroom. An innovation in Rosell-Aguilar's study is that Twitter itself served as a data collection tool to gather users' views via direct messaging. Social media can provide easy access to collaborative contexts for teachers to interact and reflect, thus when used for teacher development courses, designers should consider factors such as privacy, purpose and netiquette.

The goal of users engaging in online communities is not only to share similar thoughts but also to negotiate meaning collaboratively to learn about a specific topic. In this sense, such collaborations can be totally online as in virtual courses such as MOOCs (Massive Online Open Courses) or blended in, for example, higher education courses that include face-to-face lesson time as well as online work. Regardless of the format that online interactions take in

educational contexts, it is essential to know how online virtual communities can support pre-service and in-service teachers' language learning and professional development. This information will serve as evidence that can support online course designers and tutors to improve their practices for the benefit of the members of the community.

When it comes to educational development, virtual reality worlds such as Second Life (SL) have also taken a lead in permitting the transformation of teaching and learning processes (Duncan, Miller, & Jiang, 2012). This is due to the sense of total immersion and the possibility to (re)create realistic learning settings which are intrinsically engaging promoting the creation of new knowledge (Keser & Özcan, 2011). These graphically enhanced virtual environments promote active learning workspaces which are student-centred with abundant dialogic interactions (Johnson, Adams Becker, Estrada, & Freeman, 2015). It is because of these features that virtual environments are ideal places to promote student engagement within a community (Imlawi & Gregg, 2014).

When learners interact with one another in online communities they have the possibility to adopt different roles to accomplish specific tasks. This results in enhanced students' engagement with the content as well as having the flexibility to advance at their own learning speed when suitable for them (Capanni & Doolan, 2011). Online communities allow educators who are looking for new methodologies to interact, learn and share knowledge with peers who are located in geographically remote areas (Macià & García, 2016). Researchers have suggested that a meaningful educational experience which includes Computer Mediated Communication (CMC) lies at the centre of a community of inquiry (COI) model where teachers and students have a critical role in the educational process (Garrison & Vaughan, 2008).

The community of inquiry (COI)

The Community of Inquiry Model (COI) is an online learning framework which considers that the learning process is the result of the interrelation between three essential elements, namely, social, cognitive, and teaching presence (Garrison & Vaughan, 2008). Each of these components has a substantial influence on the others setting the guidelines for the framework to regulate the teaching and learning interaction (McKerlich, Riis, Anderson, & Eastman, 2011).

Social presence

The core of the social presence component includes the constant use of dialogic interactions which help establish communication with peers resulting in the creation of a sense of bonding and trust (Garrison & Vaughan, 2008). Social presence also assists individuals in projecting their real identity in an

online environment (McKerlich et al., 2011). Social interactions provide the unifying element which supports focus and personal contributions towards the intrinsically collaborative community system (Garrison & Vaughan, 2008). However, social relationships per se do not help students to focus on and construct academic interest. Learning processes require purposeful engagement and discussion which help participants to analytically reflect on, construct, and confirm understanding. This reflective process is known as cognitive presence.

Cognitive presence

The cognitive presence component of the COI outlines the regular inquiry sequence of learning experientially based on reflection and the development of concepts (Garrison & Vaughan, 2008). Cognitive presence involves the learner's capacity to build and validate new knowledge by using discourse within the COI model (McKerlich et al., 2011). Further, cognitive presence is a recurrent process which includes phases of confusion, elaboration and connection of ideas, as well as experimenting with possible solutions (Garrison & Vaughan, 2008). All in all, the creation of ideas and possible solutions have to be supported logically, hence a community of inquiry is fundamental to create and maintain cognitive presence.

Teaching presence

This component contributes with essential elements that “provide structure, facilitation, and direction for the cohesion, balance, and progression of the inquiry process” (Garrison & Vaughan, 2008, p. 24). Teaching presence within the COI model is related to the teacher's direct or indirect control on the plan, management, and learning assistance to guarantee a relevant instructional experience in the online environment (McKerlich et al., 2011). Furthermore, teaching presence is a vital and demanding task particularly in a blended learning experience where students are not always physically present and are constantly moving between online interactions and face-to-face communication (Garrison & Vaughan, 2008). Akin to social constructivist views of learning, teaching presence also requires the presence of an older more experienced person or student who influences and facilitates a significant educational experience (McKerlich et al., 2011). It is the COI model itself which shares commonalities with social-constructivist views where learning is the result of the interaction amongst individuals who take responsibility for their own and that of their classmates' learning. A social-constructivist environment helps create a suitable atmosphere for students to build new knowledge, explore and express themselves by using dialogic interactions which include self-explanations and explanations to others which result in enhanced cognitive development (Thanh, 2014).

Theoretical lenses

The theories used to frame this study include social-constructivism (Vygotsky, 1978) and the concept of cooperative learning (Johnson, Johnson, & Holubec, 1998). The combined use of these helped create a thorough picture of how individuals collaborate to learn. These views are linked to the COI as they promote reflection and interaction for individual and social learning.

Social Constructivism

In the same vein as the COI framework (Garrison & Vaughan, 2008) fosters the construction of social knowledge, Vygotsky's social constructivist theory suggests that intellectual advancement is the result of interacting with others (Diaz, Neal, & Amaya-Williams, 1990). In Vygotsky's theory, learning tools that include symbol systems such as numbers, technology and language allow society members to solve problems, construct new knowledge and interact (McInerney & McInerney, 2010). Also, discussions and interactions enabled by language use in social learning environments enhance cognitive development (Thanh, 2014). Vygotsky asserted that the cultural context has a direct influence on an individuals' cognitive development. A group's cultural development is closely linked to its individuals' continuous cognitive activity which has an impact on individuals' growth and development as members of that particular group. Therefore, for Vygotsky, the development of intellect is not only related to an improvement of the individual's mental capacities, but also to the development of the individual's cultural understandings. The individual becomes part of the social context and, the social context becomes part of the individual in a constant exchange of knowledge (McInerney & McInerney, 2010). According to Vygotsky, (1978), learning in social contexts derives in the notion of the zone of proximal development (ZPD). This is defined as "the distance between the actual development level as determined by independent problem solving and the level of potential development as determined through problem solving under adult guidance or in collaboration with more capable peers" (Vygotsky, p. 86). The assistance of a more capable peer involves a "scaffolding" process which allows individuals to solve problems and complete tasks that would be, otherwise, impossible to complete by themselves. Scaffolding is a pivotal element in the concept of cognitive apprenticeship with learners becoming gradually more responsible in solving problems with the structured guidance of a more capable individual (Reiser, 2004). It has been claimed that scaffolding can be supplied not only by humans, but also animated teachers, computer tutors and technology mediated environments (Azevedo & Hadwin, 2005). In this sense, Vygotsky's views are linked to the COI foundations, as cognitive and social presence foster scaffolding for learning. Similarly, cooperative group work

allows participants to maximise responsibility for their own learning and their peers' (D. Johnson, Johnson, & Smith, 1998). The social cooperation concept is also based on Vygotsky's social constructivist ideas for learning as social structure, language and higher order thinking processes are developed. In and educational context, cooperation is understood as the instructional use of small groups to boost students' work to improve their own and each other's learning (Johnson, Johnson, & Holubec, 1998). Cooperative learning improves students' self-esteem providing a safe learning where classroom outcomes are improved (Jenkins, Antil, Wayne, & Vadasy, 2003).

With the Community of Inquiry (COI) at the core of an online learning experience, technology has clear potential to develop not only foreign language skills but also intercultural awareness (O'Dowd, 2015). Increased language opportunities may be the result of Computer Mediated Communication contributing to alleviate face-to-face classroom restrictions and discourse teacher's control (Cho, 2016). Also, technology represents an opportunity for teachers to become aware of the affordances of digital resources not only for language teaching but for professional development. Particularly, in an era where technology is constantly evolving, teachers have to be prepared to apply technology in a sustainable manner (Godwin-Jones, 2015).

METHODOLOGY

The research question that led this study was: *How do pre-service teachers perceive online communities for language learning and professional development?* This question was answered by analysing the learning experience of pre-service teachers of English from an English Teaching programme in Chile who participated in an online community implemented using the virtual world Second Life. As members of the online community, participants engaged in varied activities which included WebQuests, group discussions and virtual excursions. All of these led to the elaboration and construction of new knowledge with peers. The study took a qualitative approach for data collection. Interviews were conducted to gather data regarding how the pre-service teachers constructed knowledge in an online learning environment. Individual interviews were held as they are a great way to collect data since they enable researchers to understand "the lived experience of other people and the meaning they make of that experience" (Seidman, 2006, p. 6). Before interviews were conducted, ethical approval from university authorities was sought after and granted. Also, a pseudonym was given to participants to protect their privacy. Besides the use of interviews, written logs were also kept by the students. However, data obtained from those instruments will not be included in this chapter.

Purposeful sampling was used to identify the participants who would provide data about their learning process in the online environment. It has

been stated that purposeful sampling is useful to understand a central phenomenon in a thorough way (Creswell, 2012). This study included 10 participants who voluntarily decided to participate in the study. All participants were interviewed three times (at the beginning, during and after) using semi-structured interviews which were conducted throughout one academic semester. The information contained in their interviews allowed the authors to gain insights into the whole process of learning online.

The semi-structured interviews were audiotaped for later transcription and inductive thematic analysis was applied. Information obtained from the interviews was analysed by the main author of this chapter. By using Nvivo 9 ® software, it was possible to identify recurring themes and ideas which created a holistic view of what learning online entails. This examination helped us to critically understand the way in which communities are formed and how they contribute to foster pre-service teachers' learning.

RESULTS

The findings from this study suggest that the use of an online virtual community for learning and professional development was highly welcomed and accepted amongst the pre-service teachers. This was demonstrated in the participants' comments regarding the use of online environments to share knowledge and develop teacher training. Further, participants' perception towards the creation of an online virtual community and group work for language learning had a strong influence and effects on their motivation, socialisation and achievement. In one of the interviews, a participant stated the following:

"I think it [online environment] has been very useful in terms of learning, learning how to learn, and learn better in terms of using online resources and sharing with your classmates. While interacting with peers I have learnt lots of new words and I feel my language skills have really improved. This type of environment can definitely help create a nice place to work in"

This claim aligns with what has been stated by Blas and Paolini (2014) who have asserted that online group work promotes higher achievement than individual work. Additionally, the participant's observation in relation to the "nice" environment that can be created online, goes in the same line as Weiss's (2000) statement that a positive affective environment has an encouraging learning influence. Group work within an online virtual community also resulted in an increased sense of perseverance and interest in working to reach the group's objectives as well as their own as stated in this comment:

"I think learning in an online virtual community has been very productive because as a group we feel responsible for everybody's learning. It is strange

but despite we are not physically present, I personally feel responsible for my learning and that of my peers. I have also felt that my language proficiency has improved as I have had to keep pace with more advanced language learners that I am working with”

The participant’s comment is in line with previous research which suggests that working cooperatively in online groups results in improved psychological health which is materialised by changing a person’s willingness to work with others experiencing rewarding relationship building (Johnson & Johnson, 2003, 2011). The enhanced sense of presence that participants can experience in an online virtual community also accounts for increased dialogic interactions which foster learning experiences of different types. This comment agrees with social constructivist approaches in which new knowledge is generated as the result of social interaction and shared efforts (Venkatesh et al., 2014).

Based on data contained in the interviews, participants also expressed their increased interest to use this type of medium in their future professional practices as stated in this comment:

“I feel that this type of environment lends itself for one to learn as there are no limits to the kind of information you have access to. Also, the sense of community I have developed is incredible, I really feel I am part of a group! Learning about new topics in this kind of setting is also fantastic and I will definitely use this with my future students when I start teaching”

This comment denotes that using an alternative methodology for learning can have an impact in individuals who feel like replicating and sharing the experience with others. The sense of belonging to a group can have lasting learning effects on users which correlates with the also increased sense of group belonging (Rovai, 2002).

Another interesting result of this study was related to the fact that participants considered the use of an online virtual community as an effective way to generate knowledge with the medium being an encouraging element which boosted their self-esteem as stated by one participant:

“from all the language learning experiences that I have had, this is the first time in which I feel very confident about myself and I dare to express my opinion. Sometimes, I am a bit shy to speak up, but this type of environment makes me feel very safe”

It has been stated that online virtual communities cater for those individuals who may feel threatened by peers’ criticism or are inherently shy in real settings (McKerlich et al., 2011). Correspondingly, the risk-free environment created resulted in this constructive “disinhibition” to prosper as it has been stated by Adamus, Nattland, and Schlenker (2014) in a similar experi-

ence. Based on the study presented in this chapter, it is apparent that online virtual communities open new avenues not only for language learning but also self-improvement from a personal and professional point of view.

CONCLUSIONS AND PEDAGOGICAL IMPLICATIONS

Study results suggest that online virtual communities for language learning and professional improvement are a useful tool which can be utilised in varied contexts. The positive reception in the use of an online virtual community for language learning and professional development on the part of the participants denotes that the use of such medium is an effective way to enhance learning within a technology mediated context. In addition, using an online virtual community under a social-constructivist approach for learning, showed to be an effective approach to boost not only these participants' learning but also their development of social skills for group work. Participants' positive view in learning in the company of others, agrees with researchers' suggestions that there is increased group achievement, well-being, and interpersonal relationships (Jolliffe, 2015). The affordances that online virtual communities have to foster learning outcomes may be related to the fact that participants in such environments are not hindered by physical constraints such as shyness or personal impairment that may be experienced in real settings. This was reflected on by participants in the interviews being in the same tenor as what has been stated by Dickey (2007) who highlighted the fact that the process of "disembodiment" experienced by online participants generally results in increased self-esteem optimising academic achievement.

The pedagogical implications in the use of online virtual communities are varied. Firstly, there is the possibility of accessing academic contents regardless of geographical and physical constraints. Nowadays' widespread access to technology that has been experienced at a global level, makes it easier for people to access online courses and increase their professional development. Also, the use of ubiquitous mobile technology (present in high-end smartphone devices) contributes to create an ideal environment for online virtual communities to flourish. Also, the possibility for participants to access content in their own time, is an added value of these online communities as there is written record of the exchange of opinions and materials being discussed by the group. Being able to review that content as many times as necessary to reinforce specific knowledge, does indeed emphasise the fact that learning can take place anywhere at any given time. Finally, the horizontal establishment of a sense of power which usually takes place in these environments, enhances participants' willingness to contribute to the group as the types of communities which are created are usually inclusive and welcoming of all contributions.

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SECTION 2:

REFLECTION REPORTS

REFLECTING ON THE ROLE OF INSTRUCTIONS, MODELLING AND VISUALS ON YOUNG LEARNERS' COMPREHENSION

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Abstract

It is undeniable that to expose young learners to English language input at an early age will bring them cognitive and social benefits that will last over their school years and future professional life, hence the reasons of why their learning of this language should not be taken for granted. Teachers have to create the classroom conditions to facilitate young learners' language learning. One aspect that plays a key role when teaching English to young learners is the delivery of comprehensible instructions followed by modelling. This paper reflects on how instructions can benefit young learners' language learning when they are followed by modelling and accompanied by visuals that can help learners to process language more efficiently.

Keywords: instructions, modelling, visuals, young learners

Resumen

Es innegable que exponer a los niños y niñas al aprendizaje del inglés en una edad temprana trae consigo beneficios cognitivos y sociales que perdurarán en la escolaridad y en la futura vida profesional, por lo tanto, he ahí la razón

de que el aprendizaje de este idioma no debe darse por hecho. El profesorado debe generar las condiciones en el aula que faciliten el aprendizaje por parte de los niños y niñas. Un aspecto que tiene un papel fundamental cuando se enseña inglés a niños y niñas es la entrega de instrucciones claras seguidas por el modelamiento. Este artículo presenta una reflexión sobre la forma como las instrucciones pueden beneficiar el aprendizaje de niños y niñas cuando se acompañan de modelamiento y elementos visuales que puedan ayudar a los educandos a procesar el idioma de manera más eficiente.

Palabras clave: instrucciones, modelamiento, elementos visuales, estudiantes jóvenes

INTRODUCTION

When it comes to teaching English to young learners, it is crucial to understand their cognitive development to expose them to tasks that they can really tackle in a classroom context that fosters English learning. Having an appropriate classroom environment is certainly one of the hundreds' teacher's tasks; however, it is perhaps the number one activity that can help young learners feel safe to start producing the language. Since young learners neither read nor write well at this level, it is essential to work on delivering instructions that can really support their language learning. Besides having instructions that meet certain criteria, they should be supported by strong modelling strategies on the part of the teacher and solid visual aid support that can facilitate the comprehension and consolidation of instructions. This paper will reflect on this magic triad composed by instructions, modelling and visuals when they are used to teach English to young learners.

CLEAR INSTRUCTIONS, MODELLING AND VISUAL AIDS

Not only it is important to teach English, but also the way the language is taught deserves attention. For Rixon (1999), the conditions under which young learners' programs are offered are more important than their optimal age. The way the language is taught to young learners plays an essential role. Teachers must take into account children's cognitive development and what they are capable of at an early age (3-5, for example). Linse (2005) points out that "teachers of young learners have two jobs: to provide care and to provide clear and understandable instructions. In order to provide the best possible instruction, you need to adjust educational experiences to meet the developmental stages of the individual child" (p. 2).

Explanations and how they are provided have a key role when it comes

to teaching young learners. Harmer (2007) states that “the best activity in the world is a waste of time if the students do not understand what it is they are supposed to do” (p. 37). One particular kind of explanation is instructions, which according to Ur are defined as “the directions that are given to introduce a learning task that entails some measure of independent student activity” (Ur, 1991, p. 16). Considering that young learners have a limited attention span (Nunan, 2010), it is important that instructions do not become overwhelming for children. To consider what kind and number of instructions a teacher will give to his/her learners is key. Nunan (2010) states, for instance, that “to introduce formal grammar makes little sense at the piagetian pre-operational stage” (p. 8), for children cannot analyze language yet. On the contrary, he mentions what a child can do at these early stages of learning, that is to say:

- Follows one-step instructions
- Follows two-step instructions
- Follows three-step instructions
- Understands symbolic concepts (e.g., numbers, letters)
- Likes reading or being read to
- Likes playing with words
- Grasps abstract concepts

Young learners need as much input as possible and clear instructions. Ur (1991) “provides a set of guidelines on giving effective explanations and instructions: (i) Prepare (ii) Make sure you have the class’ full attention (iii) Present the information more than once (iv) Be brief (v) Illustrate with examples, and (vi) Give feedback” (pp. 16-17). Given the limited attention span younger learners have, considering these guidelines does help the teaching process, especially if we consider that teacher talk is central in the language class for classroom organization and for the process of acquisition. Besides, teacher talk is seen also as a means for controlling student behavior. Therefore, instructions have to be comprehensible enough as part of the process of language acquisition (Linse, 2005; Liruso & Villanueva de Debat, 2003; Krashen, 1982). Making input and instructions comprehensible for young learners does not guarantee success, for they have also to be varied. Instructions have to be clear, brief and must include the use of visual aids, concept check questions (CCQs) or pre-task demonstrations (Liruso & Villanueva de Debat, 2003).

If we consider that most young learners at this age have no literacy skills (Pinter, 2006), the way teachers give instructions and demonstrate how tasks have to be done can help to carry out successful activities inside the classroom. Dörnyei (2001) points out the importance of tasks being presented in a way that motivates students. He also suggests that task preparation should consider strategies for helping learners to perform the task. Ellis (2002) proposes that a way to get students’ attention on the task is by asking them to observe a model of how to perform it. Coffey (2013) states that task modeling

occurs when the teacher demonstrates a task students will be expected to do on their own. This type of modelling generally comes before science experiments, or, as in our area of interest, foreign language communication. Furthermore, Haston (2007) highlights that “when used appropriately, teacher modelling for student imitation is a useful tool. When used inappropriately, it can be a crutch that actually prevents students from learning” (p. 26). Nonetheless, teaching modelling does not necessarily cater to all learning styles nor it suffices for large numbers inside a classroom, because not all learners will get the whole idea of what is expected from them and the task. It is important that when teachers model, they provide visual, auditory, kinesthetic, and tactile means for illustrating important aspects of the concept, skills or the task (Florida Center for Instructional Technology, n.d.).

Modelling is, undoubtedly, a teaching technique that must not be used once or twice but constantly, especially with younger learners, who need to develop a sense of familiarity. Modelling needs to be adapted as part of the classroom routine. Kang Shin (2006) states that “young learners function well within a structured environment and enjoy repetition of certain routines and activities. Having basic routines in the classroom can help to manage young learners” (p. 5). Thus, establishing a set of routines only brings positive aspects to the classroom if appropriately done. In regard to this point, Touhill (2012) points out that all children need a measure of routine and predictability to their day, for they provide a significant sense of certainty and security. Furthermore, routines do not only help younger learners to have the aforementioned certainty and security but also to implicitly learn English. Musthafa (2010) suggests that “it is a good idea if the teachers can provide useful acquisition promoting routines in English so that—as a collective—children in the classroom can acquire relatively significant amount of functional English simply by being present in the classroom” (p. 123). Based on what he proposes, it could be stated that younger learners may respond better to commands and instructions in English after some time, as they are more accustomed to associating the language with expressions or movements, due to the well-established routines inside the classroom.

Musthafa (2010) also proposes that in order to expose students to English in use—which represents an essential prerequisite for the acquisition of English to happen—teachers should use English all the time, or as much as possible, in the classroom during the instructional sessions. Teachers model the acts of speaking, reading and writing by speaking, reading, and writing themselves while the children try to do so. This functional use of English during the instructional time should be carried out consistently to provide learners with opportunities so that they can see for themselves how English is being used for communicative purposes with their teachers. In this way, “children can observe and participate in the use of English for communicative purposes, and then acquire this language in use as a prototype for later use in other communicative events” (pp. 123-124). Nonetheless, when establishing

routines sometimes teachers must use L1 in order to clarify what is being said or to avoid students' misunderstanding of what is expected from them. Kang Shin (2006) mentions that "if necessary, the use of L1, for instance, is one quick, easy way to make difficult expressions comprehensible or with instructions that can be complicated when explained in L2" (p. 6). The use of L1 in the classroom should be seen as a resource for forwarding the learning process without becoming too reliant on it.

In regard to materials and resources, a certain sense of routine should exist, therefore, certainty and familiarity. Touhill (2012) also points out that if we continually change the materials, experiences and resources that children play with, then we risk short-changing children's experience. While some change is important to maintain children's interest and introduce new ideas, "change for the sake of change reduces the chances children have to re-engage with and master materials and ideas. Children will benefit more from deep involvement with a few well-chosen experiences than from superficial involvement with many" (p. 2). Consequently, it would be suitable to consider all these aspects when designing and planning experiences, materials and resources in order to increase the possibilities of students learning, as well as to improve the quality of teaching and the learning experience. For instance, if a teacher were to use visual aids as part of his or her routine, it is important that these aids have a consistency that enriches routines and students' mastery with them.

It makes sense that teachers, especially with younger learners, use a varied set of visual material and resources for their lessons in order to enrich the learning experience of this so called digital generation. For instance, when teaching vocabulary to these children, it is essential that teachers use visual aids, because as Milton (2009) states, pictures are easily remembered, in comparison to words, for they activate the image-to-word referential connection. Considering that EFL young learners of this age are just being exposed to the language, it is logical to be aware of the fact that they do not understand English as they understand their mother tongue. Thus, some experiences inside the classroom may become more difficult for them as learners and therefore for the teachers as well. Since younger learners have no literacy skills (Nunan, 2010), books and other written material have no real use in the lessons. On the contrary, these visual-spatial learners will learn better when being exposed to audiovisual materials, for they are more realistic to their daily lives. As Daniel (2013) points out, the main purposes of teaching with the use of audiovisual aids are:

- "They help to avoid excessive, empty and meaningless verbalization in teaching English.
- They provide direct sense experience to students.
- They help students to form clear and accurate concepts in English.
- They make teaching and learning effective.

- They provide variety to teaching.
- They provide interest and inspiration.
- They create language atmosphere.
- They reduce teachers talking.
- They clarify the subject-matter.
- They save time and energy” (p. 3811).

As Nation and Newton (2009) state, using visuals in the classroom will help with the natural associations of images and words. Furthermore, visual aids *per se* benefit students, thus younger learners, because “when integrated into the lesson plan through media, they attract students’ attention to the topic presented in the class, enhance and facilitate comprehension of grammar and language, increase students’ motivation, as well as help students to memorize the new vocabulary and structures” (p. 5). Nonetheless, when integrating the audio and visuals, the benefits in the classroom are more. For instance, if images on their own can help learners to facilitate comprehension of vocabulary, concepts or actions, the inclusion of audio (in English) along with images (with or without motion) will help children to clarify or understand what is being shown and said. Besides, audiovisual aids do not only cater to the visual-spatial learning style but also the auditory (Ciara, 2016; Curtain & Dahlberg, 2010; Pinter, 2006). However, audiovisual aids (seen as teaching aids) must be used carefully in the classroom. Ciara (2016) also points out that teacher must not rely too much on them or be used in a thoughtless manner. On the contrary, they have to serve the classroom and curriculum objectives.

CONCLUSIONS AND PEDAGOGICAL IMPLICATIONS

In brief, young learners can benefit significantly when learning English if they are exposed to a combination of clear instructions, effective modelling and high quality visuals that can prepare them for learning to take place. This triad can certainly have an impact on young learners’ autonomy. Learners need to start being more autonomous in order to take the first steps into a new stage in their learning development. Young learners should get used to classroom routines in which they have the main responsibility of their learning, by experiencing, understanding and building their own knowledge about the language, and their learning.

Additionally, students can benefit both cognitively and socially. From the point of view of cognition, audio-visual materials help them understand what otherwise would be more difficult to comprehend. From the social perspective, the triad instructions, modelling and audiovisuals is an opportunity for young learners to work collaboratively. For example, if after having delivered the instructions and modelling together with the help of audio-visual material a student still does not understand the task, then peers, using their own

language, can help him/her to grasp what the student is intended to do. This permits young learners to develop their social skills. This teaching belief could result in a fruitful learning practice not only in the English lesson, but in their future school grades.

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ISSUES IN TEACHING ENGLISH PRONUNCIATION TO PRE-SERVICE TEACHERS IN CHILE

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Abstract

This chapter aims to deal with some key issues in the field of English pronunciation teaching, especially in Chile. It intends to discuss some essential elements which pronunciation teachers should consider in their own practice, as they should serve to establish the tenets of important decision-making processes in terms of an English pronunciation curriculum. Thus, we shall focus on some crucial factors such as models in pronunciation teaching, goals in pronunciation teaching, identity and accent, pronunciation assessment, teacher training and confidence in teaching pronunciation.

Keywords: pronunciation model, pronunciation goals, identity, accent and pronunciation assessment

Resumen

Este capítulo pretende abordar los aspectos más importantes en el área de la enseñanza de la pronunciación del idioma inglés, especialmente en Chile. La discusión se centrará en los elementos esenciales que el profesor de pronunciación debe considerar en su propio ejercicio, pues son ellos los que defini-

rán los principios involucrados en los diferentes procesos relacionados con la implementación de un currículo de pronunciación del idioma inglés. De este modo, nos concentraremos en factores cruciales como modelos de enseñanza de pronunciación, metas en la enseñanza de pronunciación, identidad y acento; evaluación de la pronunciación, formación de profesores y la confianza del profesor para la enseñanza de la pronunciación.

Palabras clave: modelos de pronunciación, metas de pronunciación, identidad, acento, evaluación de la pronunciación

INTRODUCTION

The great majority of English language learners receive training in all four linguistic skills, and even more so pre-service teachers. Apart from reading, writing, listening and speaking, instruction for this particular group of ESL students also includes grammar, vocabulary and pronunciation, among others; even though the specific contributions these aspects make to the overall speaking skill has not yet been clearly determined (Kang, 2013). Within the scope of the speaking ability, the most noticeable aspect in L₂ speakers is pronunciation (Ma, 2015). While in the past, pronunciation was a central element in methods like audio-lingualism, the advent of 21st century showed the consequences of the lack of attention placed on pronunciation after the emergence of the communicative language teaching approach. Nowadays, however, this aspect of second language proficiency is resurfacing as a major issue, not only in instruction, but also in research and assessment (Thomson, 2018).

In this chapter, we will present a discussion of how pronunciation is being understood in the teaching of English as a foreign language, especially in Chile. We will also delineate ideas into the models of pronunciation available and their validity in relation to the context of implementation. Also, we will analyse the pronunciation goals that are possible to be accomplished according to the models and principles under which pronunciation is being taught. Assessment will also be discussed in terms of the most effective ways to evaluate pronunciation as a major component of any speaking testing system. Lastly, we will present some ideas in relation to issues such as pronunciation and identity and teacher training in pronunciation.

MODELS IN PRONUNCIATION TEACHING

For decades, the models chosen to teach pronunciation at college level in Chile have centered on varieties which are commonly referred to as native speaker's, namely those varieties spoken in England and The United States know as Received Pronunciation and General American, respectively. The

reason for this choice lies in the fact that they have for long been the accents used in dictionaries and coursebooks worldwide, and in the case of RP, it is generally associated to certain elite groups such as the royal family and the British aristocracy, apart from the fact that it is not associated to a particular geographic area and can therefore be found scattered all over the country. As can be seen, the premise so far has been that foreign and second language learners of English are expected to aim at a native speaker accent. But is this possible? The answer to this question is not straightforward. If we think about the people who surround us such as friends, students, colleagues, etc., who speak an L_2 , we can notice that the trend is not pronouncing that L_2 at native speaker level. In other words, we would be able to claim that few of them, or probably none at all, would pass for a native speaker of that language. This is especially true for trainee teachers of English in Chile (Veliz Campos, 2011). Having a foreign accent is, therefore, the rule in most cases. This incapacity of pronouncing an L_2 with a native accent is generally associated to the Critical Period Hypothesis (Vanhove, 2013) which claims that after a certain age, it is not possible to achieve a level of mastery of an L_2 at native speaker level, at least in pronunciation.

However, in a recent work, Flege (2018) puts forward a different proposal. He claims that it is not a critical period that prevents L_2 speakers from attaining native speaker accent. Instead, he proposes that it is the quantity and quality of the input they have been exposed to which plays a crucial role. He suggests that age of arrival (AOA) in an L_2 country, a variable which has been extensively examined in accent attainment research, helps to trigger different types of relationships between L_2 speakers with an early age of arrival and those who have arrived in the L_2 country at an early age. In his work, he makes reference to the case of immigrants and claims that those with an early AOA can benefit from the type of input they receive at school, from friends, etc. On the contrary, those with a later AOA, say after 15 years of age, are deprived from this rich type of input since they have not had the opportunity to have experienced L_2 education in the native speaking community at an earlier stage of their lives.

In the light of the evidence and the teaching experience that suggest that achieving a high level of mastery in terms of L_2 pronunciation, it is necessary to examine the practicality and applicability of the pronunciation models that have been adopted not only in Chile, but also worldwide. Hence, a series of changes could be proposed, but these would first have to consider a number of factors such as the learner's mother tongue and the particular accent within that mother tongue. One possible option is the proposal formulated by Jennifer Jenkins (2000) called the Lingua Franca Core, LFC for short. In her work derived from empirical research, Jenkins proposes a series of features which are essential to preserve intelligibility (core features) and a series of optional features (noncore features). Among the core features mentioned in Jenkin's LFC, the following can be listed:

- All consonant sounds should be preserved, save for /ð/ and /θ/ which can be replaced by /v/ and /f/, correspondingly. An emphasis on consistency of use is placed, though.
- /r/ should be realized as in General American English [ɹ] and should be pronounced every time it appears in spelling. Thus, the LFC is a rhotic variety.
- The phoneme /t/ should be realized as [t] and not as a glottal stop [ʔ] or a tap [ɾ]. Thus, words like “button” should be pronounced [ˈbʌtən] and not [ˈbʌʔn] and “latter” as [ˈlætəɹ] rather than the usual [ˈlæɾə].
- Vowel length should also be preserved. However, vowel quality is not as important. Thus, pair words such as “leave” and “live” should essentially be kept apart by means of producing a length distinction such as [ˈli:v] as opposed to [ˈliv], or [ˈlɪ:v] as opposed to [ˈlɪv], or any other vowel quality as long as the duration of the vowel is what differentiates both phonemes. This feature is a key one for native speakers of Spanish.

A first critique of the LFC is that a good deal of the data is based on information drawn from speakers whose mother tongues are Asian and other European languages and little is said about those who speak Spanish as their L₁, let alone Chilean Spanish.

An attempt to fill this research gap was made by Cutillas (2017) where he carried out a diagnosis of a Madrid Spanish speaker’s production of English considering native speaker (NS) rules (both from Received Pronunciation and General American), LFC features, and others which are not encompassed by the LFC. In his study, the researcher analyzed variables such as vowel quality (F1 and F2 measurements), voice onset time (VOT), consonant segments, lexical stress, nuclear stress, and intonation phrases. In terms of vowel quality, the results revealed that the L₂ speaker used the same vowel quality for all English phonemes /i:/, /ɪ/, and /i/. A similar case occurred with vowels /æ/, /ʌ/, and /ɑ:/. However, a slightly more front quality was found for the vowel /æ/ which the author attributes to possible instruction. As for /ɔ:/ and /ɒ/, these were both produced with a quality equivalent to Spanish /o/ which was also the vowel quality found to be used for English /ɜ:/. The study also revealed the lack of English /ə/ which was systematically replaced by a Spanish vowel quality.

As regards vowel quantity, the researcher reported that there is a consistent length differentiation between /i:/ and the pair /ɪ/ - /i/. The same was found to be true for /ɑ:/ as compared to /æ/ and /ʌ/ and /ɔ:/ as opposed to /ɒ/.

Measurement of VOT indicated that the English L₂ speaker was able to perform aspiration successfully 71,4% of the times.

Concerning consonant segments, some areas of difficulty drawn by the results of this study are:

- The replacement of English /v/ with Spanish /b/.
- /s/ being used in syllable onset rather than /z/ as well as in coda position in the word “is”. The study also showed that devoicing of this segment

did not cause major difficulty in terms of intelligibility.

- One single occasion of /ʃ/ produced as /s/.
- Transfer of place of articulation for nasals, e.g. /ŋ/ realized as /n/ in word-final position, especially in “-ing” endings. Nevertheless, this normally occurs in some NS varieties as well.
- Consonant clusters and consonant elision were found to be in accordance with NS rules in spite of some instances in which NLFC consonant sequences were found e.g. [anim'bartin] for “and inviting”; which the author, rightfully, claims might be misinterpreted as “uninviting”. Some instances of an epenthetic [e] in syllable onset were found in words such as “Spanish” and “speak” which were pronounced as [es'paniʃ] and [es'pi:k] correspondingly.

As to lexical stress, this was properly used in most instances save for only two particular words, namely “perhaps” pronounced as [ˈperhəps] and “friendship” [frenˈʃi:p]. Finally, nuclear accent is generally placed accurately with a few exceptions which the author analyses. However, he then claims that these are unlikely to cause unintelligibility.

So far, we have discussed the most popular ends of the continuum; namely, native speaker models of pronunciation (RP and GA) and the *Lingua Franca Core*. However, we must bear in mind that the discussion and arguments on this issue, the choice of a model accent, has focused on the general learner of English, not on the prospective teacher and in-service EFL teachers in Chile. Concerning this latter point, Nguyen (2017) examined non-native English teachers' engagement with the native speaker model. For this, she worked with eighty-five TESOL teachers (64 females and 21 males) from TESOL Master programs in Australia, New Zealand, the United States, and the United Kingdom as well as forty TESOL teachers from the same type of programs offered by Australian universities in conjunction with Vietnamese institutions. She found that the participants, mostly (92,2%) dissociated themselves from the native speaker model regarding English varieties. She also found that the majority of them do not consider that native speaker teachers are superior to non-native speaker teachers. However, these percentages dropped significantly when it came to being surveyed on teachers' language proficiency. In this regard, the author indicates that as teachers become more knowledgeable in terms of English as an International Language and World Englishes topics, they cease to view native speaker teachers as superior to them. In spite of this, non-native teachers still feel attached to native speaker norms in terms of their language proficiency. Unfortunately, studies of this type, again, come from overseas and reveal what happens in other contexts, not in our Chilean reality. This is evidently an instance to encourage research in this field which will shed light on this matter.

It is interesting to see how the discussion of a pronunciation model has only been a dichotomous issue. Perhaps, a more sound approach, or at least practical, would be to find a collection of native speaker features from

a variety of accents which suit the capabilities of the prospective EFL teacher. For instance; Australian English, as well as Received Pronunciation and General American, makes a distinction between vowels /ʌ/ and /ɑ:/. However, this distinction, in Australian English, is made in terms of quantity only and not in terms of quality (Andreu Nadal, 2016). Therefore, these two segments have been described as having a quality of the type [ɐ] for words like “cut” and [ɛ:] for words like “cart”. Adopting these vowels rather than /ʌ/ and /ɑ:/ would involve an advantage to the Spanish speaking learner for two reasons. On the one hand, they would have to aim to produce only one vowel quality and not two, which has, by the way, commonly been described as a difficulty by these learners. On the other hand, Spanish /a/ is phonetically close to these Australian vowels.

Back to the choice of the model(s) to be adopted as the target accent in in-service as well as pre-service teachers, it is important to bear in mind aspects such as:

- The learner’s mother tongue and its phonetic closeness to the model accent.
- The teacher’s knowledge of English pronunciation and his/her confidence in teaching it.
- The possible difficulties the learner might encounter in attaining the model accent.
- The availability of teaching materials and resources for assessment.
- Of course, these suggestions are in no manner an exhaustive list, but they will certainly be of valuable use when it comes to decision-making in terms of a model accent for teacher training.

GOALS AND ASSESSMENT IN PRONUNCIATION TEACHING

As a result of globalisation, new English varieties have emerged. This new scenario of English language teaching (ELT) in multilingual settings has challenged the language and teaching theory tradition, which regarded English as a “homogeneous language” (Canagarajah, 2013, p. 4). Currently, the speakers of English as a second language have significantly outnumbered the native speakers (NS) in most worldwide communication, a fact that would call the issue of homogeneity into question. Thus, choosing the set of norms, models and goals for L₂ pronunciation teaching has become a major issue (Sewell, 2016; Chan, 2018), primarily, due to the multiplicity of teaching contexts and learning purposes. These contexts and purposes will determine whether the focus goes on intelligibility and comprehensibility (endonormative or multilingual oriented models of pronunciation) or accentedness (nativist oriented models of pronunciation). For its part, accentedness is a judgement of how much one’s speech differs phonologically from the local variety, often measured on a 9-level Likert scale, where 1 means that the speaker has no accent and 9 has

extremely heavy accent. Comprehensibility, on the one hand, is a measure of how easy or difficult it is to understand a speaker's pronunciation (1 very easy to understand, 9 extremely difficult to understand). On the other hand, intelligibility is the degree to which a listener understands a speaker, measured in ways such as transcriptions, comprehension checks or listener summaries. In short, accentedness is difference, comprehensibility is effort and intelligibility is actual understanding (Derwing, 2010). Then, one pronunciation goal could be that the L₂ speakers replicated a native accent, following the nativist principle. Such an approach has been followed for decades in ELT around the world, as well as in Chile, establishing, quite firmly one could argue, that this was the right pronunciation model to follow, despite the unrealistic accomplishment of such a goal. Abrahamson and Hyltenstam (2009) analysed the nativeness of about 200 people who spoke Swedish as a second language. The participants were all native speakers of Spanish and had started to learn Swedish between the ages of 1 and 47 years, self-identified as being native-like and high proficiency speakers. After being compared to native speakers through a range of tests, none of the late learners (age 11) had equivalent scores. This indicates that despite their excellent language skills, these high proficiency L₂ speakers were not comparable to native speakers. Native speaker performance, as these findings suggest, should not be the goal for most L₂ learners. Instead, they should aspire to become highly intelligible and easily comprehensible bilingual speakers; a pronunciation goal that follows the intelligibility and comprehensibility principle (Levis, 2005).

One cannot help but wonder if a “comfortably understandable pronunciation” would do as a goal for pre-service teachers of English. Murphy (2014: 260) identifies two key factors to be considered when choosing the goals and models in English pronunciation. The first is “the setting in which the language is being studied”, for example, at school for children, at a language institute for professionals, at university as a minor or major, and as a second or foreign language. The second key factor is “the purposes for which the students are learning English”, for example, to communicate internationally with colleagues, to interact with friends from a foreign country, to write academic texts for graduate and postgraduate studies, to teach the language at the school level, or to teach the English language to future teachers of English. Certainly, each of these settings and purposes entails a different command in the mastery of the English language, hence, a different pronunciation teaching goal and, consequently, a different model.

Together with the pronunciation goals that we have set out to accomplish, we must also consider the issue of assessment. As we have mentioned earlier, pronunciation teaching has been widely relegated to a secondary role in Chilean language classrooms, and in many outer-circle countries (Levis and Grant, 2003), therefore, it has not been properly assessed. Even in countries of the inner circle like the USA and Canada, though some assessment exists for international teaching assistants, in general, pronunciation assessment tends to be avoided (Derwing, 2010). Similarly, most standardised tests recognise

the importance of pronunciation, however these only address it partially as one element of a multicomponent speaking assessment scale. For example, the TOEFL (Test of English as a Foreign Language) rating scale, widely-used for employment and academic purposes, assesses pronunciation under the category of delivery of the speaking part. The rubric uses words like “listener effort”, “intelligible”, “awkward intonation”, “minor difficulties with pronunciation or intonation patterns”, “choppy rhythm” (Educational Testing Service, 2004). The lack of definitions of pronunciation or intonation, and the absence of more detailed guidelines may lead to a faulty application of the rubric, where each rater would have to establish their own standard for “awkward” and “choppy”. In the IELTS (International English Language Testing System), also a very important and high-stakes test, the situation is somewhat similar. Pronunciation is one category of a broader speaking test consisting of three other categories, fluency and coherence, lexical resource, grammatical ratings and accuracy, which have to do more with language proficiency rather than pronunciation. Scoring is based on a 9-band scale with descriptions like “a full range”, “a wide range”, “a range”, and “a limited range” of pronunciation features; bands 7, 5 and 3 having no specific descriptors but elements of the bands directly above and below (British Council, IDP: IELTS Australia & UCLES, n.d.). The key indicators used by raters to assess the candidate’s speech are the amount of strain to the listener, the amount of unintelligible speech and mother tongue noticeability, even though the definition of the range of pronunciation features and the degree of intelligibility and L_1 influence are, again, unclear. Finally, the Cambridge ESOL (English to Speakers of Other Languages) testing system, based on the CEFR (Common European Framework of Languages), uses descriptions for the speaking part focused on speech organisation and the various communicative situations the candidate can handle. Pronunciation at each level (A1, A2, B1, B2, C1, C2) is defined by comprehensibility, intelligibility and accent. For example, a C2 description includes “pronunciation is easily understood and prosodic features are used effectively; many features, including pausing and hesitation, are ‘native-like’” (Council of Europe, n.d., p. 74). Though a bit more comprehensive, the guidelines seem to leave plenty of room for rater choice – how to properly interpret native-likeness – and do not provide the necessary information on the impact of pronunciation over the speaking test.

Despite its limitations, the adaptation or creation of a rubric as a tool to evaluate pronunciation has many benefits. Among these benefits, we can mention the possibilities of monitoring raters’ scoring behaviour better, constructing more relevant descriptors that can better represent the ratings, and having the ratings analysed to prevent bias (Ma, 2015). The adaptation or creation process of a pronunciation rubric must conform to the norms and principles of the chosen model that better serve the pronunciation goals and purposes that have been adopted. The use of a well-designed and functional rubric will prevent teachers from rating their students based solely on a general impression of their phonological performance, and will allow for an evaluation that is rel-

evant to the model of pronunciation under which they are working, especially in tertiary education. In terms of certification, the use of a pronunciation rubric will not only provide the opportunity to better train prospective candidates in their phonological control, but also reduce anxiety and secure high ratings. Let us not forget that in Chile, pre-service teachers are to achieve a C1 level to be able to work as an EFL teacher, a certification in which there seems to be a deep-rooted belief that NS pronunciation is, by implication, the ultimate goal.

IDENTITY AND TEACHER TRAINING IN PRONUNCIATION

In the first section of this chapter, we saw how pronunciation attainment seems to be constrained by biological factors. That is to say, our mastery of pronunciation in a foreign language is determined by processes which are related to our age and mental development. This is a limitation which, apparently, we must accept. It is beyond our will. However, sometimes there are those who deliberately decide to avoid aiming at a native speaker accent because they prefer retaining some traits or features of their mother tongue as a way of marking their identity, both individually and socially. By means of using such features of the L_1 , these L_2 speakers show their interlocutors that they belong to a specific group or community (Sung, 2016). Thus, the choice of accent becomes the bone of contention both within and across groups, teachers, learners, stakeholders, and so forth. A qualitative study conducted by Sung (2016) revealed that, from a group of eighteen undergraduate students (16 females and 2 males) whose major was English, thirteen stated that they intended to speak English with a native or native-like accent, whereas five of them declared they preferred to preserve their Hong Kong accent. A thorough analysis of the data collected from this interview-based study was carried out and a series of three reasons were detected to support the participants' choice. The first reason the participants gave for their preference was related to a positive self-image as EFL speakers. In other words, these L_2 English speakers associate native speaker accents with prestige, status, and a characteristics of a competent language user. This view seems to be consistent with what we can usually observe in Chilean EFL teacher training programs, due to the fact that, as Espinoza (2015) posits, the native speaker is the common referent against which learners are assessed. And, of course, pronunciation does not fall outside this trend. The second reason identified by the author was related to the avoidance of being negatively evaluated for having a local accent as it is often stigmatized and thought of as impure and unpleasant. Additionally, as opposed to the first reason mentioned above, they attributed a local accent to a low level of proficiency in the target language. Finally, other practical reasons are provided, such as the enhanced intelligibility associated to a native accent, and therefore, reduced intelligibility levels attributed to the local accent.

What about the Chilean context, then? Even though research in this area is not copious, some attempts to fill this gap have been made. For instance,

Poblete, Gunn, and González, (2017) explored the perception of accent in non-native Chilean speakers of English. This study included the participation of a pool of sixty-five EFL teachers (pre-service and in-service). The results drawn from this study are similar to those found in Sung (2016) in that the participants, too, seemed to view that adopting a native speaker accent involves an advantage as 58% of them reported that they would be a better professional if they had a native or near-native accent. In fact, 51,7% of the respondents stated they wished to opt for either Received Pronunciation or General American. This study also brings up a topic which deserves good attention in pronunciation teaching, and that is teacher confidence. Poblete, Gunn, and González (2017) found that 61,3% of their respondents declared being “confident” or “somewhat confident” with their own accent. This finding is key in shedding light on why pronunciation has for years been the missing element in EFL classrooms nationwide. These results seem to be in line with those found by Henderson et al. (2015) where EFL/ESL teacher participants revealed having avoided teaching English pronunciation due to confidence-related issues among others. Traditionally, language proficiency, and therefore pronunciation proficiency as well, is viewed as an essential component for a EFL/ESL teacher to teach the language (Richards, 2017). Common sense, then, leads us to think that an English teacher whose levels of confidence in terms of their language proficiency are low will avoid teaching those language components where they feel weaker. We must then think of ways to strengthen pre-service teachers’ training in order to prevent such weaknesses and provide them with the necessary skills and empowerment that will allow them to face the challenges of today’s classroom.

FINAL REMARKS

In this chapter, we have discussed important issues related to pronunciation teaching such as the pronunciation model(s) to be adopted, the goals and assessment of L₂ pronunciation teaching, and identity and teacher training in L₂ pronunciation. These are only some of the aspects which deserve attention in terms of the teaching of pronunciation to speakers of other languages. In our attempt to provide an opportunity to reflect on these topics, we have made reference to relevant research which has been carried out. However, more research and more reflection are necessary and crucial. The list of possible areas of research to explore L₂ pronunciation is endless. We encourage academics, researchers, and other ELT professionals to continue examining these and other L₂ pronunciation phenomena. This, of course, must be accompanied by an encounter between both theory and practice. Some possible research niches are how the implementation of alternative pronunciation models may result and what the learners’ attitude towards them is. This will inevitably change some social considerations such as the perception of prestige that current accents

enjoy both worldwide and locally. Furthermore, data and their corresponding analysis on the perception of both the native and the non-native listener are necessary.

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VALIDITY, TRUSTWORTHINESS AND INTEGRITY IN EDUCATIONAL RESEARCH

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Abstract

The criteria used to judge the integrity, validity or trustworthiness of research studies is central to the assessment of the contributions of any research endeavour to the sciences in which it is circumscribed. However, the traditional criteria of validity, reliability, objectivity and generalisability are only applicable to studies carried out in the positivist (empiricist, rationalist) tradition, leaving the criteria of credibility, dependability, transferability and confirmability (Guba, 1981) as their interpretive (constructivist, naturalist) counterpart. The present article reviews these criteria and puts forward other four criteria to be used by critical (participatory, transformative) studies in the educational sciences, offering some conclusions and pedagogical implications.

Keywords: research in education, goodness criteria, research paradigms, quality criteria

Resumen

Los criterios para juzgar la integridad, validez o confianza que merece la investigación es central para la evaluación de las contribuciones de cualquier esfuerzo investigativo a las ciencias en las cuales se circunscribe. Sin embargo,

los criterios tradicionales de validez, confiabilidad, objetividad y generalización son sólo aplicables a los estudios realizados en la tradición positivista (empirista, racionalista), dejando los criterios de credibilidad, confianza, transferibilidad y confirmabilidad (Guba, 1981) como su contraparte interpretativa (constructivista, naturalista). El presente artículo provee una revisión de estos criterios y presenta otros cuatro criterios para ser utilizados en estudios críticos (participativos, transformadores) en las ciencias de la educación, ofreciendo algunas conclusiones e implicaciones pedagógicas.

Palabras clave: investigación en educación, criterios de bondad, paradigmas en investigación, criterios de calidad

INTRODUCTION

This article discusses the criteria employed to guide and assess trustworthiness in research, with a special emphasis on studies carried out in the domain of educational sciences. Three and a half decades after the publication of Guba's (1981) criteria for naturalistic inquiries, which have been amply discussed and used in the evaluation of dissertations, articles and proposals reporting scientific discoveries, the present reflection will review and reorganise some criteria discussed by different authors in order to suggest ways of conceiving and judging the quality of contributions made by novel scientific work in the educational sciences, in a manner which is consonant to the paradigms underlying different research endeavours. The article will firstly address the nature of research carried out in the educational sciences, followed by a summary of the main amalgamated paradigms that usually guide scientific work in these sciences. Finally, the revision will address the traditional criteria for rationalistic and naturalistic inquiries, ending in a proposal of some criteria to analyse trustworthiness in critical inquiries. In closing, the article will provide some conclusions and pedagogical implications.

On the nature of educational research

From a general perspective, educational research can be defined as a scientific procedure by means of which researchers advance knowledge in the educational sciences. This procedure is called research, and the sciences to which educational researchers contribute knowledge to are the educational sciences or the sciences of education, which have received different definitions over the years. Concerning the teaching of English as a Foreign Language in particular, Doff (2018) asserts that it became an academic discipline with the appearance of the first specialised journals in the second half of the nineteenth

century. However, we can still find revisions and discussions that place education within social sciences. The most recent approaches to the educational sciences, on the other hand, have a special place for them as forms of research that aim to address and overturn systems of oppression. In this critical pedagogical perspective, research, pedagogy and activism are intertwined (Kincheloe, McLaren, Steinberg, & Monzó, 2018).

The notion of research may arguably have less varied definitions. Schreiber and Asner-Self define research as:

wondering about the world around and within us, developing ways in which to address such wonderings, and adding to the body of knowledge we believe we have. It is about questioning the veracity of this knowledge, evaluating it in multiple arenas, even reorganizing it to develop novel understandings and applications (2011, p. 2).

This definition serves different types of research endeavours; that is, those which seek to explain and test the rules that govern the world around us and within us; those which hold as aim to unravel or understand these worlds; and those which strive to transform and awaken participants' awareness of the forces governing these worlds.

Paradigms in educational research

The literature on research methods and educational research shows diverse definitions and distinctions of research paradigms; we can find works that present only two paradigms, called quantitative and qualitative – which refer to research approaches, strictly speaking (Hernández Sampieri, Fernández Collado, & Baptista Lucio, 2014); other publications may distinguish three paradigms, namely, normative, interpretive and critical (Cohen, Manion, & Morrison, 2007) or positivist, interpretive and socio-critical (González Morales, 2003); other works may present four paradigms or worldviews, called postpositivist, constructivist, transformative and pragmatic (Creswell, 2014), or scientific realism, social constructivism, advocacy or liberatory framework, and pragmatism (Lodico, Spaulding, & Voegtler, 2006); and there is at least one publication presenting 12 different paradigms as philosophical traditions, namely, empiricism, traditional positivism, logical positivism, postpositivism, rationalism, hermeneutics, structuralism, poststructuralism, critical theory, idealism, interpretivism, and constructivism (Schreiber & Asner-Self, 2011). Regardless of the number and nature of paradigms, these are usually amalgamated into three, which receive the names of positivist, interpretive and critical or socio-critical (González Morales, 2003). In continuation, these are going to be presented and differentiated in terms of four dimensions put forward in the literature (Guba & Lincoln, 1994, 2005; Lin-

coln, Lynham, & Guba, 2018), which are summarised as follows.

- Ontology: the nature of knowledge about reality.
- Epistemology: the nature of the relationship between knowledge and knower.
- Methodology: the ways and procedures by means of which knowledge is created.
- Axiology: the value of knowledge about reality.

Positivist paradigm

The philosophical traditions within this paradigm have in common that they consider knowledge (ontology) as singular, and pre-determined by observable, reducible and measurable laws which are immutable; human beings are determined by this objective reality. Researchers relate to this knowledge (epistemology) in a dualist and objectivist way; they must at all times avoid influencing and being influenced by the object of study, which may threaten the validity of knowledge obtained. Knowledge is valuable (axiology) as an end in itself; it is acquired in order to feed the understanding of immutable laws, in order to explain the truth. Finally, the way in which the researcher acquires new knowledge (methodology) is through manipulation and control; this can enable the researcher to isolate or control any intervening variable in order to measure the effect of an independent variable on a dependent variable, the correlation or association between or among variables, or the variance in values of a variable across groups, which in turn helps the researcher refute or substantiate hypotheses in order to feed the explanation of reality objectively.

Interpretive paradigm

In the philosophical traditions that conform this paradigm, knowledge and truth are conceptualised (ontology) as relative, local, intersubjective and co-constructed. There is no objective reality which is measurable; reality is the product of a social, collective meaning-making process. The relationship between this knowledge and the knower (epistemology) is subjectivist and co-created; it is impossible to attempt to understand reality objectively; objectivity is only an illusion of control. The value of knowledge (axiology) is not in its possession; knowledge is an instrument of social emancipation, so the attempts to understand reality must have a social role. This does not mean researchers must necessarily enact their findings; it means findings must make a social or political contribution, not only a theoretical or empirical one. Finally, the way in which the researcher can access reality (methodology) is discovery-oriented, or *hermeneutic*, and based on the dialogue between participants

and realities. Through this process, researchers can understand the socially constructed phenomena they inquire into.

Critical paradigm

Though different authors may explain the philosophical traditions that make up this amalgamated paradigm as distinct ones, they share some characteristics that for the purposes of this article will be integrated under the same line of thought. Reality, truth and knowledge are conceived (ontology) as historical realism; we may not always be aware of the *true* truth, or our *true* interpretations or feelings because reality, knowledge and truth are a result of “social, political, cultural, economic, ethnic and gender values crystallised over time” (Lincoln et al., 2018, p. 233). The relationship between knowledge and the knower (epistemology) is mediated by the knower’s values, whose purpose is to emancipate the powerless and the voiceless and to enact democracy and equality. The value of knowledge (axiology) is as a means for emancipation; in this paradigm, the purpose is not to understand reality but to transform it. Therefore, knowledge is the instrument of change; knowledge uncovers the fragmented consciousness of participants, which “has brought an individual or social group to relative powerlessness” (Cohen, Manion & Morrison, 2007, p. 26). The way in which this transformative knowledge is acquired (methodology) is through identifying an unfair, oppressive, unequal, ineffective or alienating situation (Kemmis & McTaggart, 2005), creating a critically-informed and participatory action plan and assessing such plan through collaboration by all participants. These methods may include both numerical and textual data and may therefore include both interpretive and statistical data analysis.

TRUSTWORTHINESS: A CONCISE LITERATURE REVIEW

Over the years and in the different philosophical traditions that have nurtured research in the various areas of knowledge, the conditions, procedures and criteria that scientific inquiries must fulfil in order to ensure their quality and integrity have similarly received different types of attention and different definitions and names. In very general terms, we use the term *trustworthiness* to refer to the conditions, procedures, considerations and inspections that help the scientific community in the corresponding area of knowledge to acknowledge the value of a particular research study. These conditions greatly vary depending on the research paradigm that frames a specific research study. Moreover, even in the smaller area of knowledge that is educational research, there is still no consensus on the terms used to refer to the different conditions that make up trustworthiness in the different research paradigms. It is well worth remembering that trustworthiness is not absolute – even highly controlled studies have

a margin of error – but rather it deals with the arguments and evidence we can provide to support consideration of results by the scientific community.

Traditionally, we use the words *validity* and *validation* to refer to the different considerations that ensure the quality of scientific inquiry. Considering that sciences have been (and, arguably, still are) dominated by the positivist, rationalist, empiricist and postpositivist paradigms, the description of such considerations is still governed to a great extent by the criteria put forward by these worldviews. In this respect, Different publications (Guba, 1981; Guba & Lincoln, 1994, 2005; Lincoln et al., 2018; Moral Santaella, 2006) have discussed the adoption of different criteria for naturalistic inquiries, as well as the different dimensions that make up a paradigm. From these revisions, we have gained general criteria upon which we can judge validity of a study (or *trustworthiness*, in general, to avoid the word *validity* which is still governed by a positivist worldview). The traditional criteria are presented in Table 1, as well as general issues to be addressed by a framework to establish goodness or integrity criteria.

Table 1
Criteria and General Issues in Trustworthiness

Criteria	Traditional Meaning	General Issue
Internal Validity	Instruments measure the proposed variables, controlling for any other variables	Truth value. How can the researcher prove that findings are true?
Reliability	Instruments yield the same results, when applied repeatedly	Consistency. How can the researcher prove that findings are stable?
Objectivity	The researcher has no influence over the data provided by the instruments	Neutrality. How can the researcher prove that findings are not biased?
External Validity	Results are statistically generalizable to the population	Applicability. How can the researcher prove that findings are also true for other contexts?

Note. (based on Guba, 1981).

Trustworthiness in positivist studies

From the most traditional perspective of how phenomena, knowledge and research are defined, the criteria used to assess trustworthiness of research are the conditions of internal validity, external validity, reliability and objectivity (Guba, 1981; Lincoln et al., 2018).

Internal validity

In very simple words, internal validity deals with the accuracy of the procedure, i.e. evidence that demonstrates that the results can be trusted. This is usually associated with coherent instrumentation, i.e. to what extent the instrument measures what the researcher says it measures. This may involve creating an operational measure for the variables, ensuring the variables are completely represented in the instrument and assessing the readability of the instrument. Mackey and Gass (2016) describe different criteria to analyse this aspect; the research must, for example, analyse content validity, meaning that instruments include tokens for all the elements associated with the variable they intend to measure; construct validity, which implies that the operationalization of a variable considers all its dimensions; face validity, which means that instruments are easy to read and their layout does not intervene with measurements; and criterion-related validity, meaning that data provided by instruments are similar to data obtained by a validated, standardized instrument. Construct validity for latent variables, as opposed to manifest variables (Wilson & Gochyyev, 2013) is usually reported by means of a statistical test called confirmatory factor analysis (CFA).

Reliability

This basically depends on the fact that instruments yield the same results when applied many times in the same conditions. If tests or instruments are pilot-tested before their actual application for the study, and repeated results show high correlation, this is taken as evidence of their external or test-retest reliability. Other ways to support reliability are Cronbach's alpha, which shows internal consistency (Wang & Osterlind, 2013), and confirmatory factor analysis. Both these tests can be conducted on a single application. However, the recommended sample for these tests is 10 subjects for every item in the instrument.

Objectivity

Positivist researchers cannot participate in the fixed reality they are attempting to measure and explain; any evidence of the opposite would make the study subjective and less trustworthy. Standardised, highly controlled tests, and highly controlled sampling techniques which isolate and control for intervening variables provide evidence for objectivity in a positivist study. This aspect is related to the application of instruments and treatments, how scores are assigned in tests, or the non-participant presence of the researcher in the context.

External validity

This generally refers to the evidence that supports the results being generalised to a wider population. In order to do this, positivist researchers must carefully select participants in such a way that this sample is representative of the bigger population to which results will be generalised. The sample size is calculated considering a margin of error (usually 1% to 5%), and the sample characteristics have to be carefully controlled for and singled out in order to identify the best sampling method. To generalise results, the researcher needs to prove that the sample to which treatments and measurements were applied is comparable to the rest of the population. This is related with the size of the sample as well as the method through which this sample was selected (random, systematic, convenience, purposeful, cluster, etc.).

As is evident from this explanation, these four traditional criteria hardly apply to an interpretive or critical study, considering their divergent ontological, epistemological, methodological and axiological perspectives. Over the years, there have been three general tendencies regarding this conundrum: (i) trying to fit naturalistic research into the positivist definitions of trustworthiness, (ii) redefining the positivist criteria into fitting the interpretive or critical paradigm, or (iii) rejecting these criteria, as they are themselves a reproduction of the oppression of positivism over the other types of research. The present article adopts the second option, which does not compromise the worldview of interpretivism or the critical tradition nor does it disregard the issue altogether.

Trustworthiness in interpretive studies

As we know, this worldview conceives reality as a social construct, which is why this paradigm is also known as constructivist (Lincoln et al., 2018). The researcher does not seek objectivity, but rather intersubjectivity. This reality is apprehended through a participatory, dialogic method. For these reasons, the positivist criteria are not applicable to ensure trustworthiness in naturalistic inquiry. Over three decades ago, Guba (1981) put forward the criteria of *credibility*, *dependability*, *confirmability* and *transferability* for these types of inquiry, which will be explained as follows.

Credibility

Considering reality is intersubjective, the researcher must prove that procedures to grasp this reality provide a faithful picture of it. This can be done in general with enough evidence that the participants' perspectives have been considered, and it is ensured in different ways; through prolonged engagement

with participants, which will help the researcher gain the participants' trust so that they can act more naturally, avoiding phenomena such as the halo effect (Mackey & Gass, 2016) in interviews or data elicitation techniques. This also means that interpretive researchers avoid questions that may hint to expected answers, so that responses are truthful. Another method to ensure credibility is what Guba (1981) calls member checks. This means that interpretations are shared with participants, who can ensure that these are truthful.

Dependability

Contrary to the positivist endeavour to nullify variability by means of consistent measurements, dependability can be defined as “trackable variance” (Guba, 1981, p. 81). This means that researchers and their methods must be able to oversee and adapt to the changing conditions in the field. In order to ensure these changes do not affect the stability of findings, it is suggested researchers use different, overlapping methods to collect data. Alternatively, Guba (1981) also suggests stepwise replication, in which different researchers divide up the data for analysis, and cross check their interpretations. These procedures are also called methodological triangulation and inter-researcher triangulation, respectively. Additionally, it is suggested that the researchers leave an audit trail and ask an external researcher to carry out a dependability audit in order to check interpretations that are being drawn from the data during the process (Guba, 1981).

Confirmability

As naturalist researchers know the bias in standardised instruments, and additionally knowing that researchers are themselves the main instruments, with their own prejudice and preconceptions, the question of neutrality is transferred into the data itself. Interpretations are therefore trustworthy as long as they can be confirmed. For this reason, it is paramount that researchers do not only present their interpretations, but also make available the data and triangulations upon which these were drawn. This is a different kind of audit, which Guba calls a confirmability audit (1981), and it is carried out after the study has been conducted, on the product of analyses.

Transferability

Contrary to the automatic applicability in positivist studies when conditions are met, findings from interpretive studies are not as readily applicable to

other contexts. These are only true, in principle, for the context in which they were generated, because they are heavily context-laden. On the other hand, Guba states that if the researcher provides what Geertz calls “thick description” (as cited in Guba, 1981) of the context, applicability of results into other contexts can be assessed, based on the degree of fittingness in essential characteristics.

Trustworthiness in critical studies

As we can observe, the criteria put forward by Guba are consistent with the interpretive paradigm. However, the critical paradigm presupposes a reality in which the researcher, contrary to what positivists and interpretivists claim, has values and ideologies. Trustworthiness criteria are therefore defined, in general, by erosion of ignorance, emancipation, social justice and call to action (Lincoln et al., 2018, p. 233). In their revision of paradigmatic controversies Lincoln et al. also mention other criteria of trustworthiness, which authors such as Moral Santaella (2006) have used in their revisions on the issue of validity in qualitative studies. These aspects will be organised in the same criteria above as a proposal for analysis of trustworthiness in critical studies. The four aspects are *critical intelligence*, *social justice*, *crystallisation* and *social action*.

Critical intelligence

Defined by Schwandt as the researcher’s ability to transgress ideologies and engage in moral critique of the phenomena under study (as cited in Lincoln et al., 2018), truth value in critical studies cannot be construed in terms of intersubjectivity because of the presupposition that this shows the virtual reality that the researcher needs to transgress. Instead, truth value is understood as the researcher’s ability to identify presuppositions in participants’ (and the researcher’s own) perceptions. “Critical theory identifies the ‘false’ or ‘fragmented’ consciousness ... that has brought an individual or social group to relative powerlessness or, indeed, power, and it questions the legitimacy of this” (Cohen et al., 2007, p. 26). In this sense, findings are not true when they represent the participants’ perspectives, but rather when they transgress the participants’ ideologies that have led them to oppression. A good evidence for this is the researcher’s own reflections which are recorded throughout the process.

Social justice

Contrary to the expected nullification of variance in positivist studies, or tracking variance in interpretive studies, critical studies must place special emphasis on minorities or inconsistencies in the data (outliers, in the positivist tradition) that are usually overlooked. Social justice (Lincoln et al., 2018, p. 260) is understood as the researcher's responsibility to ensure that all voices are represented in the study, not as a consensus of the most salient themes, which may be a reduction of variance. Instead, special emphasis must be placed on minorities which may normally be underrepresented and considered inconsistent with the rest of the data. In other words, consistency may be considered as attention to variance. In critical studies, this is especially relevant when the unfair or oppressive situation that researchers aim to transform affects minorities, who will have a special role in the study by critically informing and assessing the action plan.

Crystallisation

Richardson explains the notion of crystalline or transgressive forms as the researcher's capacity to "uncover the hidden assumptions and life-denying repressions" (as cited in Lincoln et al., 2018, p. 271). Moral Santaella (2006) compares crystallisation and triangulation, arguing that the latter seeks to find matches in the data, while the former, as a prism, seeks to present the widest array of colours and forms. Going back to the question of neutrality as a general criterion, crystallisation can be understood as seeking to show all assumptions, even value-laden ones, to attain full transparency. This transparency also applies to the researcher's ideologies and preconceptions, which usually guide the transformation that the study sets in motion.

Social action

Action, emancipation and transformation are core elements in the critical paradigm. It is for this reason that applicability must be understood as a call for action and agency. Lincoln et al. explain that social action can be made manifest in numerous ways, "from the overturning of specific unjust practices to radical transformation of entire societies" (2018, p. 260). In this sense, the most important form of applicability is not in the generalisation or transference of findings, but rather in the persistence of the transformations set in motion by the researcher. In other words, a critical study must awaken and empower participants to take action, and it must help them perpetuate the transformations that the study initiated.

Table 2

Summary of Trustworthiness Aspects in the Different Research Paradigms

General Aspect	Positivism	Interpretivism	Critical Theory
Truth Value	Internal validity	Credibility	Critical intelligence
Consistency	Reliability	Dependability	Social justice
Neutrality	Objectivity	Confirmability	Crystallisation
Applicability	External validity	Transferability	Social action

CONCLUSIONS

This revision by no means intends to be exhaustive or definitive in providing criteria to assess educational research studies. Instead, it seeks to offer an alternative perspective to those students, researchers and research advisors who have not yet found clear guidelines on how to assess different types of study in the educational sciences. By reviewing trustworthiness criteria in conjunction with the paradigms that frame their understanding, this author expects to provide a clearer picture of what to expect from research studies, and how to judge whether findings are true, consistent, neutral (or transparent) and applicable.

Future revisions on the issue of trustworthiness should address the appropriacy of these criteria in different research designs used in the educational sciences. For example, distinguishing between participatory action research and practical action research (Creswell, 2012; Kemmis & McTaggart, 2005), or assessing whether grounded theory designs should use the same criteria as ethnographic or phenomenological studies. Some questions are also left unanswered: Should we use (or take back) the word *validity* to address all forms of trustworthiness, or should we adopt a new word for it to encompass all walks of research? Would research carried out under a complexity paradigm be consistent with any of these amalgamated paradigms? Otherwise, should we create other trustworthiness criteria for the complexity paradigm?

Pedagogical implications

Perhaps the most important contribution this revision intends to bring about is coherence in the evaluation of research studies. For example, as research advisors or members in viva voce examination commissions, we cannot expect students to validate each and every instrument in their studies; the word validation applies to instruments and procedures used in a postpositivist study. Moreover, we must remember that the researcher *is* the instrument in interpretive studies. On the other hand, if students seek to conduct a postpositivist

study or use quantitative data in their mixed studies, it is well worth remembering that instruments measuring latent variables are not validated only by experts' judgements, as is usually the tradition in many universities; expert judgement may provide hints on face validity, or content validity for instruments measuring manifest variables, but construct validity for latent variables is far more complex. Finally, and perhaps the most relevant and novel implication in this author's view, critical studies should not attempt to present a neutral perspective, nor aspire to make their findings transferable; critical studies must be coloured by the researcher's values. The critical researcher must instil awareness in the participants' minds and spirits, and this formidable action necessitates an equally strong conviction that permeates into the text by means of which the study is reported.

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NEW EXPRESSIONS ON FAMILIAR FACES: USING A FUSION OF KNOWN METHODS TO FACILITATE LEXICAL ACQUISITION IN THE EFL CLASSROOM

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Abstract

Throughout their studies and careers, most language teachers are confronted with a myriad of didactic theories and resources for constructing the most engaging and effective courses for language acquisition. Here, I discuss my personal experiences with the implementation of a variety of L2 learning and acquisition theories in the classroom, focusing mainly on institutions of higher education in south-central Chile. This text reflects on the efficacy (and lack thereof) of combining the Lexical and Natural Approaches to lexical acquisition (Lewis, Krashen, Terrell) along with the communicative approach, Total Physical Response, CALL, flipped classroom and I.S.P. Nation's vocabulary learning strategies to create and maintain a dynamic immersion environment conducive to language play within the specific cultural context of Chilean universities.

Keywords: Total Physical Response, Flipped Classroom, Natural Approach, language play, lexical acquisition

Resumen

Durante el curso de sus estudios y vidas profesionales, la mayoría de los profesores de lengua se exponen a una infinidad de teorías y recursos didácticos

para la elaboración de los cursos más eficaces e interesantes para la adquisición de lenguas extranjeras. Aquí, profundizo en mis experiencias personales con la implementación de una variedad de teorías de adquisición y aprendizaje en el aula, principalmente con un enfoque en instituciones de educación superior en el centro-sur de Chile. Este texto aborda la eficacia (o deficiencia) de una combinación de los métodos léxico y natural respecto la adquisición léxica (Lewis, Krashen, Terrell) con un conjunto de otros métodos como el método comunicativo, el de Respuesta Física Total, CALL, el de aula inversa, y las estrategias del aprendizaje de vocabulario de I.S.P Nation. De este modo, posibilitar la mantención y creación de un ambiente de inmersión dinámica que fomente el uso lúdico de la L2 dentro de un contexto cultural específico a universidades en Chile.

Palabras clave: Total Physical Response, adquisición léxica, aula inversa, Enfoque Natural, lengua lúdica

INTRODUCTION

The world thrives on innovation: the new, the different, the exciting; the academic world is much the same, constantly searching for progressive innovations and discoveries. Although we are taught to revere our predecessors in our respective fields, we often use them as a kind of staircase on the way to reaching the goal of our own innovative ambitions. Here, I seek to step away from that model by paying tribute to the influencing minds and methods of the 20th and 21st centuries in language teaching and demonstrate how their ideas and approaches, far from being mutually exclusive, may be implemented together in the language classroom in order to create and maintain an immersion environment conducive to learning. I draw primarily on Asher's Total Physical Response, the Communicative Approach, Lewis' Lexical Approach, the work of I.S.P. Nation, Krashen and Terrell's L2 learning and acquisition theories, as well as language play and CALL strategies (including the flipped classroom), to reflect upon the challenges and triumphs of combining these foundational theories for maximum efficacy in implementing immersion environments in university classrooms in south-central Chile. In keeping with the theme of this volume, the scope of this chapter is restricted to my own observations regarding the obstacles and successes of the application of a variety of methods to aid lexical acquisition in the EFL classroom among university students in Chile.

THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

For many in the language teaching world, the Total Physical Response

method first proposed by James C. Asher in the 1960's is viewed as a sort of quirky method essentially useful for basic verb acquisition and therefore easily relegated to the sidelines in favor of newer, more comprehensive methods. Relying on the dramatization of speech, Asher's first studies focused on retention of listening input via viewing the instructor act out commands as he/she taught vocabulary and then progressed to the students themselves dramatizing the words and utterances as they learned them (Asher, 1966). This led to a consensus among language professionals that the method may prove quite effective in the language learning of students at a basic level of the target language, especially with regard to commands and requests. However, in combining TPR with Lewis's Lexical Approach, using Krashen and Terrell's ideas about meaningful language experiences (Terrell, 1986), I have been able to expand TPR's foci of embodied language and exaggerated emotion to contextualize not only individual words, but also idioms, institutionalized utterances, and so on, in keeping with the Lexical Approach to promote a more natural approach to language acquisition (Lewis, 1993).

Although Nation and Terrell have somewhat differing views with regard to vocabulary acquisition and learning, I have found that by extrapolating and implementing their views within the EFL classroom, it is possible to maintain an immersion environment in the target language with the correct level of input. The advantage of combining Krashen and Terrell's L2 approaches with Nation's lexical expertise is that it is then possible to expand the horizon of expectations for both the instructor and the students with regard to their own capabilities. That is, one can maintain an immersion environment in the target language while reinforcing binding in the classroom as well as employ lexical learning strategies involving the use of L1 (even for lexical chunks) by using Nation's vocabulary techniques in homework and occasional idiomatic (not literal) translations in the classroom itself (Nation, 2008).

In addition to integrating theories to keep the classroom atmosphere communicative, the use of CALL methodology and technology in the classroom, as well in autonomous work complementary to classroom material, has become an integral part of EFL teaching. Methods of practical application, such as learning management systems in which students use online resources, like TED Talks, video clips, vocabulary and grammar explanations, and even homework submission and exams online permit the students to spend more interactive time with the language inside and outside of the classroom. CALL allows students to be exposed to a variety of culturally authentic material (for example, popular songs, video clips, how-to videos and educational talks in the target language) with the added advantage of being able to incorporate different accents and linguistic registers into language instruction relatively easily, thereby exposing the students to a wide variety of Englishes.

In many cases, CALL methodology has been and continues to be associated with the didactic method of the flipped classroom. Essentially, this means that students familiarize themselves with the course contents before

meeting with the instructor in the classroom, facilitating the learning process by their prior knowledge of the material. Usually, this comes in the form of didactic and even interactive exercises prior to meeting with the students, as Gaughan (2014) describes. In an EFL classroom, the ideal process is generally designed thusly: the students have access to lexis and/or grammar provided in a dynamic format (videos, songs, recorded lectures, verbal question and response exercises) before the in-person class. In the best-case scenario, the contents introduced are put in a meaningful context so that binding can occur in advance of productive didactic exercises during the in-person classes. They learn the material and perform the exercises, usually on an internet-based learning management system (LMS) and then bring any questions they might have to the class. In an optimal world, this eliminates the necessity of the instructor to introduce the lexical theme, allowing him/her to conduct a short review that includes pertinent questions from the students and then proceed directly to language access and use.

The potential of a contextually and culturally accurate internet-based platform combined with learning and acquisition strategies for lexis in a natural or communicative context is great. However, as with all learning and acquisition processes, student participation greatly affects the outcome of implementation. In turn, the students' expectations about their own involvement in the EFL classroom (and outside of it) are derived from the culture of learning in varying communities in which they reside.

Contextual framework

I began my teaching career at the quite advanced age of sixteen, when I was hired as a junior counselor at Concordia Language Villages German immersion summer program called *Waldsee*, which is an intensive immersion environment facilitated by an almost constant use of TPR as well as songs and activities to simulate an authentic linguistic and cultural experience for children and young adults ages 6-18. Having attended the program for eight consecutive summers as a villager myself, not only was I a direct beneficiary of the method, but also able to readily and enthusiastically implement it. Thus, when I actually lived in Germany, I was able to transfer that training to weekly English language and children's literature sessions I had with 2nd and 4th graders. As I began my MA in the United States, I transitioned to teaching adult learners of German at the University of Kansas, as well as working with children at the university affiliated child development center. Upon graduation, I moved to Chile where I again taught mostly English language, first at a K-12 school and then for students, faculty and staff at two universities on three campuses in south-central Chile. Since I have been fortunate enough to teach two languages on three different continents to learners with wide variations in ages and demographics; I have also had the opportunity to implement a variety

of teaching methods, depending on the vision of the institution and the goals of the course.

In contrast to the United States and Chile, students in Germany are exposed to language learning and acquisition techniques from a very young age; especially since the formation of the European Union, Germans have become increasingly accustomed to living in a more globalized, plurilingual society. However, in the United States, the acquisition of a second language has sharply decreased in importance on the national scale, as can be evidenced by budget cuts and degree requirements that do not involve proficiency in a foreign language. According to a report released in 2017, “Throughout all 50 states and the District of Columbia, 20% of K-12 students are enrolled in foreign language classes” (Devlin, 2018, p. 1). At my own high school in Kansas, for example, language classes were not a graduation requirement and the Spanish and German classes offered were seen more as a pain than a pleasure by the student body. Many of my students at the University of Kansas had little to no prior knowledge of SLA when they began A1 level classes, with more than one student admitting to me that they had originally attempted to enroll in Spanish, Choctaw¹, or Uyghur² only to find that the classes were full or there was a conflict in their schedules, at which point they felt that German was a “solid” option. In Chile, with recent education reforms accompanied by positive economic development, English language courses have become a priority for students studying everything from music to chemical engineering. Currently, most fields of study have at least two semesters of English as a graduation requirement. Some fields require courses that focus solely on reading comprehension, but a large part focus on communicational English skills, preparing them to enter the work force or academic community with at least intermediate English proficiency.

Obviously, there are differences between individual students, their motivations, and their learning styles, but there are also overarching distinctions among the distinct cultures in which I have been involved in second language teaching. Here, I do not attempt to investigate these cultural distinctions, but rather comment on them in the context of the general receptivity of the students to the implemented teaching methods, with the primary focus being on university students in Chile.

Whereas students in Chile may not have any experience with autonomous learning, students in Germany are not only accustomed to working independently, but also to having language classes from a young age, officially beginning with English at age 6. What is more, “studying a *second* foreign language for at least one year is compulsory in more than 20 European countries” (Devlin, 2018, p. 1). In addition, they tend to follow instructions quickly

¹ Language of a native nation in the USA.

² Language of an ethnic Chinese minority.

and without embarrassment—a marked characteristic that distinguishes them from students in the US and Chile. Even if the instructions are playful or take them out of their comfort zone, students tend to participate fully and without complaint. For instance, I experienced an activity in 12th grade at the Gymnasium³ in Hechingen, Germany, in which we had to act out a short passage from Goethe's *Faust* in a certain style (wistful, angry, joyful, etc.) and even though many in the course were not actors, artistically inclined, nor even particularly kind, everyone did the assignment without reticence or ridicule.

In the United States, such an activity could be more difficult to carry out, given certain cultural norms about rebellious attitudes and individualism being rewarded with social prestige. However, another strong cultural trait among students from the United States lies in the seeming lack of embarrassment regarding mistakes. Most students from the United States assume that they will not immediately speak a language perfectly and so any errors they make, even in a public arena, count as a part of the acquisition process. As aforementioned, most students in an A1 language course at the university level have little to no prior experience with foreign language courses, essentially leveling the playing field with regard to initial language competencies.

Meanwhile, in Chile, the structure of the educational system is again different, leading to a number of disparate levels in an A1 level classroom, for instance, there may be students who function at a B2 level or higher, who are not able to test out because of current academic regulations, who are in the class with people who have had no experience with the target language or even with language classes at all. The disparity in language proficiency levels in the classroom coupled with an extremely present cultural fear of public humiliation, leads to an active resistance to following instructions in more dynamic activities and an absolute terror of producing the language in front of peers and instructors alike. When asked to move about the classroom, some students will remain seated, others only speak in Spanish, yet others excuse themselves to the bathroom and so on. During periods of oral evaluations, various students have broken down in tears or have been unable to reproduce the language, attempting to elicit translations in Spanish from their interview partners, or simply talked at the floor.

The challenges thus presented in the ESL classroom in Chile were to implement interactive, dynamic teaching styles conducive to retention and communicational proficiency in the target language (in this case English) to students with very disparate skills levels and acquisition backgrounds, most of whom had no prior experience with productive or creative teaching methods nor with flipped classroom.

³ Institution of Secondary education. Generally grades 5-13.

Implementation: challenges and successes

I have found that integrating TPR into classroom teaching methodology and combining it with (slightly) more recent language teaching strategies such as Krashen's L2 theory and Terrell's Natural Acquisition from the 1980's and/or Lewis's Lexical Approach to vocabulary acquisition from the 1990's can help to maintain a classroom environment conducted almost completely in the target language, with learners of a variety of levels. In addition, I have found that the inherently ludic nature of TPR implementation also leads to a low-anxiety environment that is conducive to language play and creative language use in the target language. As previously mentioned, I implemented a fusion of methods, primarily focused on a communicative style of teaching in an immersion environment. Integrating the plethora of methods described above, I strove to maintain the immersion environment even with basic levels, creating the context for a mixture of natural lexical acquisition as well as conscious learning all within a meaningful and motivational context. Especially for more advanced students, I extrapolated some of I.S.P Nation's strategies regarding vocabulary learning and acquisition onto language learning and acquisition to help adult learners at the postgraduate with the acquisition of nuanced lexical chunks in context. The fusion of these various methods has provided for a certain degree of flexibility in the classroom, leading to a sort of student-centered patchwork method that encompasses a variety of acquisitive activities geared toward a myriad of learning styles and includes meaningful input and creative output in a somewhat ludic environment.

In Chile, one of the most important things I had to learn was flexibility and the idea of supporting students in an L2 environment while taking into account cultural norms regarding public mistakes. Therefore, a primary focus has been on the affective filter and how to provide a low-anxiety environment in which the students can feel comfortable experiencing meaningful language input and output. Many students felt frightened by having a native speaker teacher in the classroom who spoke only in English during the class. While some courses included students from a variety of majors, others contained students only from one major. There is a marked difference, for example, between students majoring in medicine and students majoring in sociology. With the medicine students, we were able to maintain an immersion environment quite well, with very little coaxing on my part. Using computer-based visual and auditory input, I was able to create meaningful lexis using authentic songs, videos, pictures, and stories, putting words and phrases in a comprehensible and meaningful context. Afterward, I could follow the input up with structured and then more unstructured output, primarily with the implementation of ludic activities with partners and small groups in order to take the pressure off and provide entertaining and humorous ways to produce language play.

However, with the sociology students, I had to employ a strategy similar to Nation's vocabulary acquisition strategies involving L1 and L2 relation-

ships, however extrapolated onto the affective filter. Admittedly, this concept may seem strange, which I will attempt to elucidate below. Using Nation's ideas about creating meaningful language experiences by using students' L1 to give meaning to their L2 vocabulary (Nation, 2008), I used the first part of every class with the sociology students to lower their affective filter. We spoke in Spanish for approximately the first 10 minutes about what they were studying, if they had partaken in any political activities lately, very carefully avoiding inserting my own opinions into the conversation—merely expressing my interest in their primary area of study. I would then transition into the L2 environment and the day's topic with the communicative approach involving productive ludic activities. Before I began implementing this methodology, their guards had been very much up, due to their cultural reality and perspective regarding their obligation to learn a language they viewed as essentially imperialistic and of myself as a *de facto* ambassador of cultural imperialism.

Yet, by connecting with the students in their native language, I forged a different sort of association with them, transitioning from L1 talk regarding their studies and other activities, to questions in Spanish with regard to the target language. After which, we could transition to the rest of the class conducted in an L2 environment implementing a fusion of TPR and the communicative method (using Krashen and Terrell's theories about acquisition and binding as a base). As part of a program at one university, autonomous work on an internet-based platform before the in-person class was semi-enforced as part of the course program. However, most students did not engage in the ideal flipped classroom model, instead leaving their work on the computer to the last possible minute. The lack of ability or willingness to engage with the computer assisted learning material did have an impact on the effectiveness of in-person classes. Students in Germany and the United States traditionally have had more experience with autonomous learning projects and with access to technology, something that is not a given in Chile. The idea of implementing a CALL course based on the flipped classroom model to encourage vocabulary and grammar learning and acquisition before the in-person classes, is essentially sound. Concerning students who had more academic commitment and more access to technology at home, one could see binding occur more strongly, thereby leading to increased production and use of authentic language chunks in the target language. Even, in some cases, a sort of natural language play. However, with students who either did not have easy access to technology (although the university does have computer labs) and/or did not view their language course as a priority, binding and access to language forms was weak to non-existent.

When I had the opportunity to implement English courses for graduate students at a different university, I attempted to use a similar model. The students were encouraged to work on vocabulary and grammar using material I created on an internet platform, gradually progressing to reading, writing, and listening activities, as well as cultural information. Since we could only have

classes once a week, I had hoped to foment their learning by adding new activities every few days with staggered due dates, spending about 2 weeks per unit. I had hoped that their commitment to their language course might demonstrate itself to be greater given that they were graduate students and thus would be able to work better autonomously.

Nevertheless, largely due to the lack of resources (namely, time and funding) presented by the university, the same issues that had occurred with the undergraduate students yet again presented themselves. There were students with varying levels of English proficiency in the same classroom, the course was not a priority, due to a heavy academic load in their primary fields of study, problems arose with software, etc. Thus, vocabulary and grammar were often reviewed in the classroom, taking away from time that could have been spent on reinforcing the binding-access framework and providing meaningful, communicative, language experiences.

By providing meaningful context for vocabulary and grammar during the in-person classes, it was still possible to facilitate communicative language activities. I integrated technology to show authentic video clips (songs, news-casts, TED Talks, Saturday Night Live videos), plus images to provide visual input to contextualize words and phrases. Thus, the students were able to participate in contextual guessing and develop listening strategies pre-production, which obviously aided their language comprehension and production.

In addition, I continued to implement the use of gestures, exaggerated expressions and dynamic production activities in partners and small groups to facilitate the comprehension and use of the target language. This contributed to the students' enjoyment of the material as well as an increase in their confidence. Since I strove to create meaningful activities in communicative/authentic contexts, the production and binding of the lexical chunks was reinforced, even without the ideal prior exposure to the material.

Ludic activities and language play

TPR is conducive to whimsy and creative activities, which then create a low-anxiety environment in which the students enjoy the language course and feel more confident in producing the forms (Celestino, 1993). This in turn establishes stronger lexical binding for the students. Activities that allow students to laugh and tap into their creative side promote both laughter and lexical acquisition and can even lead to creativity and language play as defined by Cook (1997).

Through using language chunks as advocated by Lewis, it was possible to support the mix of learning and acquisition advocated by Terrell and Nation in a communicative classroom environment. The general approach was to review the material in context without too much literal translation (using a mix of authentic listening and reading activities as well as contextualized visual input

in the form of images and embodiment) and then progress to lexically related activities with a strong ludic component. For example, playing the commonly known cross-continental game “Never have I ever,” integrated the use of the present perfect while encouraging the students to be creative and playful with their use of English. Their playful attitude encouraged participation, binding and access to the forms, and their own creative use of the language. Many of them constructed sentences like “Never have I ever ridden a whale” or “Never have I ever seen a unicorn,” demonstrating a spontaneous desire to push the boundaries of their knowledge and genuinely have fun with the language. In doing so, the students tend to retain more, as expounded upon by Broner and Tarone (2001): “...the emotional excitement that comes with language play as it increases what Stevick (1976) called “depth” (pp. 41-44) of all things associated with affective responses” (p. 375).

CONCLUSIONS

Due to general cultural experiences involving the transmission of course contents, the implementation of flipped classroom methodology in language classrooms in Chile has proven, in the most extreme cases problematic, and at the very least a challenge for the students who must undergo a paradigm shift regarding their own involvement in the learning process. In order for the flipped classroom model to be successful as an acquisition strategy, the students must redefine their horizon of expectations. They should also take responsibility for autonomous work outside the classroom, which has shown itself to be something generally novel within the cultural framework of the country, even among graduate students.

On the positive side, the implementation of communicative language practices in the classroom, using technology and authentic material to provide a structure for lexical binding has been a great success. Expanding on the principles of Krashen and Terrell to include Asher and Lewis has provided a classroom environment in which the students can bind form to meaning quite strongly and demonstrate creative mastery of language chunks in an immersion environment. Furthermore, I believe there is great potential for expanded study in the area of strategies for the implementation of computer-based flipped classroom methodology and the effect on students’ autonomous learning paradigms in general and for SLA specifically. Additionally, there are possible implications concerning student confidence with regard to language production. The relevance of the affective filter has never been so clear to me as in the past few years in Chile, which has served as the primary impetus for my application of a fusion of methods in the EFL classroom.

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EXPLORING THE IMPLEMENTATION OF AFFECTIVE PRACTICES IN A CONTEXT OF CRITICAL LITERACY PEDAGOGY: THE USE OF MOVIE SCENES TO INCREASE STUDENTS' EMPATHY LEVELS IN THE EFL/ESL CLASSROOM

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Abstract

This paper aims at presenting a multimodal framework for the implementation of affective literacy practices based on the use of movie scenes in the EFL/ESL classroom. Our ultimate intention is to contribute to increasing students' levels of empathy towards language, gender and race discrimination in a context of critical literacy pedagogy. To this end, we provide in this paper both (i) a framework for the implementation of affective literacy through cinema and (ii) a didactic proposal based on this model and focused on a well-known scene from *English Vinglish* (2012), an Indian comedy-drama film written and directed by Gauri Shinde. The narrative revolves around Shashi, who enrolls in an English course in New York to stop her family mocking her lack of English skills, gaining self-respect in the process.

Keywords: affective literacy, critical literacy, EFL/ESL, empathy, cinema, multimodality

Resumen

Este capítulo tiene como objetivo presentar un marco multimodal para la implementación de prácticas de alfabetización afectiva basadas en el uso de escenas cinematográficas en el aula de inglés. Nuestra intención es aumentar los niveles de empatía de los estudiantes hacia la discriminación lingüística, de género y racial en un contexto de pedagogía de alfabetización crítica. Con esta finalidad, en este trabajo proporcionamos (i) un marco teórico para el desarrollo de la alfabetización afectiva a través del cine, así como (ii) una propuesta didáctica basada en dicho modelo y centrada en una escena muy conocida de la película *English Vinglish* (2012), una comedia dramática india escrita y dirigida por Gauri Shinde. El argumento de la película gira en torno a Shashi, quien se inscribe en un curso inglés en Nueva York para evitar que su familia se burle de su falta de habilidad en inglés, adquiriendo una mayor autoestima durante el proceso.

Palabras clave: alfabetización afectiva, alfabetización crítica, enseñanza de segunda lengua y lengua extranjera, empatía, cine, multimodalidad

INTRODUCTION

The last few decades have witnessed a growing interest in binding together language teaching and literacy education in pursuit of development of critical literacy skills (Crookes, 2010; Curtis & Romney, 2006; Riasati & Mollaei, 2012). In particular, the promotion of social justice as the cornerstone of the language teaching curriculum implies teaching students to work with texts more actively and reflectively for a better understanding of power, in/equality and in/justice in human relations (Aliakbari & Faraji, 2011; Benesh, 2009; Crookes, 2010; Duncan-Andrade and Morrell, 2008; Izadinia, 2011; Riasati & Mollaei, 2012). Critical literacy pedagogy should go hand in hand with affective literacy practices, enabling students “to cope with ethical dilemmas in responsiveness to human suffering” (Anwarrudin, 2016, p. 381).

Accordingly, we defend the incorporation of affective literacy practices into a critical literacy-based education so as to claim the need for fostering affections in the language classroom, this means; for enhancing “attitudes and behaviours that deal with feelings, emotions, values and, in general, the personal concerns of students” (Alpren, 1974, p. 46). More specifically, it is our intention to provide a framework for the implementation of affective literacy practices based on the use of movie scenes to enhance language learners’ levels of empathy towards language, gender and race discrimination in a context of critical literacy pedagogy.

As far as structure is concerned, the paper starts with a general overview of affective education as a part of a broader critical multiliteracy pedagogy. A revisited version of Serafini's multimodal adaptation of Luke and Freebody's Four Resources Model (1999), aimed at promoting the development of critical literacy in the language classroom, is then introduced and a set of strategies and practices leading to the development of affective literacy skills is used to complete the model. Finally, a didactic proposal based on a well-known scene from *English Vinglish* (2012) is provided to illustrate the model.

TOWARDS A FRAMEWORK FOR THE IMPLEMENTATION OF AFFECTIVE LITERACY PRACTICES THROUGH CINEMA IN THE EFL/ESL CLASSROOM

Following a brief revision of Serafini's multimodal adaptation of Luke and Freebody's Four Resources Model (1999), a set of strategies and practices leading to the development of affective literacy skills will be included to complete the framework for the implementation of affective literacy practices through cinema.

Our approach to affect is part of the tradition of those scholars who use the term affect generically, including emotions, feelings, desires and impulses, and defending the idea of the inseparability of affect from emotion. In particular, we follow Ahmed's model of the sociality of emotions, which puts the emphasis on the circulation of emotions between bodies and objects (2010). Emotions do not move from inside out or from outside in, but rather "it is the objects of emotions that move and circulate" (Anwarrudin, 2016). This understanding of emotions is crucial and leads us to the necessity of encouraging critical literacy practices that move readers towards certain emotions. This means, to the necessity of developing critical literacy practices to move readers towards particular emotions such as empathy.

Affective education is often regarded as part of a broader critical multiliteracy pedagogy (Chambers & Radbourne, 2015). According to Clough (2007), the recent turn towards affective education situates affective theory within a theory of multiple literacies and, more particularly, within the theory of critical literacy. Among the existing approaches to critical literacy education (Kalantzis and Cope's Critical Multiliteracies Model 2000, Luke and Freebody's Four Resources Model 1999 or Unsworth's Critical Literacy Model 2001, among others) we will revisit Serafini's multimodal adaptation of Luke and Freebody's Four Resources Model (1999).

Luke and Freebody's Four Resources Model (1999) encourages the development of critical literacy in the language classroom through four explicit reader roles that allow the social and textual realms to converge and to make meaning: 1) Code Breaker, 2) Text Participant, 3) Text User, and 4)

Text Analyst. As Code Breakers, learners need to be able to decode the symbols that make up the text. They are also expected to activate their personal experiences and their previous knowledge in order to be able to interact as Text Participants. The role of the Text User involves their awareness of the purpose of the text, which is necessary to understand its different cultural and social functions. Text Analysts are expected to identify biased issues and to think analytically.

Drawing on research on the ‘paradigm’ shift (Bearne, 2003) towards the predominance of digitally mediated texts, Luke and Freebody’s Four Resources Model (1999) was expanded by Serafini (2012) into four new social practices that are characteristic of the analysis of multimodal texts: 1) navigating, 2) interpreting, 3) designing and 4) interrogating. The reader as navigator is expected to decode non-linear structures, hypertexts, visual images, and multimodal compositional structures. As interpreter should develop interpretive repertoires that address visual images and design elements from political, historical and cultural perspectives. As designers, readers need not only to construct meaning, but also to design the reading path. Interrogators are expected to read both the personal and the public meanings of texts.

Figure 1 shows a blending of the two models that facilitates students’ approach to multimodal texts. The traditional reader roles (Code Breaker, Text Participant, Text User and Text Analyst) are complemented by new roles that support students’ interaction with multimodal texts that entail 21st century reading practices (Navigator, Interpreter, Designer, Interrogator).

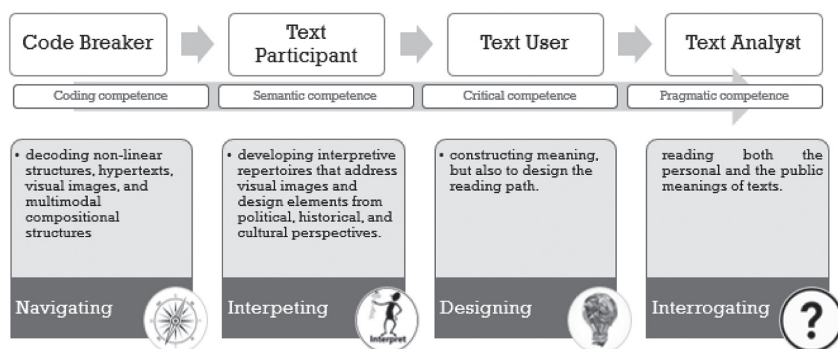


Figure 1. Revised Four Resources Model (Adapted from Luke and Freebody, 1999 and Serafini, 2012)

With a view to the implementation of affective literacy practices through cinema, each of the roles in the resulting model needs to be expanded through the incorporation of a series of affective strategies such as the following:

- **Inferring** takes place when students “think about and search the text, and sometimes use personal knowledge to construct meaning beyond what is literally stated” (WECB, 2006-2013). Students’ feelings are thus involved as they are asked to make inferences based on their prior knowledge of the world and their personal observations.

When working with filmic texts, inferring involves exploring the message of the movie, its plot and its main characters through static pictures or mute videos as well as identifying the feelings and emotions behind them.

- **Visualizing** is of special importance when working with video soundtracks as students need to use all of their other senses to supplement the lack of visual information. This occurs when students “create images in their minds that reflect or represent the ideas of the text. These images may include any of the five senses and serve to enhance understanding of the text” (WESB, 2006-2013). This means, students explore the movie’s dialogues, music and soundtrack with all the senses to recreate feelings and emotions.
- **Making connections** is a core literacy skill that is required “to visualize, infer, synthesize and question, especially at a deeper level” (Chambers & Radbourne, 2015). In terms of affective literacy development, this allows students to explore their own feelings and relate video texts to their own experiences. Students “relate what they read to personal experiences (text-to-self), to information from other texts (text-to text), and to information about the world (text-to-world) in order to enhance understanding of self, text, and life” (WESB, 2006-2013).

The development of this affective skill entails the students’ examination of their own emotional experiences in relation to the emotional experiences of the movie characters.

- **Questioning** is an essential skill for the deep comprehension of texts that consists in generating questions about the text and the author’s intentions before, during, and after reading and looking for information to clarify and extend knowledge (Hassett, 2008). This skill is crucial in the case of video texts as it gives teachers the opportunity to work with a wide range of filmic elements such as shots, sound effects or music as well as the effect that these have on students’ feelings and emotions.
- **Synthesizing** takes place when students “create original insights, perspectives and understandings by reflecting on text(s) and merging elements from texts and existing schema” (WESB, 2006-2013). Synthe-

tizing inevitably involves the use of complex judgmental skills such as critical thinking and problem solving to analyze the way students are moved towards emotions such as empathy. When applied to filmic texts, synthesizing becomes of outmost importance to provide the opportunity for students to examine the role of filmic elements in a broader social context and increase their perception of feelings and emotions conveyed by a movie.

Figure 2 describes our framework for the implementation of affective literacy practices through cinema. As mentioned above, affective skills have been added to complete each of the roles in the resulting model.

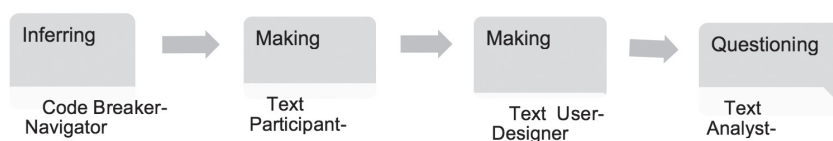


Figure 2. Framework for the implementation of affective literacy practices through cinema.

TOWARDS THE IMPLEMENTATION OF AFFECTIVE LITERACY PRACTICES THROUGH CINEMA IN THE EFL/ESL CLASSROOM

Our responsiveness to the suffering of others is conditioned by how their lives are presented to us (Buttler, 2010). In this vein, cinema is an extremely powerful vehicle to cut through the fences of ideology as it brings us into an empathic communion with the characters onscreen (Kozloff, 2013). We metaphorically step into someone else's shoes, drawing into the inner world of our hero (Vendrell, 2014).

On this basis, we have selected one of the best known scenes of *English Vinglish* (2012) to illustrate our framework. *English Vinglish* (2012) is an Indian comedy-drama film that revolves around a new language-based caste system which is affecting society in India and the world nowadays. The movie addresses the vast majority of world citizens who do not have English as their first language and suffer discrimination on the basis of language, gender or race. Shashi, the female character of the movie, is struggling to overcome an inferior complex for not speaking English as a lingua franca. Besides, the movie provides a powerful voice to the female empowerment movement through Shashi, the main character of the movie, who is struggling for a new life.

The scene in question describes an incident at the coffee shop in New York city where Shashi tries to order a coffee and a sandwich unsuccessfully. Unable to speak fluent English, she is abused by a waitress and leaves the coffee shop tearfully. The following lines provide one example of implementation of the model based on the scene described (Sridevi Classics HD, 2016). The full description of the didactic proposal can be found in the following link <https://youtu.be/enVzpsagLCo>

1) STEP 1 – CODE BREAKING / NAVIGATION

RESOURCE	ACTIVITY DESCRIPTION	AFFECTIVE LITERACY SKILLS
POSTER	Students look at the poster of the movie and answer the following questions: What do you think the movie is going to be about? What makes you think so? What do you think about the title of the movie?	INFERRING
PICTURE OF THE MAIN CHARACTER	Look at this picture of the main character of the movie: Who is she? Where is she from? What kind of person do you think she is? What are her feelings right now? What is her story?	INFERRING
MUTE VIDEO	Watch this mute version of a video scene and answer the following questions: What is happening in the scene? How do the main character's feelings change throughout the scene? What issues are addressed in the scene? What kind of music/sound effects do you expect to hear in this video?	INFERRING/ VISUALIZING

2) STEP 2 – TEXT PARTICIPATION / INTERPRETATION

RESOURCE	ACTIVITY DESCRIPTION	AFFECTIVE LITERACY SKILLS
VIDEO	Students watch the scene with audio and check their predictions: Have you managed to identify the main character's feelings? What makes her feel so? Also, check your predictions regarding issues addressed, music and sound effects used in the video. Is this story feasible? Justify your answer.	MAKING CONNECTIONS
REMARKS ON THE MOVIE	Read the following remarks on the movie and answer the questions: Do you agree with these statements? Do you think that human emotions and feelings are universal? <i>"I just wanted to make an authentic film. We're all the same. We may talk different, look different, live in different places but human emotion is the same. Our insecurities and fears are all similar."</i> <i>"Even in the U.S. a lot of people are not born or brought up in the U.S. A lot of them are immigrants, Spanish people, they face the same thing. It is a universal issue."</i> Gauri Shinde, <i>English Vinglish</i> film director.	MAKING CONNECTIONS
FILM REVIEW	Read the information about the movie and answer the question below: <i>English Vinglish. Shashi is a middle-class Indian housewife who is mocked by her family members for not being able to speak English fluently. She travels to New York for her niece's wedding and struggles to learn English.</i> Could you identify yourself with the main character? If so, think of any similar situations you have gone through when visiting new countries without speaking their language.	MAKING CONNECTIONS

3) STEP 3 – TEXT USE / DESIGN

RESOURCE	ACTIVITY DESCRIPTION	AFFECTIVE LITERACY SKILLS
NEWSPAPER QUOTE	Have a look at the following data and see how it is related to the message of the movie. <i>If you thought that India is rapidly progressing on the path of women empowerment changing its perceptions towards gender quality, a major survey has revealed some sobering statistics. The vast majority of Indians (64%) are of the view that the role of women in society is to become good mothers and wives and they should focus mainly on home. The Huffington Post, 22 May 2017.</i>	MAKING CONNECTIONS
VIDEO	Discuss the following questions: What do you think is the film creators' point of view towards the issues discussed in the movie? What is the message conveyed in this movie? How do you know? Why?	QUESTIONING SYNTHESIZING

4) STEP 4 – TEXT ANALYSIS / INTERROGATION

RESOURCE	ACTIVITY DESCRIPTION	AFFECTIVE LITERACY SKILLS
VIDEO	How does the film director enhance empathy towards the characters? Analyse the following filming elements: camera shots, sound, music, dialogue, costumes, lightening, etc.	QUESTIONING SYNTHESISING
VIDEO FILM SHOTS	Consider the combination of different shots (close-up, medium and long) used throughout the scene. How does the film operator use them to express ideas and emotions? What kind of shots prevail in the video? Are there any cut shots or dissolve shots? What is their function?	QUESTIONING SYNTHESISING

VIDEO MUSIC	Listen to the music accompanying the scene. In which way does it contribute to creating empathy towards the main character?	VISUALISING QUESTIONING SYNTHESISING
VIDEO CLOTHING	What does clothing tell us about the main character?	QUESTIONING SYNTHESISING
VIDEO DIALOGUE	Listen to the following dialogue taken from the video. What does it tell us about the characters? How does it increase your empathy towards the main character's situation?	VISUALISING QUESTIONING SYNTHESISING

CONCLUSIONS

The benefits of integrating affective literacy practices into critical literacy-based language teaching are evident. On articulating this view, the present paper has explored a wide range of perspectives underpinning the advantages of teaching critical literacy based on affective literacy skills and has developed a framework for the implementation of affective literacy practices through cinema in a context of critical pedagogy in the EFL/ESL classroom. Especial emphasis has been put on working with movie scenes since cinema has been proved to be an extremely powerful resource to bring out our feelings and emotions thus to increase our levels of empathy.

To illustrate our model, we have developed a series of activities based on a well-known scene from the Indian comedy-drama *English Vinglish* (2012). This experience is expected to be of great help for those researchers and language teachers willing to incorporate affective literacy practices into their classrooms. The ultimate goal is to increase language learners' empathy towards language, gender and race discrimination in the light of the latest efforts of Unesco to introduce alternative pedagogical practices in support of a Global Citizenship Education which aims at building fair, tolerant and inclusive societies (Global citizenship education: preparing learners for the challenges of the 21st century, 2014).

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GRAMMAR TEACHING APPROACHES FOR THE EFL CLASSROOM

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Abstract

Grammar teaching has always been a controversial topic. Hence several teaching approaches and methods have been developed through the decades. This chapter aims to discuss Focus on Form as an effective approach to grammar teaching within communicative language teaching. It intends to provide a basis for the implementation of Focus on Form strategies in Chilean classrooms, as well as to discuss the main benefits that this type of grammar teaching approach brings, not only for students, but also for teachers. Finally, some of the challenges that the implementation of Focus on Form poses for teachers will be presented.

Keywords: focus on form, grammar, grammar teaching approaches, communicative language teaching, english as a foreign language

Resumen

La enseñanza de la gramática siempre ha sido un tema controversial. Por esta razón, gran cantidad de métodos y enfoques han sido desarrollados a través de las décadas. Este capítulo tiene la finalidad de discutir el Foco en la Forma como un enfoque efectivo para la enseñanza de la gramática, dentro de la enseñanza comunicativa de la lengua. El capítulo pretende dar razones para

la implementación de estrategias de Focalización en la Forma en las aulas chilenas, junto con discutir los principales beneficios que brinda este tipo de instrucción, no solo a los estudiantes, sino también a los profesores. Finalmente, se presentarán algunos de los desafíos que se enfrentan en la implementación de este tipo de metodología.

Palabras clave: focalización en la forma, gramática, enfoques de enseñanza de gramática, enseñanza comunicativa de lenguas, inglés como lengua extranjera

INTRODUCTION

Teaching and learning English as a foreign language is a challenging process, not only for students, but also for teachers, who need to provide their students with the necessary tools to develop their communicative competence. One of the most controversial aspects within the communicative competence is grammar. For decades, teachers have been trying to innovate and apply new methodologies in their classrooms with the aim of finding the most appropriate approach or method for the students to be able to learn grammar better. Despite the enormous amount of studies carried out in the field, there is not one right answer. There is a wide range of approaches that can be used depending on various factors, such as the age of the students, level of proficiency, and purpose for learning English, among others.

In this chapter, I will mention some of the different methodologies and approaches to grammar teaching that exist, as well as discuss criteria for selecting an approach, based on the different characteristics of the classes. Furthermore, I will discuss the approach that I believe to be the most appropriate for current Chilean classrooms: Focus on Form. Finally, challenges for implementing Focus on Form will be presented.

APPROACHES TO GRAMMAR TEACHING

Throughout the years, several approaches to language teaching have appeared. In the nineteenth century, language teaching was based on the grammar translation method, in which, as the name suggests, translating texts was the main aim, completely ignoring communication. Later, in the twentieth century, the direct method appeared. The main focus of this method was on speaking and phonetics. Later in that century the reading approach appeared, which intended students to learn the language by reading. As time passed and language teaching developed as a result of research and theory development

(Ellis, 2016), approaches and methods also evolved. While in the nineteenth century the language seemed to be the goal itself, nowadays, we are on an opposite side of the continuum, in which the main aim for language teaching and learning is communication. That is to say, language is a tool for communication, not a goal in and of itself.

There are some approaches that consider communication the main goal in language learning, the communicative approach being the most renowned of them. The communicative approach has proven to be highly motivating for students, since it encourages them to perform actions with the language. However, the communicative approach focuses on the students' ability to communicate rather than on their accuracy. This represents a problem, at least in the Chilean context, given that when students are assessed, accuracy is one of the main criteria in most rubrics and tests.

Nonetheless, there is an approach that allows learners to combine meaning and accuracy in order to discover grammar through real life interaction, rather than memorizing rules (Macías, 2011). Focus on Form is an integrating approach, in which both communication and meaning are essential for learning. It was first introduced by Long (1988), who described it as a means of drawing students' attention to form while completing a communicative task. Even though in Long's description Focus on Form is motivated by students needs or requests, it has changed remarkably since then (Ellis, 2016). Doughty (2001) mentions that there are different types of Focus on Form, such as simultaneous processing, Focus on Form in advance, shifts of attention, and immediately contingent Focus on Form. All of these types of Focus on Form help the students reach their goal of communicating in the target language, keeping in mind the relevance of linguistic forms (Macías, 2011).

How do we choose an approach?

There are many factors that teachers need to consider when choosing an approach for grammar teaching. As Macías (2011) states, the teachers' knowledge about the students, the context, the types of errors, and the corrections needed are key to deciding which approach is the most suitable. Nevertheless, there are some other aspects that need to be considered as well, such as the age of the learners, the context in which the language is learnt, the type of assessment the students receive and the purposes for learning the language. Given the context in which English is taught in Chile, it is possible to say that Focus on Form could be a very effective approach to grammar teaching in Chilean classrooms, since English is expected to be taught as a tool for communication rather than as an objective in itself (Ellis, 2015).

Focus on form

English is taught as a foreign language in Chile, since it is not a local medium of communication. Thus, students do not have an immersion environment outside the classroom. Rahimpour, Salimi & Farrokhi (2012) mention that in the context of EFL one of the most suitable approaches to grammar teaching is Focus on Form, since it helps develop high levels of accuracy in the students, always keeping communication as the main goal of the interaction or task. Moreover, Littlewood (2007) explains that Focus on Form is necessary in EFL classrooms, since explicit language teaching is expected.

According to the Chilean Ministry of Education, English language teaching in the classrooms must be communicative. Hence, Focus on Form would be especially adequate, since it allows to direct students' attention to meaning while providing periodic attention to form (Ellis 2016), which results in higher levels of accuracy in the students. Moreover, Focus on Form is an approach that results in richer kinds of interaction in the classroom, which, according to Ellis (2016), benefits incidental acquisition. According to Shintani (2015) incidental grammar acquisition occurs when students' attention is directed to grammatical forms within a functional need. In other words, Focus on Form allows the students to achieve a communicative outcome at the same time that a linguistic feature is taught.

The objectives for learning the language are also key in selecting an approach. For instance, there are different goals when one learns a language to be able to go on vacation versus learning it as an expert. In this regard, Tütüniş (2012) points out that teachers of English need to develop their declarative knowledge about the language, that is to say, they need to know the characteristics of the linguistic code. That is also the case with students of English for Academic Purposes. According to Burgess & Etherington (2002), Focus on Form is particularly suitable in said cases, since EAP requires the student to develop high levels of accuracy, as well as communicative efficiency. On the other hand, students at schools may not need that kind of knowledge, if their aim is mainly to be able to communicate.

Another key factor for choosing an approach is age or proficiency level. Gallup (2009) discusses the effectiveness of Focus on Form in learners from different age groups. According to the author, Focus on Form is not effective in students with a low level of proficiency, since it is only advisable to focus on the formal characteristics of the language once the learners have acquired the basic structures of the language and the ability to communicate.

Challenges for implementation

The effectiveness and benefits of Focus on Form have been amply discussed and researched by several authors. However, the implementation of

this approach also presents some challenges, especially if we think about the Chilean context, in which sometimes classes have an average of 45 students and there are just a few hours dedicated to English teaching. According to Gallup (2009), in this type of classroom, it is especially difficult to implement Focus on Form, since the tremendous number of students in the classroom does not allow for individual feedback, which is crucial for effective Focus on Form. Another challenge rooted in the same issue is the type of interaction needed for successful Focus on Form. Nassaji (2013) states that the effectiveness of Focus on Form may vary according to the participation structure in the classroom. For instance, when the classroom setting allows for small group discussion, Focus on Form has a stronger effect. On the other hand, when the class is mainly set up for whole group discussion, Focus on Form may not be completely efficient.

Another challenge for Chilean teachers of English is the amount of language exposure that students get outside the classroom. According to Fotos (2002), one of the key factors in the success of Focus on Form is that the students need to have not only plenty of communicative opportunities inside the classroom, but also fair amounts of exposure outside the classroom. However, that does not commonly happen in the Chilean context, since Chile does not have many English speakers who the students can turn to in order to get input.

Finally, the type of instruction that the students are used to can also influence the effectiveness of Focus on Form. In 2007, Littlewood studied Focus on Form in an East Asian classroom. The results of his study showed that Focus on Form was ill-suited for cultures of teaching that are different from western settings. According to Littlewood (2014), a communicative or task-based approach may be seen as culturally inappropriate in contexts in which education is conceived as a process of accumulating knowledge rather than a process of using knowledge for immediate purposes.

CONCLUSIONS

In this chapter I have argued that there is a wide range of approaches and methods for grammar teaching. However, there is not a magical approach that is suitable and effective for every single classroom. In order to choose the right approach, teachers and educators need to consider various aspects, such as the age of the students, their level of proficiency, their linguistic needs, the classroom setting, and the context in which the language is learnt. Considering all these elements, Focus on Form arises as an effective alternative to grammar teaching, since, as the Chilean Ministry of Education suggests, it allows communicative language learning, as well as accuracy.

The positive effects of Focus on Form in EFL instruction have been amply discussed for decades. Ellis (2015) argues that in this type of instruction, Focus on Form is necessary, since learners are expected to reach not only com-

municative goals, but also linguistic accuracy. Similarly, Ellis (2016) explains that the remedial nature of Focus on Form makes it efficient, since it arises in response to the learners' needs or requests. Likewise, Fordyce (2013) explains that Focus on Form is effective not only in the short-term, but also in the long-term, which is a sign that the knowledge gained by the learners is meaningful. Even when Focus on Form has proven to be effective, there are certain aspects that can negatively influence its effectiveness, such as the number of students per classroom, the level of proficiency of the students and exposure to the language that the learners receive outside the classroom. Nevertheless, there are things that teachers can do in order to cope with the challenges mentioned, for instance having different participation structures throughout the lesson, and giving the students plenty of communicative opportunities inside the classroom.

All things considered, teachers' awareness of Focus on Form strategies should be raised in English Language Teaching programmes, since they constitute a crucial element of communicative language teaching (Ellis, 2015). Teachers need to be informed of the various ways in which Focus on Form can be implemented, and drawing the learners' attention to form should not be overlooked if the aim is for them to be able to be effective users of the language they are learning (Macías 2011). Let us not forget that learners expect not to learn about the language, but to learn how to actually communicate by using the language, and in this endeavour, Focus on Form represents a valuable and effective tool.

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WILLINGNESS TO COMMUNICATE WHEN SPEAKING ENGLISH

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Abstract

This paper reflects on three key factors that can help learners of a foreign language gradually develop their language proficiency. The speaking skill, classroom interaction and willingness to communicate are all variables that can either foster or hinder learners' language development because learning English does not only involve cognitive processes, but also affective and social domains that have a lot to say when addressing foreign language learning. This essay will approach speaking, classroom interaction and willingness to communicate as three constructs that need further attention in language teaching and research.

Keywords: speaking, classroom interaction, willingness to communicate

Resumen

Este trabajo reflexiona sobre tres factores clave que pueden ayudar a los estudiantes de una lengua extranjera en el desarrollo de su dominio lingüístico.

La expresión oral, la interacción en el aula y la disposición a comunicarse son tres variables que pueden favorecer o entorpecer el desarrollo lingüístico de los estudiantes, puesto que el aprendizaje del inglés no solo involucra procesos de tipo cognitivo, sino que también a los dominios afectivo y social que tienen mucho que decir sobre el aprendizaje de una lengua extranjera. Este ensayo aborda la expresión oral, la interacción en el aula y la disposición a comunicarse como tres constructos que requieren atención adicional en la enseñanza e investigación de lenguas.

Palabras clave: expresión oral, interacción en el aula, disposición a comunicarse

INTRODUCTION

According to the *Education First* (EF) study, which tested the English skills of people in the year 2016, Chile shows a low level of proficiency in the language (Education First, 2017), in spite of the fact that English has taken a key role in global communication. One common aspect teachers tend to focus on is language proficiency. However, as Pappamihel (2002) states, we must not overlook the fact that students can feel anxious or nervous in the classroom when they have to use a foreign language. This is a familiar situation we experience in Chilean classrooms, when we see our students interacting; they use Spanish instead of English. This could indicate that students' language use can be affected by factors that are beyond their English command. In this sense, classroom environments can present an answer to this problem.

If our expected outcome is to have students who can really speak the English language, teachers must encourage the participation of all learners in the classroom. They must not only allow the most proficient students to participate, but also the least proficient ones should have the same number of opportunities to use the language in different social and academic contexts. Mohr and Mohr (2007) point out that first language learning is driven by a natural motivation to socialize, whereas second language learning is motivated by a more "extrinsic influence" (p. 440), such as the learners' interest, their proficiency, and the environment in which they learn.

Speaking as a key skill

Speaking is one of the basic four skills of the language and has also been defined as a productive skill, which is key in the pursuit of effective communication (Boonkit, 2010). Speaking has been referred as a "social skill" (Rochmahwati, 2016, p. 202) because it implies more than one person interacting when getting messages across. Speaking involves building and sharing

meaning through verbal and non-verbal symbols (Lin, 2017).

Unfortunately, some teachers tend to teach speaking by having students drill and repeat dialogues or by memorizing oral presentations. Today's world requires students to express themselves by following certain social and cultural rules and, thus, it is important to improve their communicative skills. These skills can be developed when learners participate in real-life situations, using authentic and meaningful tasks, particularly when students collaborate in groups to achieve a goal. It is then essential to create an environment where speaking comes out naturally and authentic interaction can take place.

Rochmahwati (2016) states that for a speaking lesson to be successful, students must have the same number of opportunities to speak, and tasks must be motivating so that students can feel interested in class. As teachers, we have to make sure we provide students with plenty of tasks to use the language. As Richards & Renandya (2008) claim, teachers are responsible for creating opportunities to speak. Whether the focus is on accuracy or fluency, we must set clear goals for our students to feel comfortable enough to use the language.

Classroom interaction

Classroom interaction has been studied for decades and has been defined as “the interaction between the teacher and learners, and amongst the learners, in the classroom” (Tsui, 2001, p. 120). Different studies have shown that there are several factors that influence classroom interaction, such as the teachers and students' language used in the classrooms, their beliefs, and their social and cultural background. The first research studies attempted to describe the interaction based on the language the teacher used in terms of the questions they asked learners and how they elicited the answers together with the feedback the teacher gave. More recent studies focused on the language the students use, their strategies to communicate, the relation between the different tasks and how students negotiate meaning. Collier (2016) proposed *The Classroom Language Interaction Checklist* (CLIC), which measures and compares the level of classroom language a student uses in English and in their native language. The CLIC is regarded as “a scale of social language and academic language in the classroom collected through observation of student interaction in both English and another language” (Collier, 2016, p. 4), and it has two sections. The first section is related to social language interaction and the second section is related to academic language interaction. The first one focuses on interpersonal communicative skills and it can be used inside or outside the classroom, whereas the second one focuses on cognitive academic language interaction such as “language learned through academic, structured school interactions with teacher and peers” (Collier, 2016, p. 8) and it derives mainly from what is observed inside the classroom.

Some of the behaviors that are expected to occur when a student who is

learning a second language interacts, are:

- “-follows specific directions for academic task,
- generates simple sentences,
- asks for clarification during academic tasks,
- asks/answers specific questions regarding topics,
- can communicate thoughts,
- and initiates writing activities” (Collier, 2016, pp. 9-11).

The scale has a total of fifty-five items to be checked, and depending on the number of items revised, the scores will indicate where the student stands in the language development stage. Thus, a student can be in the following stages: pre-production, early production, speech emergence, intermediate fluency, advanced intermediate, or advanced fluency. Regardless of the students' language stage, they will be able to participate in the lesson as long as the teacher adapts the tasks, the instructions and the learning environment. Collier (2016) suggested several strategies for the different stages such as: demonstration, modeling, *Total Physical Response* (pre-production); consistent sequence, guided practice, video tapes (early production); context embedding, peer tutors, role plays (speech emergence); guided reading, guided writing, language games, oral discussions (intermediate fluency); advanced organizers, language games, oral discussions (advanced intermediate); and advanced organizers, peer tutors, cognitive strategies, guided reading, guided writing (advanced fluency).

Students' willingness to communicate

Willingness to communicate (WTC) was first introduced to literature in the 1980s by McCroskey and Richmond (1987), referring to it as a personality trait. However, the concept was later associated to situational variables when it was first applied to the second language acquisition context by MacIntyre in the 1990s. Thus, it was later defined as “the probability of engaging in communication when free to choose to do so...the intention to initiate communication, given a choice...a readiness to enter into discourse at a particular time with a specific person or persons, using an L2” (MacIntyre, Clément, Dörnyei & Noels 1998, p. 546). Simić (2014) proposed some factors that can influence students' WTC: classroom atmosphere, group work, wish to practice speaking, interest in the topic, among others. Not only is a student's decision to speak influenced by his/her personality characteristics, but by other factors leading to the conclusion that “WTC influences language use and use is an important predictor of language vitality” (MacIntyre, 2007, p. 11). Farouk (2016) defined WTC as “a concept that focuses on how language learners will utilize any opportunities to communicate in a second or foreign language” (p. 11). Since

learning highly depends on social interaction, then it is only natural to expect students to want to communicate in the target language. Therefore, there is a strong connection between anxiety, communication and learning, because, the more one communicates, the more practice one has in talking and the more one learns (Yashima 2002).

There are several scales that are used to measure students' WTC. One of these is a questionnaire developed by MacIntyre (2007), which is made up of twenty-seven aspects both inside and outside the classroom based on the four skills of the language. McCroskey and Richmond (1987) also created a scale based on the assumption that learners' WTC could be influenced by different external aspects. They developed a WTC scale that mixed "three common types of receivers with four common communication contexts" (Lin, 2017, p. 3). MacIntyre et al. (1998) also proposed a model that helped to understand the importance of the learners' WTC.

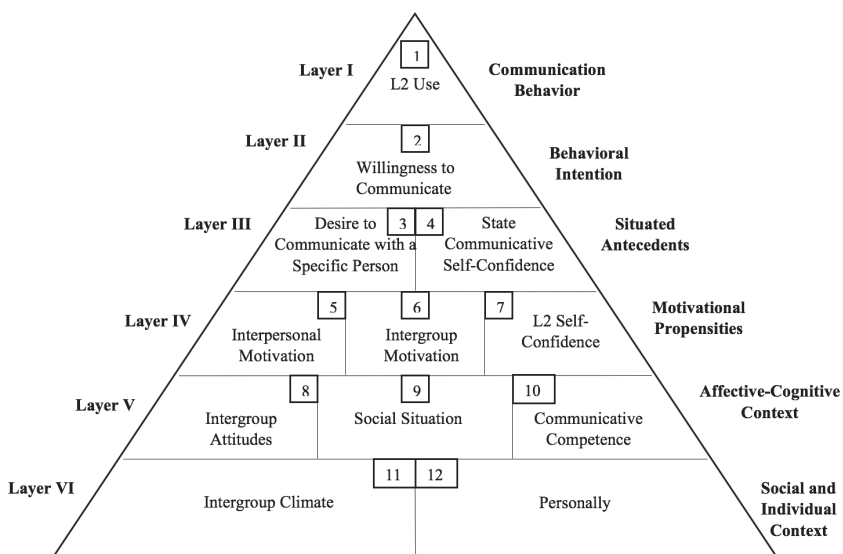


Figure 1. Heuristic model of variables influencing WTC (MacIntyre et al, 1998, p. 547)

The first three layers of the model represent more situation-specific factors that influence communication in an L2. The next three layers represent more stable and long-lasting factors. If we analyze the pyramid from the top, we can see clearly that the most immediate factor that influences communication in an L2 is WTC, hence, the importance of developing it in our students.

Regarding empirical studies, Farouck (2016) carried out a study on university students of an EFL course. One of the purposes of the study was to establish the effect of a project-based learning model on students' WTC. These students interacted with their classmates and with contents as they were immersed in a Web 2.0 environment, by participating in communicative tasks, such as the presentation of projects. The findings showed that the students' levels of anxiety when communicating were reduced. The author indicated that "the opportunity to do interviews, presentations, and also answer questions in English reduced their anxiety and improved their WTC in English" (Farouck, 2016, p. 16). The study also concluded that project-based learning allowed an "amalgamation of learning methods to enable students to achieve their language goals" (p. 16), because it represented an alternative to more traditional learning methods.

Furthermore, a study conducted by Zare-Behtash and Sarlak (2017) demonstrated the effectiveness of using Project-based learning to promote learners' speaking ability. They proposed "that the best teaching method is one which helps language learners to speak more comprehensibly" (Zare-Behtash and Sarlak, 2017, p. 119). They also stated that project-based learning is a communicative approach that helps students improve speaking in terms of vocabulary, grammar, fluency, pronunciation, and organization. The aim of this study was to examine the influence of project-based learning on forty-five Iranian EFL beginner level students during thirteen weeks. The authors concluded that project-based learning "reinforced students to be more active" (Zare-Behtash and Sarlak, 2017, p. 129) and it gave learners various opportunities to practice speaking by allowing them to activate their knowledge in real life situations in a friendly environment.

CONCLUSIONS

Having students expose to specific oral tasks is paramount for the development of speaking. Students can certainly be willing to communicate in English when they have a clear aim in their task and when their task is specific and related to the topic. The fact that students can perceive that they use the language to orally communicate, can increase their motivation towards the lesson and the language itself, since there is a sense of task accomplishment when using the language. Students' confidence and self-esteem can increase too if they feel they can actually use the language in a meaningful way. This implies that as long as there are specific oral tasks, with a clear purpose, students will undoubtedly attempt to communicate in English.

Finally, it is important to get to know one's students to identify their needs to be able to take actions and improve our teaching practice for the benefit of all students. In this context, speaking, classroom interaction and willingness to communicate function as an intertwined pyramid that does not only

have cognitive roots, but it is also supported by affective and social layers that are essential for the learning of a foreign language.

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